



CITY: Pg 3

No knock visit, big red flags



NATION: Pg 5

'May 4 marks TMC's end', says PM



FILM: Pg 14

'Ranveer Singh doesn't see Dhurandhar as his film'

Voters power EVMs to historic highs

WEST BENGAL REGISTERS RECORD 92% TURNOUT IN PHASE-1; TAMIL NADU SEES HIGHEST EVER VOTING AT OVER 85%

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KOLKATA/ CHENNAI: Record voter participation marked the opening round of Assembly elections in West Bengal and Tamil Nadu on Thursday, with both states reporting their highest turnout figures since Independence, even as political accusations and disputes over electoral rolls shaped a charged electoral atmosphere.

West Bengal recorded a historic 92.35 per cent turnout across 152 constituencies in the first phase, setting the tone for what is emerging as a fiercely contested battle between the ruling Trinamool Congress and the Bharatiya Janata Party. In Tamil Nadu, polling for all 234 Assembly seats was conducted in a single phase, registering a record turnout of 85.14 per cent, surpassing previous benchmarks in the state.

Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar described the polling levels in both states as the highest ever since Independence, noting that the figures could rise further as final data is consolidated.

In West Bengal, long queues at polling stations, particularly in rural areas, reflected intense mobilisation efforts by rival parties. The Election Commission deployed around 2,450 central paramil-



Women show their identity cards as they queue to vote at a polling station during the Tamil Nadu Assembly elections, in Chennai, on Thursday PTI

TAKEAWAYS

- » Election Commission calls both states' turnout highest since Independence
- » Election Commission maintains voting was "largely peaceful" overall
- » Narendra Modi terms turnout an "overwhelming mandate for change"
- » Mamata Banerjee says early trends favour TMC victory
- » BJP and TMC offer sharply contrasting interpretations of high turnout
- » In 2021, TMC won 93 seats in these areas; BJP secured 59

Tamil Nadu	West Bengal (Phase-I)
234	152/294
4,023	1,478
5.73 crore	3.60 crore
75,064	44,376
85.14%	92.35%
Male: 83.57% Female: 85.76% Third gender: 60.49%	Male: 90.92% Female: 92.69% Third gender: 56.79%

COUNTING FOR ALL POLL-BOUND STATES SCHEDULED ON MAY 4



Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls, which led to the deletion of over 91 lakh names statewide.

Continued on P4

'Uninformed', in 'poor taste': India slams Trump over his 'hellhole' comment

India is a great country, says Trump after criticism

SIMONTINI BHATTACHARJEE

NEW DELHI: A controversy erupted on Thursday after Donald Trump reposted a podcast by American commentator Michael Savage that referred to India, China and other countries as "hellholes" while criticising US birthright citizenship laws. The post included claims that immigrants travel to the United States late in pregnancy so their children gain automatic citizenship. The remarks drew a sharp response from India, even as the US Embassy later issued a clarification quoting Trump separately describing India as "a great country" led by "a very good friend".

The comments came from Savage's podcast, where he argued against birthright citizenship, a policy that grants US citizenship to nearly anyone born on American soil. Trump shared both the transcript and video of the episode, which also criticised the American Civil Liberties Union, accusing it of backing policies that favour undocumented immigrants.

India reacted strongly to the repost. The government



KEY POINTS

- » India advises nationals not to travel to Iran by air or land
- » No clarity on when or where Trump made the positive statement

called the remarks "uninformed", "inappropriate", and in "poor taste". Randhir Jaiswal, spokesperson for the Ministry of External Affairs, said the comments do not reflect the reality of India-US ties, which are based on mutual respect and shared interests. He added that India had taken note of both the original remarks and the US Embassy's clarification.

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Quick News

INDIA EXTENDS AIRSPACE CLOSURE FOR PAK TILL MAY 24

NEW DELHI: India has prolonged its restriction on Pakistani aircraft using its airspace until May 24, extending a measure first imposed after the Pahalgam terror attack on April 22, 2025. The decision means the ban will remain in force for over a year.

A Notice to Airmen issued on Wednesday stated that Indian airspace remains unavailable to Pakistan-registered aircraft, including those operated, owned or leased by Pakistani airlines and military operators. The restriction is valid until 2359 hours UTC on May 23, corresponding to 0530 hours IST on May 24. **Continued on P4**

CBSE CLASS-10 SECOND BOARD EXAMS FROM MAY 15-21

NEW DELHI: The Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE) on Thursday released the schedule for the second round of Class 10 board examinations, set to take place from May 15 to May 21. According to the official datesheet, the cycle will open with mathematics papers, both standard and basic, on May 15. English (communicative) and English (language and literature) exams will follow on May 16, while science is scheduled for May 18.

May 19 will see multiple language and elective subjects, including Hindi, Urdu, Punjabi, Bangla, Tamil, Telugu, Marathi, Gujarati, along with foreign languages, home science and select vocational courses. Sanskrit, painting, information technology and artificial intelligence papers are planned for May 20, with social science concluding the exams on May 21. **Continued on P4**



India-Africa partnership will be message of stability in turbulent world
S Jaishankar

In today's paper

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30 mins of horror: Accused raped IRS officer's daughter in rooftop study, killed her & dragged body down stairs

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: A 19-year-old former domestic worker accused of raping a woman in Rajasthan's Alwar and, hours later, killing a 22-year-old woman in south Delhi, showed "no remorse" during interrogation, police said, as investigators pieced together a sequence of events that unfolded across two states within less than a day. The suspect, Rahul Meena, was arrested on Wednesday from a hotel in Dwarka and produced

CRIME TIMELINE

TUESDAY EVENING (ALWAR): Attends wedding with survivor's husband
TUESDAY NIGHT: Allegedly rapes woman; threatens her
LATE NIGHT: Leaves Alwar for Delhi (conflicting travel claims)
4:30 AM (DELHI): Reaches Kailash Hills, waits outside

6:49 AM: Enters house using spare key
6:50-7:00 AM: Confronts victim, demands money
MINUTES LATER: Attacks, strangles, sexually assaults
7:00-7:15 AM: Drags body, tries biometric lock, breaks it, steals cash/jewellery
BEFORE EXIT: Changes clothes
7:20 AM: Leaves house (CCTV)
Post-crime: Takes auto to Dwarka hotel

before a Saket court on Thursday, which granted Delhi Police four days of custody to reconstruct the

crime, verify forensic evidence and establish motive. The victim in Delhi, the daughter of an Indian

Revenue Service officer, was found dead at her home in Kailash Hills on Wednesday morning, with postmortem findings pointing to death by strangulation following a violent assault.

According to police officials, Meena had worked at the family's residence for about eight months before being dismissed roughly a month earlier over allegations of financial misconduct. Investigators said he was familiar with the layout of the house, including its multi-layered

Continued on P4

Two road accidents leave 19 dead: 8 in Uttarakhand gorge, 11 in UP highway blaze

MPOST BUREAU

NEW TEHRI/MIRZAPUR: At least 19 people lost their lives in two separate road accidents in northern India within 24 hours, with incidents reported from Uttarakhand's Tehri district and Uttar Pradesh's Mirzapur. The crashes, involving a vehicle plunging into a gorge and a fiery multi-vehicle collision on a highway, left several others injured and triggered rescue operations by police, disaster response teams and local residents. Authorities in both states have begun investigations even as chief ministers expressed grief and directed officials to assist



Wreckage of a utility pickup vehicle is seen after it fell into a deep gorge, in Chamba, Tehri, Uttarakhand, on Thursday PTI

victims and their families.

In Uttarakhand, eight people were killed and two injured when

a utility pickup vehicle veered off the road and fell nearly 300 metres into a gorge near Nail village on the Chamba-Koti Colony road in Tehri district on Thursday afternoon. The accident occurred around 2.15 pm as about 10 passengers were returning to Thyoldhar village in Ghansali after attending the last rites of 65-year-old Sampat Lal in Haridwar.

District Magistrate Nitika Khandelwal said the driver lost control of the vehicle, leading to the fall. Police received the alert through the Dial 112 emergency service and dispatched ambulances and rescue teams. **Continued on P4**

SCORCHING DAYS, RESTLESS NIGHTS PERSIST

Heatwave tightens grip across India

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Large parts of India continued to endure extreme weather on Thursday, April 23, as searing heat gripped the northern and eastern plains while thunderstorms and hail lashed several other regions, reflecting a sharp contrast in conditions across the country. Jharsuguda in Odisha emerged as the hottest location nationwide at 44.6 degrees Celsius, even as the India Meteorological Department (IMD) warned that the dual pattern of heatwaves and storm activity is likely to persist in the coming days.

In the national capital, residents faced the hottest day of the season so far, with Safdarjung recording a maximum tem-



PUNJAB AND HARYANA RECORDED TEMPERATURES 3 TO 4 DEGREES ABOVE NORMAL

perature of 41.7 degrees Celsius, about 4 degrees above normal. The Ridge station was the hottest in Delhi at 43 degrees Celsius, followed by Palam at 41.6 degrees Celsius, Lodhi Road at 41.4

degrees Celsius, and Ayanagar at 41.7 degrees Celsius. Night-time temperatures also remained elevated, with Safdarjung logging a minimum of 25.4 degrees Celsius, adding to discomfort levels.

An IMD official said heatwave conditions have not yet been officially declared for Delhi as criteria require at least two stations to meet thresholds for two consecutive days. **Continued on P4**

CLOSER LOOK

- » Jharsuguda in Odisha recorded the highest temperature at 44.6 degrees Celsius
- » Heatwave conditions prevailed in Gangetic West Bengal and Bihar
- » Delhi recorded its hottest day of the season at 41.7 degrees Celsius
- » Ridge station in Delhi peaked at 43 degrees Celsius
- » Night temperatures stayed above normal, offering little relief in north India
- » IMD said Delhi heatwave not yet declared due to unmet criteria

GENTLE BREEZE



A desert cooler is installed inside an enclosure to provide relief from heat to elephants during the summer season at Elephant Village, in Jaipur, Rajasthan, on Thursday PTI

Malegaon blasts case reached dead end: HC; raps NIA for overlooking evidence

Seven suspects across probes remain missing

MPOST BUREAU

MUMBAI: Nearly two decades after coordinated explosions tore through the town of Malegaon, killing 31 people and injuring more than 300, the 2006 blasts case now stands at a legal and investigative impasse, with courts acknowledging deep contradictions in the prosecution's narrative and no accused left to face trial. A recent ruling by the Bombay High Court has underscored the uncertainty, describing the case as having "reached a dead end" and raising questions that remain unresolved since the attacks on September 8, 2006.

In its order, a bench led by Chief Justice Shree Chandrashekhar and Justice Shyam Chandak discharged four men accused by the National Investigation Agency, ruling that there was insufficient material to proceed to trial. The court also criticised the agency for "completely ignoring" evidence gathered during earlier investigations, particularly those conducted by the Maharashtra Anti-Terrorism Squad.

The four accused, Rajendra Chaudhary, Dhan Singh, Manohar Ram Singh Narwaria and Lokesh Sharma, had been charged under provisions of the Indian Penal **Continued on P4**

ON THE RUN SINCE 1986

82-year-old arrested after 40 yrs in wife murder case

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a breakthrough in a four-decade-old murder case, the Delhi Police has arrested an 82-year-old man who had allegedly killed his wife in 1986 and been on the run since then, an official said on Thursday.

The accused, Chandra Shekhar Prasad, a native of Bihar's Nalanda, was apprehended from a factory store-room in Nangli Poona area of outer north Delhi, where he had been living under a false identity, he said.

The case dates back to October 19, 1986, when Prasad, then 40, allegedly murdered his wife at their Shakarpur residence in east Delhi by crushing her head with bricks over suspicion of an extramarital affair.

"During the incident, he and his accomplices also held a domestic help at gunpoint before fleeing the scene," he



said. An FIR under sections 302 (murder) and 34 (crime committed with common intention) of the IPC was registered at Shakarpur police station, but the accused evaded arrest and was declared an absconder by a court in 1987.

The officer said that a team has been tasked to solve all the unsolved murder cases, and during the study, the team got to know about this case, as the case remained unsolved for nearly 40 years due to a lack of leads and the absence of modern investigative tools at the

time. Police said tracing the accused posed significant challenges as there were no digital records, photographs, Aadhaar data or mobile trails from that era, and his age had advanced from around 40 at the time of the crime to about 82 now.

A team of the crime branch reopened the case and began tracking the accused through a mix of human intelligence and technical surveillance.

"Investigators found that his children were settled in Delhi and Bihar, and discreetly monitored suspected mobile numbers linked to the family. Field verification in Nalanda confirmed that Prasad was alive and occasionally visited during family or religious events," the officer said.

Police tracked him through surveillance and arrested him in Alipur on April 22. He confessed to the 1986 murder, citing a quarrel and fit of rage.

Delhi Police bust LPG black-marketing rackets; 16 nabbed, 241 cylinders seized

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police Crime Branch has busted two separate LPG cylinder black-marketing rackets operating in Mangolpuri and Jahangirpuri, arresting five accused and recovering 104 illegally hoarded cylinders.

Acting on a tip-off from an anonymous source, teams from Northern Range-I carried out coordinated raids, seizing 73 Bharat Gas and 31 Indane Gas cylinders. Authorities also recovered refilling equipment, digital weighing machines, and four vehicles used for transportation.

Police said the operation exposed serious violations of safety norms and the deliberate misuse of the LPG distribution system.

In Mangolpuri, the raid was conducted near Pankaj Gas Agency, where three accused—Santosh, Sachin Kumar, and Pramod Pal—were caught red-handed while illegally storing and refilling cylinders. Three vehicles, along with refilling



HIGHLIGHTS

» In a parallel op in Jahangirpuri, 2 accused, Mahesh Pal and Kishan Yadav, were held while unloading cylinders from a modified cycle rickshaw into a shop in Mahendra Park

» Officials from the Food and Supply Department assisted in the raid: Police

equipment and weighing machines, were seized from the site. Investigations revealed that the accused were delivery workers who diverted LPG cylinders instead of completing assigned deliveries.

In a parallel operation in Jahangirpuri, two accused, Mahesh Pal and Kishan Yadav, were apprehended while unloading cylinders from a modified cycle rickshaw into a shop in Mahendra Park. Offi-

cials from the Food and Supply Department assisted in the raid.

The duo allegedly hoarded LPG cylinders and sold them at inflated prices, posing significant risks in a residential area.

Police stated that the accused used unauthorised equipment to transfer gas from filled cylinders into empty ones for resale in the open market. Such illegal storage and refilling practices posed serious fire

and safety hazards, particularly in densely populated localities.

Two FIRs have been registered under relevant provisions of the Essential Commodities Act and the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita. Further investigation is underway. Officials said the crackdown dismantled organised black-market networks while also preventing potential accidents and strengthening enforcement of public safety regulations.

HC pulls up police over allegations of illegal detention

NEW DELHI: The Delhi High Court on Thursday came down heavily on the Delhi Police over allegations of illegal detention and custodial torture of several activists last month, stressing that due process of law must be followed irrespective of the seriousness of allegations.

A bench of Justices Navin Chawla and Ravinder Dubeja questioned the manner of arrests and warned that the matter could be referred to the CBI if proper action was not taken. "When someone makes an allegation, you will just pick them up? We are not going to allow this. Procedure prescribed by law must be followed," the court observed, adding that constitutional safeguards cannot be bypassed even in serious cases.

The court noted that allegations of torture were grave and said such methods could not be used during interrogation. It directed the Delhi Police to either take appropriate action or face escalation of the matter, including possible CBI involvement. The bench also expressed dissatisfaction with a sealed-cover report submitted by the police and ordered that the complete case file be produced on May 19.

The petitions relate to alleged illegal detention of activists picked up in March from outside Dayal Singh College and Vijay Nagar. The petitioners claim they were taken to an undisclosed location and subjected to custodial abuse.

The Delhi Police, however, denied all allegations, stating in its affidavit that the individuals were only called for lawful questioning in connection with an FIR linked to Maoist-related activities. It described the claims as false, exaggerated, and aimed at derailing an ongoing investigation. PII

NEW DELHI: A Delhi court on Wednesday directed the registration of a First Information Report (FIR) against Abhijit Iyer-Mitra over objectionable social media posts targeting Newsland's Manisha Pande and other journalists. The order was passed by Judicial Magistrate First Class Bhanu Pratap Singh of the Saket Court.

The court observed that Iyer-Mitra's posts contained sexually coloured remarks directed at Pande and others, and were prima facie intended to insult her, noting that she had been explicitly named in the tweets. It held that the content disclosed cognisable offences under Sections 75(3)

Pande, other journalists approached the court alleging that Iyer-Mitra repeatedly referred to them as prostitutes

and 79 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita (BNS).

Emphasising the need for a police probe, the court stated that the alleged offences were committed in cyberspace on the platform X (formerly Twitter). It directed investigators to verify the user account from which the posts originated and to trace and recover the electronic devices used. The court also found the Action Taken Report filed by PSI Ombir to be unsatisfactory, as it failed to consider the tweets in question.



Delhi Police will launch a week-long anti-drug awareness campaign, 'Nasha – Not Cool', from April 24, 2026, as part of the Centre's zero-tolerance policy on drugs. A rap-based theme song was unveiled by Commissioner Satish Golecha, with activities including school pledges, outreach programmes, and social media initiatives targeting youth awareness PIC/MPST

35-yr-old killed, wife and kids injured in Vikas Marg accident

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: A 35-year-old man was killed and three members of his family were injured after a car collided with their motorcycle on Vikas Marg in East Delhi in the early hours of Thursday, police said.

The incident came to light after a PCR call was received at Shakarpur Police Station at around 1:50 am, reporting a road accident on the stretch from ITO towards Laxmi Nagar. The caller informed police that the injured had already been shifted to Hedgewar Hospital and that the driver of the offending vehicle had been apprehended by

members of the public.

Police teams rushed to the spot and initiated an inquiry. According to the complainant, Anil Kumar, the accident occurred at approximately 1:30 am near Geeta Colony Cut, when a Maruti Celerio bearing a Delhi registration number allegedly rammed into a Passion motorcycle carrying four persons.

The victims were identified as Neeraj, his wife Sonam, and their two children. The family was returning to their home in Vishwas Nagar from Connaught Place when the collision took place.

All four sustained injuries and were taken to Hedgewar

Hospital for treatment. During medical examination, Neeraj, a resident of NSA Colony in Vishwas Nagar, was declared brought dead. His wife and two children are currently undergoing treatment, though their condition has not been officially disclosed.

The body has been shifted to the mortuary at LNJP Hospital for post-mortem examination. The accused driver, identified as Sachin Gulati (45), a resident of Sector-31, Noida, was caught at the scene by passersby and later handed over to the police. A case has been registered under relevant provisions of law, and further investigation is underway.

NOIDA TAKES STEP TOWARDS ZERO-WASTE CITY GOAL

Noida signs pact with IGL to set up 300 TPD compressed biogas plant

DIPIKA KIROLA

NOIDA: In a significant step towards sustainable waste management and clean energy generation, the Noida Authority on Wednesday signed a Letter of Intent (LoI) with Indraprastha Gas Limited (IGL) to set up a compressed biogas (CBG) plant with a capacity of 300 tonnes per day (TPD).

The agreement was formalised at the authority's office in the presence of Noida Authority CEO Krishna Karunesh and IGL's Executive Director (Business Development, Corporate Strategy and Gas Sourcing) Sanjeev Kumar Bhatia. Officials said the proj-

The proposed CBG plant will process organic waste generated across the city

ect will be developed in line with the Government of India's sustainability initiatives aimed at promoting eco-friendly and renewable energy solutions.

According to officials, the proposed CBG plant will process organic waste generated across the city to produce compressed biogas, which can be used as a clean alternative fuel, particularly for vehicles. In addition to biogas, the plant will also generate bio-manure as a valuable by-product, which can be used

in agriculture and landscaping. The project is expected to play a crucial role in reducing the burden on landfill sites, which have been a growing concern in urban areas. By diverting organic waste for processing, the initiative will help lower greenhouse gas emissions and improve overall environmental conditions. It will also promote the concept of a circular economy, where waste is converted into useful resources.

"This initiative is in line with our vision of making

Noida a sustainable and zero-waste city," Karunesh said, adding that the authority is committed to adopting innovative solutions for effective waste management. Under the agreement, the Noida Authority will provide suitable land for the plant and ensure a steady supply of segregated organic waste to maintain operations. IGL, on its part, will develop the project either independently or through its authorised partners, leveraging its experience in city gas distribution and clean energy infrastructure.

Bhatia said it would improve waste management and support renewable energy goals.

Live-in couple found dead in locked Gr Noida room

DIPIKA KIROLA

GREATER NOIDA: A sensational incident has emerged from Greater Noida, where the bodies of a live-in couple were recovered from a locked room in the Knowledge Park area, police said on Thursday.

The incident was reported from Tughlapur village under Knowledge Park police station limits after residents complained of a foul smell emanating from a rented accommodation. Suspecting something amiss, locals alerted the police. A team rushed to the spot and broke open the door, only to find the decomposed bodies of a man and a woman inside the room.

According to police, the man was found hanging from the ceiling fan, while the woman's body was lying on the floor. The deceased have been identified as Guddu Paswan alias Golu (27), a native of Deoria district, and his live-in partner Jyoti (24). The couple had been living together for nearly three years, posing as husband and wife. Preliminary investigation suggests a case of suspected murder followed by suicide. Officials said the condition of the bodies indicates that the deaths occurred around two days before they were discovered. Neighbours also confirmed that the couple had not been seen for the past couple of days.

Police sources said Jyoti worked in housekeeping at a private hospital but had not reported to work for nearly



KEY POINTS

» Preliminary investigation suggests a case of suspected murder followed by suicide

» Officials said condition of the bodies indicates that the deaths occurred 2 days before they were discovered

20 days. Guddu was reportedly unemployed, and frequent disputes over financial issues were common between the two. Investigators believe these factors may have contributed to the tragic incident. DCP Greater Noida Praveen Ranjan Singh said, "On receiving information through PRV about a suspected suicide in Tughlapur village, a police team reached the spot and broke open the locked room. The man was found hanging, while the woman was lying dead on the floor. The bodies have been sent for post-mortem, and all angles are being thoroughly investigated."

A forensic team inspected the scene and collected evidence. Police said further investigation is underway to ascertain the exact sequence of events.

HOSPITAL PULLED UP AS CM FINDS GAPS IN MEDICINES, CLEANLINES...

No knock visit, big red flags

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a stern message on accountability in public healthcare, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta conducted a surprise inspection of Aruna Asaf Ali Hospital, uncovering medicine shortages, long queues, and poor sanitation, and ordering immediate corrective action.

Arriving unannounced, the Chief Minister reviewed multiple departments including OPD, wards, pharmacy counters, sanitation, and digital services. She interacted directly with patients and attendants to gather first-hand feedback on the hospital's functioning.

During the visit, several elderly patients informed her that they had been waiting since early morning without being attended to. Taking serious note, Gupta termed the situation "completely unacceptable" and directed officials to ensure proper seating arrangements and introduce a streamlined token system to reduce waiting time. The inspection also highlighted gaps in doc-



tor availability, overcrowding in the OPD, and inefficiencies in the online appointment system. Despite digital booking facilities, patients continued to face long queues. The Chief Minister instructed authorities to better integrate online and offline systems for smoother patient flow.

A key concern raised by patients was the shortage of medicines, forcing many to purchase drugs from outside. Acting swiftly, Gupta ordered an immediate audit of stock

“If a medicine is needed today, it must be provided today — CM REKHA GUPTA

registers and announced a strict stance against shortages. "If a medicine is needed today, it must be provided today," she said, calling such lapses unacceptable.

Complaints regarding unhygienic conditions, water supply issues, and poorly maintained



toilets also drew sharp criticism from the Chief Minister. She warned officials that negligence in basic facilities would not be tolerated.

To address systemic issues, Gupta ordered administrative reforms, including mandatory biometric attendance for staff

and the use of nameplates to ensure accountability. She also raised concerns over increasing hepatitis cases and directed doctors to take preventive measures.

Reiterating the government's commitment to citizen-centric healthcare, Gupta said, "Hospitals are not just centres of treatment, but spaces of service, compassion and trust," adding that the administration is focused on delivering efficient, clean, and reliable healthcare services.

Delhi hits 57% desilting target

NEW DELHI: With the monsoon season approaching, the Delhi government has intensified flood prevention measures, with the Irrigation and Flood Control Department achieving over 57 per cent of its desilting target across major drains to curb waterlogging and urban flooding.

According to official data, desilting work across 76 drains has reached 57.68 per cent completion, with more than 16.48 lakh cubic metres of silt removed against a total target of 28.57 lakh cubic metres. The progress is particularly notable in 21 priority drains, where work has crossed 76 per cent, indicating near readiness ahead of the rains. The Najafgarh drain system, one of the city's most flood-prone areas, has recorded nearly 48 per cent completion, while the remaining 55 drains have achieved over 63 per cent progress. Officials said this year's approach focuses on simultaneous execution across zones, with vulnerable points identified from previous monsoons being prioritised.

Alongside desilting, the department is strengthening its machinery base through a Rs.94 crore procurement plan. A total of 38 specialised machines, including draglines, long-boom excavators, amphibious excavators and dredgers, are being deployed to improve efficiency, particularly in deep and waterlogged drains. So far, 12 machines have been procured, with additional orders placed.

Delhi Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh, who reviewed the preparedness, said, "Our priority is clear—before the monsoon arrives, every critical drain must be cleaned and functional. We are not leaving things for the last moment." He added, "The idea is to ensure that during heavy rainfall, water does not accumulate and disrupt daily life." Officials have also been directed to ensure proper disposal of silt and maintain real-time monitoring to complete the remaining work before peak monsoon. MPOST

BJP set for Mayor repeat in Capital

AAP abstains from nomination



Pravesh Wahi files papers for Delhi Mayor post

MPOST

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The BJP and the Indian National Congress on Thursday filed nominations for the posts of Mayor and Deputy Mayor in the Municipal Corporation of Delhi, while the Aam Aadmi Party for second year in a row stayed away from the contest for the top two positions.

Bharatiya Janata Party councillor Pravesh Wahi from Ward 53 (Rohini-East) — who is likely to win — filed his nomination for the Mayor's post, while Monika Pant, councillor from Ward 206 (Anand Vihar), was nominated for deputy mayor.

The electoral college for this year's mayoral election comprises 273 votes, including 249 councillors, 14 MLAs nominated by the Delhi Assembly, seven Lok Sabha MPs, and three Rajya Sabha members. A candidate will need 137 votes to secure victory.

Currently, the BJP has 123 councillors in the 250-member municipal council which tips the favour towards the incumbent party. AAP has 100, the Indraprastha Vikas Party has 15, the Congress has nine, and two are independents, while one seat is vacant. Going by current numbers, the BJP holds an edge with 141 votes, including 123 councillors, seven Lok Sabha MPs and 11 MLAs. The AAP has 106 votes, consisting of 100 councillors, three Rajya Sabha members and three MLAs.

On behalf of the Congress, councillor Zarif from Kabir Nagar Shahdara (Ward 234) filed his nomination for mayor, and Rajesh Kumar Gupta from Mubarakpur (Ward 39) for deputy mayor, officials said.

Sitting mayor Raja Iqbal Singh and Standing Committee chairperson Satya Sharma were present when BJP candi-

dates submitted their nomination papers.

For the standing committee, BJP nominated councillor Jai Bhagwan Yadav from Ward 27 (Begumpur) and councillor Manish Chaddha from Ward 82 (Paharganj). AAP's Jalaj Kumar, councillor from Shalimar Bagh-A (Ward 55), also filed nomination for a vacant seat on the panel. The 18 standing committee members are elected through a mixed process: 6 members are elected directly by the councillors in the MCD House, while 12 members are elected by the 12 municipal zone ward committees. Councillors and designated aldermen (nominated members) participate in the voting process.

The elections for the posts of mayor and deputy mayor are scheduled to be held during the MCD House meeting on April 29. Speaking after filing his nomination, Wahi said clearing garbage and improving civic infrastructure would be his priority. "Freeing Delhi from mountains of garbage will be our top priority. We will work to make roads pothole-free and ensure parks are green and well-maintained," he said. He added that coordination with the Delhi government would be key to improving sanitation and overall civic conditions in the city.

Monika Pant, nominated for the post of deputy mayor, said her nomination reflects the party's commitment towards women's representation.

"For us, 'Nari Shakti Vandana Adhiniyam' is not merely a slogan, but a pledge to secure women's rights," she said, adding that her candidature is part of that commitment.

Meanwhile, the AAP announced that Ankush Narang has been reappointed as the Leader of the Opposition in the MCD.

BJP MLA Anil Goyal selected for Assembly's 'Best MLA Award'

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a move aimed at recognising legislative excellence, the Delhi Legislative Assembly has announced Dr. Anil Goyal, MLA from Krishna Nagar, as the recipient of the "Annual Award for Best Legislator" of the Eighth Assembly, reviving the honour after an 18-year gap.

The decision was taken by a high-powered Selection Committee chaired by Speaker Vijender Gupta at the Vidhan Sabha. The award will be formally presented at a felicitation ceremony, along with a citation, memento, and a cash prize of Rs 51,000.

Officials said the award is based on a comprehensive 100-point evaluation system combining quantitative data and qualitative assessment. Of this, 65 points are derived from official Assembly records, while 35 points are awarded by the committee. A major component of the assessment, carrying

HIGHLIGHTS

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The award will be formally presented at a felicitation ceremony, along with a citation, memento, and a cash prize of Rs 51,000



50 points, focuses on contributions to House debates, including quality of arguments, awareness of issues, attendance, and legislative activity such as questions and notices. Another 30 points are linked to participation in House Committees, evaluating both attendance and quality of engagement.

The remaining 20 points assess conduct, discipline, and adoption of digital practices like the NeVA system. This includes adherence to House decorum and timely submission of notices.

Speaker Vijender Gupta said the initiative aims to restore a healthy parliamentary tradition and encourage higher standards among legislators. He noted that recognising meaningful debate, accountability, and active participation would help strengthen governance and public trust in democratic institutions.

The Assembly said the award sets a benchmark for performance and will motivate lawmakers to contribute more effectively to legislative functioning.

41.7°C and rising



A sambar deer drinks from a water sprinkler in its enclosure amid heat during the summer season, at the National Zoological Park, in New Delhi, Thursday

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: It was a scorching Thursday in the Capital, with residents reeling under intense heat as temperatures soared beyond 40 degrees Celsius, with the city's base station at Safdarjung recording the hottest day of the year so far as the mercury logged 41.7 degrees Celsius, 4 degrees above normal.

The spike in temperatures was felt across stations, with the Ridge emerging as the hottest at 43 degrees Celsius, 4.6 degrees above normal.

Meanwhile, Palam recorded 41.6 degrees Celsius (3 degrees above normal), Lodhi Road 41.4 degrees Celsius (4.4 degrees above normal), and Ayanagar 41.7 degrees Celsius (3.3 degrees above normal), underlining the widespread rise in day temperatures across the city.

Nights offered little relief as minimum temperatures also climbed, making it the warmest night spell of the season so far. Safdarjung recorded 25.4 degrees Celsius (2.3 degrees above normal) as the capital's minimum.

Meanwhile, minimum temperatures were logged at 25.6 degrees Celsius (2.3 degrees above normal) at Palam, 23

CAQM conducts inspection drive across key zones

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In its inspection of visible road-dust levels contributing to air pollution, the Commission for Air Quality Management in NCR and Adjoining Areas (CAQM) has found 34 violations on different road stretches in the region, officials said on Thursday.

The violations primarily pertain to high levels of visible road dust and the accumulation of construction and demolition waste at multiple locations across the inspected areas.

"The presence of such conditions indicates gaps in routine road sweeping, dust-mitigation measures and timely removal of waste, all of which are critical for abating localised sources of air pollution," an official said.

The inspection took place on Wednesday across three zones of the national capital — Civil Lines, Karol Bagh and West Delhi — falling under the Municipal Corporation of Delhi's (MCD) jurisdiction.

The CAQM directed the authorities concerned, particularly the MCD, to strengthen the on-ground implementation of dust-control measures.

The commission also asked authorities to ensure regular mechanised sweeping of roads, effective water sprinkling, prompt removal of construction and demolition waste and strict enforcement against unauthorised dumping.

"The CAQM has emphasised that road dust and improperly-managed construction and demolition waste are significant contributors to particulate pollution, especially in urban environments," the official said.

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: In a major push towards artificial intelligence-driven growth, the Delhi government will establish two AI Centres of Excellence (AI-CoEs) under the IndiaAI Mission to promote innovation, strengthen the startup ecosystem, and generate employment.

The initiative, led by the IT Department in collaboration with the Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY), Netaji Subhas University of Technology (NSUT), and GGSIPU, aims to position Delhi as a key hub for AI and emerging technologies. Each centre will be developed with a funding support of Rs 20 crore under a 40:40:20 model involving the Centre, Delhi Government, and industry or academic partners.

According to officials, the AI-CoEs are expected to support around 100 startups, train over 7,000 individuals, and generate more than 1,000 jobs over a four-year period. The centres

will focus on research, innovation, and scaling AI-based solutions while also strengthening digital governance.

IT Minister Dr Pankaj Kumar Singh said, "Delhi is taking a decisive leap into the future by investing in Artificial Intelligence for promoting innovation and economic growth. These AI Centres of Excellence will not only nurture cutting-edge research and startups but also ensure that technology meaningfully improves the lives of our citizens."

He further added, "Through this initiative, we aim to build a robust pipeline of skilled AI professionals while enabling startups and innovators to solve real-world challenges."

Officials said the centres will also focus on deploying AI-driven solutions in governance to enhance efficiency, transparency, and public service delivery, while building a future-ready workforce through training and capacity-building programmes.

Ring road project gathers pace

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Moving ahead with its road decongestion plan, the Delhi government is likely to carry out its elevated ring road project in six phases, connecting north and south Delhi, officials said on Thursday.

According to Public Works Department (PWD) minister Parvesh Sahib Singh, the detailed project (DPR) report for the ring road elevated corridor is completed.

"The consultants have submitted the DPR for the project and further examination is going on. We will take up the first phase from Mukarba Chowk to Ashram intersection. Later based on the ground inspections, further phases will be constructed," Singh said.

Last year in June, the government announced the project of a ring road over the existing ring road, for which six phases were planned at a staggering estimated cost of Rs 7,000 crore under the city's decongestion plan.

We will take up the first phase from Mukarba Chowk to Ashram intersection. Later based on the ground inspections, further phases will be constructed: Min

As per the plan, the initial phases, including Azadpur Flyover near Mukarba Chowk and the DND road, which further connects to the Ashram flyover, a critical arterial road in south Delhi.

"Spanning a total length of 55 km, the project aims to enhance connectivity, decongest major intersections, and promote sustainable urban transport through elevated corridors over the existing ring road," an official said.

The remaining phases, including DND Flyover to Moti Bagh Metro Station (10.5 km), Moti Bagh Metro Station-Rajouri Garden (10 km), and Rajouri Garden-Pacific Mall (Pitampura)-Azadpur Flyover (13.5 km), will be taken up later.

"These are heavily congested stretches, and in some roads our initial reports show residential properties and commercial establishments very close to the road, there will be some land acquisition issues in areas like Narela," the minister said.

After completion, the ele-

vated road will connect to the Azadpur flyover near Mukarba Chowk and the DND road, which further connects to the Ashram flyover, a critical arterial road in south Delhi.

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WITH FOCUS ON AWARENESS, ENFORCEMENT

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi government has stepped up efforts to reduce road accidents and promote safer mobility through a mix of awareness campaigns and stricter enforcement, under the "Aware Today, Responsible Always for a Safer, Greener Tomorrow" initiative.

Led by Transport Minister Dr Pankaj Kumar Singh, the Road Safety and Sustainable Mobility Initiative 2026 brought together key stakeholders including the Delhi Traffic Police, local represen-

“Our goal is clear: safer roads, reduced accidents, and cleaner air for every citizen — Transport Minister

tatives, and civic organisations to drive behavioural change on roads. The programme featured awareness drives for schoolchildren, free Pollution Under Control (PUC) check-ups, and nukkad natak aimed at educating citizens on traffic rules and responsible road use.

Highlighting the government's approach, Dr Singh said,

"Road safety is not a one-day campaign, it is a continuous commitment. Through initiatives like these, we are working to ensure that people not only understand traffic rules but follow them responsibly." He added, "Our goal is clear: safer roads, reduced accidents, and cleaner air for every citizen of Delhi."

Regularisation of properties in unauthorised colonies in Delhi to begin from April 24

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Residents of over 1,500 unauthorised colonies in the city will be able to apply online for registration of their properties through Swagam portal of the MCD from Friday, officials said.

The Centre earlier this month rolled out a new policy for the regularisation of unauthorised colonies in Delhi on "as is where is" basis.

According to the guidelines, the applicants will log on SWAGAM portal of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) for registration of their properties in the identified 1,521 unauthorised colonies.

The applications of property owners who have conveyance deeds (properties on government land) or authorisation slips (properties on private land) issued earlier by the Delhi Development Authority (DDA)

will apply for regularisation.

Those who do not have conveyance deeds or authorisation slips will be redirected to the PM-UDAY portal through which they will be issued these documents, the officials said.

Under the new policy, the power to issue conveyance deeds or authorisation slips has been transferred from the DDA to the Revenue Department of the Delhi government.

A Revenue Department officer said that dedicated cells under additional district magistrates (ADMs) are being formed for issuing conveyance deeds. The ADMs in the 13 districts will serve as nodal officers for the purpose.

The regularisation process will benefit over 10 lakh households in the 1,521 unauthorised colonies. The DDA earlier issued around 40,000 conveyance deeds and authorisation slips.

The minister emphasised the importance of early education in shaping responsible behaviour. "Students are the future of our nation. Educating them about road safety today will shape a more responsible generation tomorrow," he said, stressing the need to discourage underage driving.

He also underlined the role of community participation in ensuring long-term impact. "If our local representatives, MLAs, and NGOs come together to drive such campaigns, it will significantly enhance awareness and contribute to a reduction in accidents," he said.

On tackling drunken driving, Singh noted that a combination of enforcement and behavioural interventions has been adopted. He said sustained efforts have already led to a reduction in such incidents and expressed confidence that continued measures and public cooperation would further improve road safety outcomes.

The government reiterated its commitment to a multi-pronged strategy to ensure safer roads and better environmental outcomes.

INDIA-UK STRATEGIC DIALOGUE

NSA Doval holds wide-ranging talks with British counterpart

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: National Security Advisor Ajit Doval on Thursday held extensive talks with his British counterpart Jonathan Powell focusing on addressing New Delhi's concerns related to terrorism, extremism and pro-Khalistan elements operating from the UK. The two sides also agreed to further strengthen the India-UK Comprehensive Strategic Partnership against the backdrop of a "turbulent geopolitical environment", officials said.

NSA Doval and Powell also exchanged views on the volatile situation in West Asia and its impact on maritime security



National Security Advisor Ajit Doval meets his UK counterpart Jonathan Powell in New Delhi

PTI

and trade.

Doval highlighted that dialogue and diplomacy was the only way forward to resolve

the conflict, the officials said.

The talks were held under the framework of annual India-UK Strategic Dialogue.

HIGHLIGHTS

» The two sides also agreed to further strengthen the India-UK Comprehensive Strategic Partnership'

» Doval and Powell exchanged views on the volatile situation in West Asia and its impact on maritime security and trade

» Doval highlighted that dialogue and diplomacy was the only way forward to resolve the conflict

Document, including in technology, defence and security domains for enhancing long-term bilateral strategic cooperation, the officials cited above said.

Both sides noted the need to deepen cooperation to address security concerns related to terrorism, extremism and pro-Khalistan elements, they said.

NSA Doval thanked the UK government for the continued support on these matters and highlighted the need to maintain the momentum through further deepening cooperation between law enforcement agencies of the two sides, they added.

Rs 145 cr FD ‘fraud’: ED raids over 10 locations in Hry & Pb

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Enforcement Directorate Thursday said it has conducted searches at multiple locations in a money laundering case linked to an alleged Rs 145 crore fraud with the fixed deposits of Panchkula Municipal Corporation deposited in a Kotak Mahindra Bank branch in Haryana.

The raids undertaken on Wednesday covered a dozen locations in Chandigarh and Panchkula (Haryana), apart from Zirakpur, Dera Bassi and Rajpura (Patiala district) in Punjab. The ED case, filed under the provisions of the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), stems from an FIR registered in March by the Haryana Vigilance and Anti-Corruption Bureau (ACB) on charges of embezzlement of Panchkula Municipal Corpo-



ration's fixed deposits worth Rs 145 crore maintained at the Kotak Mahindra Bank branch at Sector-11 in Panchkula.

The premises of former Kotak Mahindra Bank deputy vice president Pushpender Singh, former customer relationship manager at the said branch Dileep Kumar Raghav, Vikas Kaushik, former senior accounts officer of the municipal corporation and some others were covered during the searches. The ED said in a statement it seized "incriminating"

documents during the raids.

Singh, Raghav and four others were arrested by the Haryana ACB as part of this investigation. The ED said it found a close "criminal nexus" of the municipal corporation and bank officials along with some private persons who hatched a conspiracy to siphon government funds.

Prima facie investigation finds that Raghav along with Singh, in support of Vikas Kaushik, opened two bank accounts through "forged" and "fake" authorisation documents in the name of the Panchkula Municipal Corporation.

The funds of the corporation available in genuine accounts were transferred to "unauthorised" accounts using forged and fake fund migration authorisation letters in the name of the municipal corporation, the ED said.

From Page 1

Voters power EVMs

The exercise has become a central political issue, influencing campaign narratives and voter sentiment. While the ruling party has alleged that the revision disproportionately affected vulnerable sections, the opposition has argued it helped ensure a cleaner electoral roll.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi termed the turnout an "overwhelming mandate for change" and claimed that May 4, when votes will be counted, would mark the end of what he described as a long-standing system under the ruling party. Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee said early polling trends indicated that her party was "already in a position to win", adding that the turnout reflected concerns among voters about retaining their rights.

The first phase assumes strategic importance for both sides. For the BJP, it includes key constituencies in north Bengal, a region central to its expansion plans. For the TMC, the focus is on maintaining its stronghold and countering the opposition's advances early in the contest. In the 2021 elections, the TMC had won 93 of these 152 seats, while the BJP secured 59.

In Tamil Nadu, polling proceeded largely without major disruptions, though scattered incidents of clashes and localised boycotts were reported. The contest in the state is primarily between the ruling Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam and the opposition All India Anna Dravida Munnetra Kazhagam, alongside emerging players such as actor-politician Joseph Vijay's party and Seeman's Naam Tamilar Katchi.

Chief Minister M. K. Stalin expressed confidence in retaining power, stating that the electorate had voted to uphold democratic and constitutional values. AIADMK leader Edappadi K. Palaniswami also projected optimism about returning to office after five years.

Out of approximately 5.73 crore eligible voters in Tamil Nadu, about 4.87 crore cast their ballots. District-level data showed variation, with Karur recording the highest turnout at 91.86 per cent, while Kanyakumari registered the lowest at 75.50 per cent. The total votes polled were significantly higher than in 2021, when turnout stood at 73.63 per cent.

Though the day was largely peaceful, instances of protest voting were reported in parts of the state. In some villages, residents boycotted polling over unresolved local issues, including past incidents and infrastructure disputes. Elsewhere, minor clashes between party agents and allegations of attempts to influence voters surfaced.

Political leaders and public figures across Tamil Nadu participated in the voting process, with high visibility at polling booths. Election officials ensured arrangements for elderly and differently-abled voters, including transport facilities in remote areas.

The surge in turnout in both states has added a new dimension to the electoral contest, particularly given the reduction in electorate size following the revision of voter rolls. While higher participation percentages reflect strong voter engagement, they have also become a subject of competing

political interpretations.

With the second phase of polling in West Bengal scheduled for April 29, counting for all five poll-bound regions, including Kerala, Assam and Puducherry, set for May 4.

‘Uninformed,’ in ‘poor taste’

Political reactions followed soon after. The opposition Congress party said the comments were insulting and urged Prime Minister Narendra Modi to raise the matter with Washington. Congress leader Supriya Srinete also strongly objected to the language used against India and its people.

Amid the backlash, the US Embassy in New Delhi sought to ease tensions. Its spokesperson, Christopher Elms, said Trump considers India "a great country" and described its leader as "a very good friend". However, the embassy did not specify when or where Trump made those remarks.

Meanwhile, India advised its citizens to avoid travel to Iran amid ongoing regional tensions and continued uncertainty in flight operations. The Indian Embassy in Tehran said reports of some flight services resuming should not be seen as a sign of normalcy and urged nationals not to travel by air or land.

The advisory also asked Indians currently in Iran to leave through designated land border routes in coordination with the embassy. Emergency helpline numbers and an official email were issued for assistance.

The warning comes as airspace restrictions remain in place following the conflict that began on February 28. According to official data, around 9,000 Indians were in Iran when hostilities started, with nearly 1,800 having returned so far.

Trump orders

Corps, which intercepted two vessels and moved them into Iranian waters for inspection. Trump also claimed internal divisions within Iran's leadership, describing tensions between "hardliners" and "moderates".

The United States Central Command said American forces had already redirected 33 vessels since the start of what it described as a blockade. Separately, US forces reported intercepting a sanctioned oil tanker, M/T Majestic X, in the Indian Ocean.

In Islamabad, Interior Minister Mohsin Naqvi met US diplomat Natalie Baker for the second time this week to discuss efforts toward a second round of US-Iran talks. Naqvi described Trump's extension of a ceasefire as a "welcome development" and called for continued diplomatic engagement.

Parallel discussions were held with China and Canada. Chinese envoy Jiang Zaidong met Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif, while Canadian High Commissioner Tarik Ali Khan held talks with Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar.

Iranian Foreign Minister Abbas Araghchi blamed US and Israeli actions for instability in the Strait, while President Masoud Pezeshkian reiterated support for dialogue but cited sanctions and threats as barriers.

Despite speculation that talks could resume soon, Iran has not confirmed participation. Pakistan has deployed over 10,000 personnel to secure Islamabad for the

proposed dialogue, following an inconclusive first round held on April 11 and 12.

AGENCIES

30 minutes of horror

security system and the placement of spare keys. CCTV footage showed him entering the colony around 6.30 am, accessing the house at 6.49 am and leaving at about 7.20 am, indicating he spent roughly 30 to 60 minutes inside.

Police said Meena waited for the victim's parents to leave for their morning gym routine before entering the house using a spare key. He proceeded directly to a rooftop study where the woman, an engineering graduate preparing for civil services examinations, was present. During questioning, the accused allegedly told investigators that he had gone there to demand money. "If I didn't have the money, this would not have happened," he said, according to police sources, adding, "It just happened."

Investigators said the accused initially asked the woman for money and, after being refused, attacked her with a lamp and another heavy object, leaving her bleeding and unconscious. He then allegedly strangled her using a mobile phone charging cable. Forensic examination later revealed multiple abrasions and contusions on her arms, hands and legs, as well as a nasal bone fracture, consistent with signs of resistance. Internal examination showed damage to neck muscles and congestion in organs, indicating asphyxial death due to strangulation.

Police said the accused then sexually assaulted the victim while she was unconscious. He subsequently dragged her body downstairs to a room containing a locker and attempted to access it using her fingerprint. When the biometric lock failed, he broke it open with a screwdriver and took cash and jewellery. Investigators said he changed out of his blood-stained clothes, reportedly wearing clothing belonging to a family member, before fleeing.

The crime came to light when the victim's parents returned home and found her lying in a pool of blood, with signs of a struggle and belongings scattered. She was taken to hospital, where doctors declared her brought dead.

Officials said Meena fled the scene and took an autorickshaw to a hotel in Dwarka, about 25 kilometres away, where he had checked in using a mobile phone. The vehicle and driver have since been traced and questioned. Police have formed multiple teams to track his movements and gather evidence, including CCTV footage from Delhi and Rajasthan.

During interrogation, Meena reportedly changed his account multiple times regarding how he travelled from Alwar to Delhi. He initially claimed he came by ambulance, but later said he hired a car for Rs 5,000 and did not pay the driver after reaching the capital. Police said they are verifying the exact sequence of his travel.

Investigators are also probing a separate rape case registered against him in Rajasthan's Alwar district, where a woman alleged that Meena sexually assaulted her on Tuesday night, hours before the Delhi incident. According to the complaint, the accused was known to the victim's family and had attended a wedding with her husband that evening. The husband later alleged that

Meena returned to the village and assaulted his wife in his absence, also threatening her against reporting the crime.

Alwar police said a medical examination of the survivor has been conducted and that inputs are being shared with Delhi Police. "A special team has been formed, and several people have been detained for questioning," a senior officer said.

Delhi Police officials said the accused appeared composed during questioning and showed little sign of regret, though he expressed remorse in court, telling the magistrate, "Mujhse apradh ho gaya, galti ho gayi." Officers described his statements as inconsistent and said he would be taken to multiple locations, including the crime scene in Delhi and sites in Rajasthan, to recreate events.

Police said efforts are underway to recover the victim's mobile phone, stolen cash and jewellery, and other evidence. Forensic teams are also working to establish a DNA profile and analyse samples collected during post-mortem, including swabs and nail scrapings, to confirm sexual assault.

Officials said the investigation so far indicates that the accused acted alone and was not in contact with accomplices. "We are reconstructing the entire chain of events and gathering all material evidence to ensure a strong case," an officer said.

The case has raised concerns about security vulnerabilities in gated residential areas, as investigators noted that the accused exploited prior familiarity with the household's routines and access systems.

Two road accidents

Personnel from the police and the State Disaster Response Force recovered eight bodies from the gorge and rushed the injured to a nearby hospital.

The deceased included Prem Lal, 36, son of Sampat Lal, and the driver Shiv Singh, 35. Others were identified as Asha Lal, 40, Vijay Lal, 36, Mahavir, 60, Sehat Lal, 65, and Laxman, 33, while one victim remained unidentified. Chief Medical Superintendent Dr Amit Rai said the injured were out of danger. Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhama said he was saddened by the loss of lives and instructed officials to ensure proper medical care.

In Uttar Pradesh, a separate accident in Mirzapur district claimed 11 lives, including four children, after a truck allegedly suffered brake failure and triggered a chain collision on National Highway-135 on Wednesday evening. The crash occurred around 8.30 pm on a downhill stretch from the Dramandganj valley towards Lasoda, about 50 km from the district headquarters.

Police said the truck, carrying chickpeas from Madhya Pradesh, lost control on a slope and rammed into a Bolero and another truck. The impact led to a pile-up, and two cars caught fire. Officials said it took over two hours to extinguish the flames.

Superintendent of Police Aparna Rajat Kaushik said 11 deaths had been confirmed. Nine occupants of the Bolero, including four children, three women and two men, were charred. They were returning from a visit to the Maihar temple in Madhya Pradesh. The drivers of another car and the truck also died, with one suc-

cumbing on the way to hospital.

District Magistrate Pawan Gangwar said seven victims were from Mirzapur, three from Madhya Pradesh and one from Sonbhadra. Police added that identification was challenging due to the condition of the bodies, and families were traced using vehicle registration details. Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath described the incident as "extremely tragic and heart-rending" and directed officials to ensure treatment for the injured, while a detailed probe is underway.

Heatwave tightens grip

Across Punjab and Haryana, temperatures hovered well above seasonal averages. Bathinda recorded 44 degrees Celsius, while Rohtak touched 43.3 degrees Celsius. Other cities such as Hisar, Narnaul and Sirsa reported highs above 42 degrees Celsius, and Chandigarh recorded 40 degrees Celsius.

Rajasthan also remained in the grip of intense heat, with maximum temperatures ranging between 40 and 42 degrees Celsius in most areas, 2 to 3 degrees above normal. The IMD has issued a heatwave warning for parts of the state through Saturday, with temperatures expected to rise further by up to 2 degrees Celsius. In Jaipur, authorities have revised school timings from April 27, with classes up to Class 8 scheduled between 7.30 am and noon.

While heat dominated large swathes of the country, parts of the northeast and central India experienced thunderstorms, with wind speeds ranging from 50 to 95 km/h reported in states including Assam, Nagaland and Madhya Pradesh. Hailstorms were also recorded in Assam and parts of Maharashtra.

The IMD has forecast continued heatwave conditions in isolated pockets of Delhi, Uttar Pradesh, Bihar, Haryana, Rajasthan and Madhya Pradesh, along with persistently warm nights. A marginal drop in temperatures of 2 to 4 degrees Celsius is expected only towards April 26 to 29, while some areas, including Rajasthan, may see limited rainfall activity beginning April 25.

Malegaon blasts case

Code including murder and criminal conspiracy, as well as the stringent Unlawful Activities (Prevention) Act. The High Court quashed a September 2025 order by a special court that had framed charges against them, noting that the lower court had failed to properly assess the evidence.

The explosions themselves struck shortly after Friday prayers. Three blasts occurred within the premises of Hamidia Masjid and Bada Kabrastan, while a fourth detonated at Mushawarat Chowk nearby. The attacks left devastation in their wake and triggered a complex investigation that would later take sharply divergent directions.

Initially, the Maharashtra ATS arrested nine Muslim men and accused a total of 13 individuals, alleging that the conspiracy had been planned months earlier. Investigators pointed to forensic findings,

including traces of RDX in soil samples collected both from the blast sites and from a godown linked to one of the accused. The High Court noted that these samples were found to be consistent with each other.

However, when the NIA took over the probe in 2011, it introduced an entirely different narrative. In its 2013 chargesheet, the agency linked the blasts to alleged right-wing extremists, dropping the earlier accused and declaring the nine men arrested by the ATS innocent. This shift created what the court later described as "diagonally opposite stories" that could not be reconciled.

"The things as stand today give two contradictory versions of the incident and both stories... cannot be reconciled by any stretch of imagination," the High Court observed. It added that the trial court had overlooked "inherent contradiction and intrinsic improbability" in the NIA's case while framing charges.

The NIA's case against the four discharged men relied heavily on circumstantial evidence, including statements that were later retracted. Among these was the confession of Swami Aseemanand, which the agency used to suggest that associates of a deceased right-wing activist were behind the blasts. The High Court pointed out that such retracted statements could not form a reliable basis for prosecution.

"No person has come forward to testify that he or she has seen the accused engaged in the bomb blasts," the court noted, adding that the agency had failed to collect fresh evidence and instead relied on statements made in other cases. It also described certain claims, such as the purchase of bicycles allegedly used in the blasts, as hearsay. The judgment questioned why evidence gathered by earlier agencies, including the ATS and the Central Bureau of Investigation, had been disregarded. "There is no explanation as to how the evidence... can be ignored," the court said, stressing that such material remains part of the record and must be considered.

The ruling has effectively left the case without any accused facing trial. The nine men arrested by the ATS were discharged by a special court in 2016, a decision that remains under challenge but has not been heard since 2019. The four men named later by the NIA have now also been discharged.

Beyond those formally charged, seven individuals named across both investigations remain untraceable. Among those identified in the ATS probe were Muzammil, alleged to be a Pakistani national, and three residents of Malegaon who disappeared in October 2006: Munawwar Ahmed, Riyaz Ahmed Shafi Ahmed and Ishtiyak Ahmed Mohammed Isaq.

Munawwar was described by investigators as a key conspirator who allegedly directed the targeting of the mosque and cemetery complex. Riyaz was accused of placing one of the explosive devices, while Ishtiyak was named as part of the broader conspiracy. Despite initial surveillance and questioning, all three vanished within weeks of the blasts.

Families of the missing continue to grapple with uncertainty. Munawwar's father, Mohammed Amin, now in his

seventies, has lived for years without knowing whether his son is alive. "We do not even know if our son is alive or dead," he said in an earlier account, reflecting the anguish of those left behind.

The second phase of the investigation introduced another set of absconding suspects. The NIA named Ramchandra Kalsangra, Sandeep Dange and Ramesh Mahalkar, alleging their involvement in planting and assembling the explosives. Like the earlier suspects, they too could not be traced.

Kalsangra, an electrical contractor from Indore, reportedly disappeared around 2008 after leaving home for work. Authorities later announced a reward for information about him, but he remains missing. Dange, also from Indore and trained as an electrical engineer, and Mahalkar, a resident of Nanded, similarly vanished and continue to be listed among wanted individuals in multiple cases.

In 2009, a suspended police officer claimed in an affidavit that two of these men had died in custody, but the allegation was never substantiated. Their disappearance, along with that of the earlier suspects, represents what investigators have described as the last unresolved thread in the case.

The broader investigation into related incidents has also seen setbacks. In July last year, a special court acquitted former BJP MP Pragya Singh Thakur, Lt Col Prasad Purohit and five others in the 2008 Malegaon blast case, citing lack of evidence. The overlap of names and allegations across cases has further complicated the narrative.

For the High Court, the central issue remains the absence of a coherent and credible prosecution story. It noted that while courts have the authority to sift and weigh evidence at the stage of framing charges, such scrutiny must ensure that there is sufficient material to proceed in serious offences that carry severe penalties.

The court's conclusion that the case has reached a "dead end" reflects not only the contradictions between investigative agencies but also the passage of time and the erosion of evidentiary clarity. With no accused currently facing trial and several key figures missing, the question of accountability for the 2006 blasts remains unanswered.

India extends airspace

The move follows Pakistan's own extension of a similar ban on Tuesday, with both countries continuing reciprocal closures since April last year. India shut its airspace on April 30, 2025, while Pakistan acted earlier on April 24.

The restrictions came after the Pahalgam attack that left 26 people dead. Airlines in India continue to take longer international routes due to the ongoing airspace limitations.

MPOST

CBSE Class-10 second board

Controller of examinations Sanyam Bhardwaj issued the datesheet a week after first-term results. CBSE allows students to appear in up to three subjects and retain their best scores.

MPOST

'BUMPER VOTER TURNOUT SIGNALS REGIME CHANGE'

‘May 4 marks TMC’s end’: PM Modi sees Bengal turning the tide

OUR CORRESPONDENT

KRISHNANAGAR/ MATHURAPUR: Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Thursday congratulated the people of West Bengal for their massive turnout in the first phase of assembly elections, and called the voting figures so far indicative of an “overwhelming mandate for change”.

Addressing poll rallies in Krishnanagar in Nadia district on a day when voters across 152 constituencies of the state queued up to exercise their franchise in the aftermath of the over 90 lakh SIR deletions, Modi also congratulated the Election Commission for keeping “violence during the assembly polls in the state at a minimum”.

“This is the first time in the last 50 years of poll history in West Bengal that incidents of violence were kept at a minimum. The information I have



PM Narendra Modi during a roadshow in Howrah

received so far about the record-breaking turnout makes me certain that this is going to be an overwhelming mandate in favour of a change which West Bengal’s voters have already decided to bring about,” the PM said.

Addressing a gathering at the South 24 Parganas district’s Kakdwip stadium under the Mathurapur assembly constit-

uency, the PM claimed that the massive poll turnout in the state signalled a transition from the TMC’s regime of ‘bhoy’ (fear) to the ‘bharosa’ (trust) the BJP has promised.

May 4, when votes will be counted, would mark the “expiry” of the “TMC’s 15-year-old syndicate system and maha jungle raj” in West Bengal, Modi said.

Highlights

» Holding the Mamata Banerjee dispensation responsible for making “false promises and betraying people”, the PM listed out a set of “broken promises” made by TMC

» Addressing a poll rally in Krishnanagar in Nadia district, Modi also congratulated the Election Commission for keeping “violence during the assembly polls in the state at a minimum”

ignoring the sweltering heat that swept across the districts.

Reports of sporadic violence were received from some pockets of the state during the course of the day, despite unprecedented security arrangements, where over 2,400 companies of central paramilitary troops were deployed across the 44,000-plus booths where polling took place.

Modi said the BJP’s West Bengal unit would hold victory celebrations on May 4 after the counting of votes gets over, where the party would distribute among people not just sweets, but also ‘jhalhuri’, the popular street snack which the PM savoured at an unscheduled stop during his visit to Jhargram last week.

Referring to that incident, Modi took a dig at TMC leaders after Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee termed the PM’s extended stay as “drama” and claimed that “the entire episode was scripted”.

Referring to previous voter turnout figures elsewhere in the country, the PM claimed the BJP achieved decisive victories whenever people turned up to vote in massive numbers.

West Bengal has recorded an average voter turnout of nearly 90 per cent till 5 pm, among the highest in the state’s recent electoral history, with lakhs reportedly still waiting in queues,

Shah’s big pitch: ‘BJP win will end infiltration in WB’

BALAGARH: Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Thursday said “not a single intruder” would be allowed to enter West Bengal if the BJP comes to power in the state, and the illegal immigrants already here would be “selectively rooted out”.

Addressing a public rally at Balagarh in Hooghly district on a day when voting for the first phase was underway, he said the BJP was poised to form a government in the state with a full majority.

“Today, the voting for the first phase is almost over, and this is my 30th programme across Bengal. On May 5, Didi’s game will be up. The BJP will form a government in Bengal with a full majority,” he said.

The result of the West Bengal Assembly polls will be declared on May 4.



Amit Shah is felicitated during a public meeting, at Balagarh, in Hooghly

Asserting that infiltration was hurting the state’s economy and national security, Shah said, “Intruders are eating away the jobs of Bengal’s youth, the rations of the poor, and working to undermine the country’s security”.

Stepping up his attack on the TMC government, the senior BJP leader accused it of

Maha bypolls: 58% turnout in Baramati; Sunetra set for sweep

Urges voters to support her as a tribute to Ajit Pawar

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: A voter turnout of 58.27 per cent was recorded by 6 pm on Thursday in the byelection to Baramati Assembly constituency in Maharashtra where deputy Chief Minister Sunetra Pawar is a contestant, election officials said.

The turnout was estimated at 56.20 per cent in Rahuri, another assembly constituency where a byelection was held.

Polling began at 7 am and ended at 6 pm. The process was peaceful in both places, officials said.

The death of then Deputy Chief Minister and Nationalist Congress Party president Ajit Pawar in a plane crash on January 28 necessitated the bypoll in Baramati.

His wife Sunetra Pawar, who is contesting her first assembly poll, is likely to sail through riding a sympathy wave, and given her family’s strong hold on the constituency. No major political party



Maharashtra Deputy CM Sunetra Pawar after casting a vote

has fielded candidates against her.

The results will be announced on May 4.

The Rahuri assembly seat became vacant after BJP MLA Shivaji Kardile’s death in October last year. His son Akshay Kardile is in the fray as a BJP candidate. NCP (SP)’s Govind Mokate and Vanchit Bahujan Aghadi’s Santosh Chalke are among his main rivals.

In Baramati, there were a total of 23 candidates in the fray, including Sunetra Pawar.

During the campaigning, she urged voters to support her as a tribute to her late husband. The total number of registered voters in the constituency is 3.84 lakh.

Sunetra Pawar, Ajit Pawar’s younger brother Srinivas Pawar, and his wife Sharmila cast their votes at Katewadi polling booth early in the morning.

The Opposition Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA) did not field any candidate against Sunetra Pawar, giving a virtual walkover to her. Congress had fielded Akash More but the party later decided to withdraw his candidature.

Talking to reporters, Sunetra Pawar said, “People of Baramati are coming in big numbers to cast their votes. I would not say it is out of enthusiasm, but they are stepping out to fulfil their duty. By doing so, they are paying tribute to Dada (‘elder brother’ in Marathi, as Ajit Pawar was called by his supporters).

BJP attributes surge in voter turnout in Tamil Nadu to SIR

CHENNAI: The BJP on Thursday attributed the surge in voter turnout in Tamil Nadu to electoral roll reforms undertaken by the Election Commission, saying the high polling percentage reflects strong democratic participation and augurs well for the NDA.

BJP leader Narayanan Thirupathy credited the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls for the enthusiastic response from voters across the state. “Full credit to SIR. Hats off to the Election Commission of India. We have seen this trend in Bihar, Assam, West Bengal, Kerala, Puducherry and now in Tamil Nadu,” he said.

He said the reforms had

Alleges that the ruling DMK has resorted to widespread malpractice due to a “fear of defeat”

strengthened the electoral process and ensured greater inclusivity, leading to what he described as “large, large” voter participation. Thirupathy added that critics of the revision exercise should reconsider their stance in light of the turnout figures. “Those who opposed it earlier should now feel ashamed seeing peo-

ple come out in such numbers to vote,” he said.

Expressing confidence about the NDA’s prospects, Thirupathy said the alliance is focused on delivering “good governance” and believes the electorate is ready for change.

At the same time, he levelled allegations against the ruling DMK, claiming the party had resorted to malpractice due to a “fear of defeat”. He alleged that both money and violence played a role during polling. “Money flowed like a river and violence also matched that,” he said.

Despite the allegations, he maintained that electoral outcomes are part of the democratic process.

BJP scored double ‘F’ in ensuring fuel, fertiliser security for nation: Kharge

NEW DELHI: Congress president Mallikarjun Kharge on Thursday alleged that the Modi government has scored a “double” failure grade in ensuring fuel and fertiliser security for India, and tried to deflect its failures through “delimitation theatrics”.

Kharge also took a swipe at Prime Minister Narendra Modi, saying he should heed to his own “Mardarshak Mandal” member Murlidhar Manohar Joshi, who recently stated that “we should not use the rhetoric of Vishwaguru anymore”.

Kharge’s swipe came days after Joshi said India is not a ‘vishwaguru’ (global teacher) anymore and this term should not be used.

‘Tried to deflect its failures through delimitation theatrics’

Speaking to reporters on the sidelines of an event here, Joshi had made a strong pitch for making Sanskrit India’s official language, saying many people, including B R Ambedkar, made efforts for it in the past, but the proposals were not cleared.

In a post on X, Kharge said, “Modi government tried to deflect its failures and serious Epstein file allegations, through delimitation theatrics, but India saw through the charade. The BJP has scored a DOUBLE ‘F’

(Fail) in ensuring Fuel & Fertilizer security for the nation.”

On fuel, Kharge said production is down, import diversification fails, and our ships in the Strait of Hormuz are unable to secure safe passage.

“14 Indian-flagged vessels remain stranded there for 54 days. India’s crude oil production has been falling for the 11th consecutive year in 2025–26, all thanks to Modi Govt. Overall crude production has collapsed by nearly 22% since 2014–15,” he said.

Gas output has suffered an even more shocking decline of around 40%, falling from 47,555 MMSCM in 2011–12 to just 28,672 MMSCM in 2020–21, Kharge said.

Over 59% voter turnout recorded in Gujarat’s Umreth bypoll

ANAND: A voter turnout of 59.04 per cent was recorded in the bypoll to the Umreth assembly seat in Gujarat’s Anand district on Thursday, officials said.

The bypoll, necessitated following the death of sitting BJP MLA Govind Parmar last month, witnessed a direct contest between BJP candidate Harshad Govindbhai Parmar and Congress nominee Bhurugajsinh Chauhan. Three Independents and a candidate from a lesser-known party were also in the fray.

The Umreth assembly seat recorded a provisional voter turnout of 59.04 per cent in the by-election, data shared by poll authorities said.

Voting took place in a peaceful manner and no untoward incident took place during the day, they said.

Polling commenced at 7 am and ended at 6 pm across 306 polling stations set up in the constituency, a release by the Chief Electoral Officer (CEO) for Gujarat said.

Both the key candidates exercised their franchise in the morning and expressed confidence of winning the elections.

A total of 2,45,623 voters were eligible to exercise their franchise in the by-election, conducted with the help of 1,500 personnel, the release said.

Counting of votes will be taken up on May 4.

The BJP fielded Harshad Parmar, son of four-time MLA Govind Parmar, who died on March 6 at the age of 72 after a brief illness. It is his first major election.

On the other hand, the Congress has nominated Bhurugajsinh Chauhan, a 62-year-old seasoned local leader who is also contesting his first assembly election.

Chauhan served as the president of the Umreth taluka panchayat for three consecutive terms between 2000 and 2015. He is currently the party’s coordinator for the central zone in the state. In the 2022 assembly elections, Govind Parmar had retained the Umreth seat for the BJP.

TN polls: 14-member family keeps tradition alive

CHENNAI: In a vivid snapshot of democratic spirit, a three-generation family of 14 turned heads as they arrived together at a polling booth set up at Stella Maris College on Thursday to cast their votes in the 2026 Tamil Nadu Assembly election.

Spanning ages from elderly family heads to first-time voters, the group queued up as one, drawing attention from fellow voters and media crews at the prominent polling station. Their coordinated participation stood out amid the steady stream of electors exercising their franchise across the city.

Stella Maris College, one of Chennai’s well-known polling venues, has often witnessed high voter turnout and visits by notable personalities, making it a focal point on election day.

Members of the family said voting together has been a cherished tradition for years—one they consciously uphold to set an example for younger generations.

“We have been doing this for years. It is important that the grandchildren see us participate so they understand that their voice matters as much as ours,” said 63-year-old Jayanthi.

Her son Shivraj, 35, added that the collective act transforms voting into a meaningful family ritual. “Coming with the whole family makes it feel less like a chore and more like a celebration of our rights. We even discussed key issues like employment and law and order over breakfast before heading here,” he said.

Polling is currently underway across all 234 constituencies in Tamil Nadu, with voters turning out in large numbers to shape the state’s political future.

Ballots with a twist: Tamil Nadu polls witness fun, drama and colourful chaos

Polling was on across 234 Assembly segments in the state with over 4,000 candidates in fray

CHENNAI: The Tamil Nadu Assembly election on Thursday turned out to be a kaleidoscope of tidbits, tense moments and curiosity.

Incidents like AIADMK leader and former Minister Dindigul C Srinivasan reportedly pressing the ‘red light’ on the Electronic Voting Machine (EVM) instead of the button to cast vote amused people. Later, the polling official pointed to the button and he cast his vote.

Polling was on across 234 Assembly segments in the state with over 4,000 candidates in fray. In Coimbatore, Vellore and Dharmapuri districts, ‘Robo Tina’, dressed like a cute little girl, welcomed voters to the polling station and gave flowers and chocolates to the people.

Some, working in foreign countries including Singapore and in cities outside of Tamil Nadu arrived in their hometowns including Chennai to cast their votes.

At Namakkal, a “super elderly” woman, Mariaayi,



Tina, a robot, dressed in traditional attire, welcomes voters during polling in Coimbatore

reportedly 110 years old, cast her vote. Speaking to reporters, she said she had seen so many leaders including DMK founder CN Annadurai and AIADMK founder MG Ramachandran in her life. At Palpalayam in Namakkal, a 60-year old bedridden woman was brought to the polling station in an ambulance to ensure she performs her democratic duty. Similarly, several persons with disabilities and health issues were brought in wheel-

chairs to the polling stations.

The Election Commission arranged three boats to help villagers off the Pechiparai dam falling under the Padmanabhapuram Constituency in Kanyakumari district to reach the polling station to cast their votes. Voters linked to Vengaiavasal village in Pudukottai district boycotted polling over the incident of faeces being mixed in an overhead water tank a few years ago. They demanded justice over

the incident.

At Perumpathu village in Nanguneri constituency in southern Tamil Nadu, not even a single person allegedly voted for several hours to mark their protest against a double murder case.

Further, villagers near Ettayapuram in Thoothukudi district boycotted the election and their polling station (Kulathuvai Patti union primary school) under the Vilathikulam Assembly constituency wore a

deserted look as only five votes were cast out of the total 983. Their boycott was due to a local dispute over using a pathway.

At this polling station, it is customary for the people of four villages—Kulathuvaipatti, Kumaragiri, Sothunaickanpatti, and Ammampadam—to cast their votes. However, this time, the people of Kulathuvaipatti and Kumaragiri villages have boycotted the election.

Sporadic, violent incidents were also reported. Booth agents clashed at Keezhavasal in Madurai and at Kalasapakkam in Tiruvannamalai, an agent of an independent candidate allegedly broke a control unit and it was replaced.

Tension prevailed at a polling booth under Arisipalayam, Salem city, during voting in view of a sudden clash between booth agents of the AIADMK and DMK. A woman resident of Chennai in Mylapore constituency alleged she ran pillar to post to find out why her name was deleted from the voters list.

Nation Briefs

ASSAM CONG CONSTITUTES 7 TEAMS FOR ‘IRREGULARITIES’ IN COUNTING

GUWAHATI: The Assam Pradesh Congress Committee (APCC) has constituted seven special teams to ensure security measures are in place to prevent any irregularities during the vote counting process on May 4. Following discussions between AICC general secretary and Assam in-charge Jitendra Singh and APCC president Gaurav Gogoi, the special teams were constituted to visit various districts across the state, ahead of the counting of votes for the assembly polls, a party release said on Thursday. A record 85.96 per cent of Assam’s 2.50 crore electorate exercised their franchise in the April 9 assembly polls, the Election Commission had said. These teams have been instructed to inspect the ‘strongrooms’, meet party candidates, and hold discussions with district administrations from April 25.

YOGI ADITYANATH REVIEWS ARRANGEMENTS FOR PM MODI’S APRIL 29 VISIT

HARDOI: Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Thursday visited Mallawan here to review preparations for Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s proposed visit on April 29 to inaugurate the Ganga Expressway connecting Meerut and Prayagraj. Officials said preparations for the event have reached the final stage, with the district administration on high alert to ensure smooth conduct of the programme. The CM inspected the arrangements and directed officials to ensure there is no lapse in security, traffic management, parking, stage setup.

ALLOWED TO PRAY IN MOSQUES

No restriction in Islam on women coming to mosque: AIMPLB to SC

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Urging the courts not to judicially determine religious practices, the All India Muslim Personal Law Board (AIMPLB) on Thursday told the Supreme Court that Islam does not restrict women from coming to the mosque for namaz, but it is preferable that they stay at home.

Senior Advocate M R Shamshad, appearing for the AIMPLB, told a nine-judge constitution bench headed by Chief Justice Surya Kant that women are allowed to offer namaz in the mosque subject to some discipline.

The issue, he submitted, has come up before the bench because a writ petition was filed seeking that women be allowed to pray in mosques.

“We have filed an affidavit to say that under all sects of Islam, women are allowed to enter mosques and offer prayers, subject to certain disciplines. There is no bar on them anywhere; they can come and be part of the congregation,” he said.

He submitted that there is no sanctum sanctorum in the mosque, as was the impression given.

The AIMPLB counsel told the bench -- also comprising Justices B V Nagarathna, M M Sundresh, Ahsanuddin Amanullah, Aravind Kumar, Augustine George Masih, Prasanna B Varale, R Mahadevan, and Joyimalya Bagchi -- it is preferable that women offer namaz at home and they will get the same religious rewards as men who offer prayers at a mosque.

Intervening, Justice



HIGHLIGHTS

» But it is preferable that they stay at home, it said

» AIMPLB submitted that there is no sanctum sanctorum in the mosque, as was the impression given

Amanullah said the reason behind this was that if everyone from a household goes to the mosque, then who will take care of the children?

Justice Nagarathna said that in Islam, women are not mandated to attend the congregation in a mosque.

Shamshad said the holy book, the Quran, asks to follow the Prophet, and that the manners of worship are mentioned in Hadiths.

He submitted that given the belief, practices, thought processes, adherence to religious teaching, flexibility with which a person is obliged to follow religious tenets, and the personal choice of a person to treat certain practices as essential for his belief sys-

tem, it will not be prudent or possible to determine essential practices of a particular religion.

Accordingly, it is submitted that the courts must not attempt to judicially determine the nature of religious practices. According to Article 25, to interpret what is religious practice, or for that matter, the core of the religion within the meaning of essential religious practices, these matters must be left for those who are scholars in the religion or the religious denominations, and/or the beliefs of the followers of that particular religion...,” he submitted.

During the eighth day of hearing on petitions related to discrimination against women at religious places, including the Sabarimala temple, and on the ambit and scope of religious freedom practised by multiple faiths, the bench observed that it respects the views of all eminent authors and thinkers, but cannot accept information from “WhatsApp University”.

The hearing would continue on April 28.

India-Africa partnership will be message of stability in turbulent world: Jaishankar

Logo, theme for upcoming India-Africa Forum Summit-IV unveiled

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: As the world navigates through complex geopolitical challenges, the India-Africa partnership assumes particular significance, and it will be a message of “stability” and “reliability” in a turbulent and uncertain world, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar said on Thursday.

Addressing a gathering at the unveiling of the logo, theme and website for the upcoming India-Africa Forum Summit-IV, Jaishankar also asserted that together, India and Africa are not just development partners, but also “partners in shaping a better world”.

His comments come in the backdrop of multiple conflicts in various parts of the world, including the one in West Asia that has stretched for more than 50 days with global ramifications.



EAM S Jaishankar speaks during the launch of the logo, theme and website of the 4th India-Africa Forum Summit, in New Delhi

The logo for the upcoming summit features a lion, superimposed on an image depicting interlocked maps of India and Africa.

It carries the theme ‘Enduring Partnership Shared Vision’ and the date of the summit, May 28-31.

Jaishankar said the upcoming summit presents a “unique opportunity” to further “deepen our engagement”.

Badrinath Dham reopens

DEHRADUN: The portals of the Badrinath temple in the Garhwal Himalayan region of Uttarakhand reopened for devotees on Thursday after a six-month winter break.

The first puja following the reopening was performed in the name of Prime Minister Narendra Modi.

The gates of the temple located in Chamoli district were opened at 6.15 am following Vedic rituals and prayers.

Nearly 15,000 pilgrims from across the country and abroad attended the ceremony.

Uttarakhand Chief Minister Pushkar Singh Dhami and Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) state president Mahendra Bhatt attended the opening ceremony and interacted with pilgrims to seek feedback on administrative arrangements.

Dhami said the state government made extensive preparations to ensure a safe and smooth Chardham Yatra and urged pilgrims to cooperate in maintaining a “green and clean” pilgrimage.



Devotees throng at Badrinath Dham during the portals opening ceremony, in Chamoli, Thursday

Sounds of drums, army bands and chants of ‘Jai Badri Vishal’ resonated in the air, while women from Mana and Bamni villages performed the traditional ‘Jhumailo’ dance in the temple courtyard.

Suzuki to expand investments in Haryana: Toshihiro Suzuki to CM

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini on Thursday met Suzuki Motor Corporation Representative Director and President Toshihiro Suzuki, who assured that the company will continue to expand investments in the state.

The meeting took place in Haryana Bhawan in New Delhi.

During the meeting, Suzuki said that the company is committed to contributing not only to India’s progress, but also to the development of Haryana.

During the discussion, Saini said that Haryana has consistently supported Suzuki Motor and expressed confidence that the company will continue to invest in the state.

He sought support from the state govt to ensure smooth production and sales

Suzuki Motor is the only company that has received SGST incentives from the Haryana government, the chief minister added.

In response, Toshihiro Suzuki said that the company will focus on hybrid and CNG vehicles in India. He further noted that if Suzuki decides to manufacture electric vehicles and set up a new plant in the future, Haryana would be its preferred destination for investment.

The executive emphasised

the importance of continued strong communication and cooperation with the Haryana government. Reflecting on Suzuki’s early days in India during 1982-83, he mentioned that despite differences in working styles between India and Japan, there are many similarities that have strengthened collaboration.

Suzuki stated that the company is taking significant steps in the compressed biogas sector and plans to increase investment in this area.

He said Suzuki aims to set up nine biogas plants, out of which two have already been established.

He further informed that Suzuki will manufacture strong hybrid vehicles at its Kharkhoda plant in Haryana.

\$1 TRILLION ECONOMY GOAL

UP pushes industry-linked training for youth

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: The Uttar Pradesh government has stepped up efforts to align skill development with employment generation, positioning it as a key driver of the state’s ambition to build a \$1 trillion economy.

At a high-level review of the Vocational Education and Skill Development Department, Minister of State (Independent Charge) Kapil Dev Agarwal directed officials to directly link training programmes with job opportunities, ensuring that youth secure employment immediately after completing courses.

The review, held at the state secretariat, focused on making skill initiatives outcome-driven rather than certificate-oriented. Agarwal stressed that training

INSIGHT

» Officials were tasked with making all programmes time-bound, quality-focused and aligned with industry requirements

must translate into jobs or self-employment, underlining its role in accelerating economic growth under Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath.

Officials were tasked with making all programmes time-bound, quality-focused and aligned with industry requirements. The government is betting on large-scale employability through reforms in Industrial Training Institutes, deeper industry partnerships and the

» The government is betting on large-scale employability through reforms in ITIs, deeper industry partnerships and the introduction of modern, technology-driven courses

introduction of modern, technology-driven courses.

The push comes amid rising demand for skilled manpower, driven by increased industrial investments and expansion in the MSME sector across the state. The government sees the integration of training with real-time industry needs as critical to sustaining this growth momentum.

A key focus area remains the modernisation of ITIs. The minister called for strengthening col-

laboration with Tata Technologies to make training fully industry-oriented. A separate virtual review with Deloitte India highlighted the need to align curricula with emerging technologies and global standards.

Officials have been directed to upgrade infrastructure at training centres, including advanced labs and modern equipment, to meet international benchmarks.

Concerns over rising dropout rates in skill programmes and ITIs were also flagged. The minister asked departments to identify underlying causes and introduce incentive mechanisms to improve course completion rates. Expansion of industry exposure through On-the-Job Training and the Dual System of Training has been prioritised to enhance practical learning outcomes.

Girls top UP board exams

MPOST BUREAU

PRAYAGRAJ (UP): Announcing the results of board examinations, the Uttar Pradesh Board of Secondary Education on Thursday said 90.42 per cent of candidates cleared the Class 10 exam, while 80.38 per cent passed Class 12.

In both examinations, girls dominated the top three positions.

In the high school examination, Kashish Verma from Sitapur and Anshika Verma from Barabanki secured the top position with 97.83 per cent marks, while Aditi from Barabanki stood second with 97.5 per cent. Arpita from Sitapur, Rishabh Sahu from Jhansi and Pari Verma from Barabanki shared the third position scoring 97.33 per cent, Director of Secondary Education Mahendra Dev told reporters.

In the Intermediate examination, Shikha Verma from Sitapur emerged first scoring 97.6 per cent. Nandini Gupta from Bareilly and Shriya Verma from Barabanki stood second with 97.2 per cent, while Surbhi Yadav from Bareilly and Poja Pal from Barabanki shared the third position with 97 per cent, Dev said.

He said 26,01,381 candidates appeared in the Class 10 examination, out of which 23,52,181 were declared successful. While 87.30 per cent of boys passed the examination, the pass percentage of girls stood at 93.76 per cent.

A total of 24,86,072 candidates appeared in the Class 12 examination, of whom 19,98,317 were declared successful. While 75.04 per cent of boys passed this examination, the pass percentage of girls was 86.32 per cent.

The high school and Intermediate examinations in the state were conducted from February 18 to March 12, 2026.

The exams were held successfully over 15 working days at 8,033 centres. Evaluation of answer sheets was carried out from March 18 to April 4 at 254 evaluation centres, Dev said.

‘Punjab-Finland varsity tie-up improving classroom learning’

MPOST BUREAU

CHANDIGARH: Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Thursday said a collaboration between his government and Finland’s University of Turku is beginning to translate into visible changes in classrooms, with teaching practices becoming more interactive and early signs of improved student engagement emerging on the ground.

As part of this initiative, teaching is steadily moving away from rote methods towards more joyful and participatory learning approaches, he said.

Anchored in Punjab’s broader ‘Sikhya Kranti’, the programme focuses on adapting global expertise to local



classroom contexts while building scale through a structured train-the-trainers model, with nearly 300 teachers set to be trained to strengthen foundational learning across the state, said Mann.

During his ongoing official visit to Finland, Mann visited the Kukulo-Moikoinen Early Childhood Education and Care Centre, according to an official release.

“This initiative is already yielding results by aligning global pedagogical expertise with local classroom realities,”

said Mann.

The partnership, anchored through the State Council of Educational Research and Training under the Department of School Education, seeks to strengthen teacher development in early childhood and foundational education.

It is designed not as a short-term intervention but as a long-term institutional effort to embed child-centred and play-based learning in the state’s education system, alongside inclusive teaching practices, he said.

“The programme has focused on equipping teachers with research-driven methods while ensuring these approaches are adapted to Punjab’s socio-cultural context,” he stated.

Protect grasslands by amending forest conservation laws, states urge Centre

‘Grasslands are an essential ecosystem requiring protection & restoration’

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: Karnataka, Rajasthan, Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh, and Jammu and Kashmir have highlighted the need to conserve grasslands by amending India’s forest conservation laws.

At a recent meeting of the Standing Committee of the National Board for Wildlife (SC-NBWL), representatives from these states “emphasised that suitable amendments/clarifications in guidelines under the Van (Sanrakshan Evam Samvardhan) Adhiniyam, 1980, may be required to enable/recognise grassland restoration under compensatory afforestation mechanisms”.

Compensatory afforestation is a legal mechanism that promotes afforestation and regeneration activities to compensate for forest land diversion for non-forestry uses.

According to the minutes of the meeting, the states asserted that grasslands are an essential ecosystem requiring protection and restoration, while balancing

KEY POINTS

- » Karnataka, Rajasthan, Gujarat, Madhya Pradesh, and Jammu and Kashmir have highlighted the need to conserve grasslands
- » They raised the issue at a recent meeting of the Standing Committee of the National Board for Wildlife (SC-NBWL)
- » The states asserted that grasslands are an essential ecosystem requiring



protection and restoration, while balancing conservation priorities with grazing requirements and livelihood dependencies

ing conservation priorities with grazing requirements and livelihood dependencies.

However, Mohan Pargaian, a retired Indian Forest Service (IFS) officer, raised concerns regarding the states’ recommendation, saying it seems to be more about afforestation targets than ecological restoration.

Pargaian said: “When it comes to compensatory afforestation, states are facing a land crunch. This is because non-forest land is becoming scarce and expensive, and the number of projects which involve diversion of forest land is rising. Due to this, states are not able to

meet their afforestation targets. As a result, it appears that they want to use grasslands for compensatory afforestation.”

Such a move could severely harm grasslands, the former forest official said.

“Not all land is meant to be planted with trees. Ecologically open lands like grasslands and scrublands have their own native ecosystems, which would be negatively affected by afforestation. For instance, if you take a savanna and plant a dense forest there, the entire ecology will change,” Pargaian added.

He also said if states want

to conserve grasslands, they can do so on their own without needing permission from the Centre or tweaking the legislation.

Grasslands and rangelands (a broader land category including grasslands, shrublands, and deserts) have a sequestration (removal) potential of about 2.3 to 7.3 billion tonnes of CO2 equivalent per year, the SC-NBWL was informed during the recent meeting.

According to the minutes: “These ecosystems hold nearly one-third of terrestrial carbon, with about 90 pc of this carbon stored below ground.”

NCB warns Indians about Maldives laws

NARESH BISWANI

NEW DELHI: The Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB) has issued an advisory for Indians travelling to the Maldives following stricter anti-drug laws that came into force in March 2026. The updated regulations impose severe penalties, including life imprisonment for several offences, while large-scale trafficking could attract capital punishment subject to judicial approval. Even minor possession now carries stringent consequences.

The advisory follows reports of foreign nationals, including Indians, being detained over alleged drug violations. India’s diplomatic mission in Malé has urged travellers to strictly adhere to local laws.

The NCB cautioned against carrying items for others without full knowledge of their contents and warned travellers to remain vigilant, particularly in transit areas. Personal belongings should not be left unattended.

It emphasised that ignorance of Maldivian law offers no defence, and violations could lead to serious legal consequences.

‘India’s green transition to boost jobs’

NEW DELHI: India’s transition to a green economy will generate substantial employment for young professionals across renewable energy, electric mobility and circular economy sectors, Union minister Jitendra Singh said on Thursday. Speaking at the valedictory session of an environmental sustainability conference at Jamia Millia Islamia on Earth Day, he outlined the government’s push for green entrepreneurship as a key driver of growth and climate action.

Singh highlighted the National Green Hydrogen Mission as central to decarbonising industries such as steel and cement. He also cited innovations in electric mobility, including low-cost retrofitting of conventional vehicles.

Beyond traditional renewable sectors, Singh identified emerging domains including battery production, grid management, biofuel conversion, and ocean energy as growth areas.

MPOST



EDITORIAL
GUARDRAILS
FOR GAMING

The notification of the long-awaited rules to operationalise the Promotion and Regulation of Online Gaming Act marks a decisive, if cautious, step in India's approach to regulating a rapidly expanding digital sector. Coming into effect from May 1, 2026, the framework attempts to strike a delicate balance between enabling innovation and safeguarding users. By opting for a "regulation-light" regime, the government has signalled that it does not intend to stifle a sector driven by creativity and technological dynamism. At the same time, the creation of a dedicated Online Gaming Authority of India introduces an institutional mechanism to address concerns that have long shadowed the industry—ranging from addiction and financial risk to data misuse and opaque monetisation practices. The question, however, is whether this calibrated minimalism will be sufficient to manage the complexities of a sector that sits at the intersection of entertainment, finance, and behavioural psychology.

At the heart of the new rules is a conscious decision to avoid blanket regulation. Most online social games will not require mandatory registration or prior classification, and service providers are not compelled to seek formal determination of their offerings. This optionality is designed to reduce compliance burdens and encourage ease of doing business. It reflects an understanding that overregulation could push innovation offshore or into informal channels. Yet, this light-touch approach also carries risks. In a digital ecosystem where business models evolve rapidly and monetisation strategies often blur the lines between gaming and gambling, leaving classification largely voluntary may create grey zones. The government has, however, retained the power to step in—triggering classification in specific cases, including suo motu reviews or when financial stakes appear significant. This safety valve is important, but its effectiveness will depend on the vigilance and capacity of the regulator.

A notable innovation in the framework is the introduction of "user safety features" as an enabling provision. By requiring platforms to incorporate safeguards such as age verification, time restrictions, parental controls, reporting tools, counselling support, and fair-play monitoring, the rules recognise that risks in online gaming are not merely financial but also psychological and social. This is a progressive step, particularly in a country with a large young and digitally active population. However, the emphasis remains on disclosure rather than strict standardisation. Service providers are required to outline their safety mechanisms, but the adequacy of these measures is not tightly prescribed. This could lead to uneven implementation, with some platforms adopting robust protections while others comply only minimally. For a sector where user harm can be subtle and cumulative, the challenge will be to ensure that "safety features" do not become a box-ticking exercise.

The determination framework for identifying online money games is another critical pillar of the rules. By outlining factors such as entry fees, expectation of monetary gains, revenue models, and the monetisation of in-game assets, the government has attempted to create a structured test to distinguish permissible games from those that fall into the prohibited category. The 90-day timeline for such determinations introduces much-needed certainty for businesses. Yet, the complexity of modern gaming ecosystems—where virtual currencies, reward systems, and hybrid models are commonplace—means that classification will not always be straightforward. There is a real possibility of disputes and interpretational challenges, particularly as platforms innovate to stay ahead of regulatory thresholds. The success of this framework will depend not only on clarity in rules but also on consistency in their application.

Institutionally, the creation of the Online Gaming Authority of India as a multi-sectoral body under MeitY reflects the cross-cutting nature of the sector. With representation from ministries dealing with home affairs, finance, broadcasting, sports, and law, the Authority is equipped to address diverse concerns—from financial integrity to consumer protection. Its role as a digital-first regulator, empowered to publish lists of prohibited games, adjudicate grievances, and coordinate with banks and law enforcement, is both ambitious and necessary. The linkage with financial institutions, in particular, is a strong enforcement mechanism. By enabling banks to scrutinise transactions and act against unregistered or prohibited entities, the rules attempt to curb illicit financial flows. However, this also raises concerns about overreach and the potential for disruption in legitimate operations if safeguards and due process are not rigorously maintained.

Ultimately, the new rules represent an important beginning rather than a final solution. They acknowledge the need for oversight without undermining the sector's growth potential. Yet, their success will hinge on implementation, regulatory agility, and continuous refinement. The gaming industry is not static; it evolves with technology, user behaviour, and market incentives. A framework that is "regulation-light" today may need recalibration tomorrow as new risks emerge. Equally, user awareness and digital literacy will play a crucial role in shaping outcomes. Regulation can set boundaries, but responsible engagement must come from both providers and users. As India positions itself as a major digital economy, the challenge will be to ensure that innovation does not outpace accountability—and that the promise of online gaming is realised without compromising public interest.

GOVERNANCE
GRID



KDP RAO

THE WRITER IS A FORMER ADDITIONAL CHIEF SECRETARY OF CHHATTISGARH

Federalism in India is not merely a constitutional design—it is a constantly negotiated political reality shaped by power, resources and trust

Testing India's Federal Compact

Rising tensions between the Centre and opposition-ruled states over fiscal devolution, governance and political friction are once again testing the resilience of India's federal structure

Federalism in India has often come under stress on account of the unitary nature of the Constitution, fiscal structures, and issues of governance. The opposition-ruled states, over the last few years, have intensified their demand for more autonomy due to specific problems and structural imbalances. The three-day special session of Parliament held last week witnessed fiery speeches by law-makers from regional parties focusing on the federal structure and state-specific interests. The situation once again highlighted the importance of Centre-State relations.

With regard to fiscal matters, southern states (Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Kerala, Telangana) have a grievance that they contribute disproportionately high taxes (income tax, GST, corporate) but receive lower shares from the divisible pool. As argued, the Finance Commission formula rewards population and backwardness more than performance, which the southern states have shown through better governance indicators like higher literacy, lower fertility, and higher GDP contribution. The rise in Centrally Sponsored Schemes (CSS), with strict conditions reducing state flexibility in spending, has made some states insecure, as increased centralisation in the welfare narrative—for example, direct benefit transfers—dents their local political leverage. The post-GST (2017) effects have worsened the situation, as the 15th FC and the upcoming 16th FC are seen by states as unfair. The imposition of limits and higher interest on state borrowings is believed to have pushed states like Kerala, Punjab, and West Bengal into a tight fiscal position, and the same is perceived as politically motivated.

The increasing outreach of the Centre on legislative and administrative matters related to the State List or Concurrent subjects has apparently added fuel to the fire. For example, the farm laws of 2020, education policies like NEP 2020, and the NIA Act, etc., have led to friction, with the result that



Cooperative federalism must move beyond rhetoric, grounded instead in mutual respect between national and regional aspirations

some states have challenged central laws in the Supreme Court. Moreover, some states have also alleged an uncooperative disposition from Governors in approvals, so much so that the Supreme Court had to intervene.

According to experts, the current system of financial devolution is based on the constitutional Finance Commission's recommendations aimed at equitability to help the poorer states. Moreover, a strong Centre is needed for national priorities, infrastructure, and reducing regional disparities. Southern states also benefit from central schemes, defence, infrastructure, and market access.

The states' demands are mainly: a higher share in tax devolution, from the present 41% to 50%; inclusion of cesses and surcharges in the divisible pool; more fiscal autonomy; and fewer conditions on funds. The scenario is not new; similar demands arose in the 1970s-80s and, as a matter of fact, ever since regional parties began calling the shots in national politics through coalitions from the 1990s to 2004, the demand for greater autonomy or the assertion of regional interests has become almost a political sentiment. Now, the intensity has only increased because of various triggers, including the recent delimitation Bill, 2026.

Dr. Ambedkar, the chief architect of the Constitution, emphasised the need for a

strong Centre with a flexible federation. He preferred the expression "Union of States" over "Federation" to define India. While rejecting the rigid federal structure of the US, he favoured a dual polity that has both the character of a Union and a federation, so that national unity and security could be safeguarded at any cost. Hence, the emergency provisions, the Seventh Schedule, and residuary powers resting with the Centre, overriding states' legislative and executive powers. In the United States, for example, states enjoy absolute autonomy with dual sovereignty and separate constitutions, with rare interference from the federal government headed by the President. A similar political arrangement is unthinkable in India—a nation with diverse cultures, languages, religions, and a vast majority of marginalised classes.

The Supreme Court has exclusive jurisdiction to resolve disputes between the Centre and the states and has accordingly laid down principles of constitutional law in different cases. In *State of West Bengal v. Union of India* (1963), the apex court held that the Indian Constitution is not a pure federation like the USA and that it has a strong unitary bias. But equally, in another landmark judgement (*S.R. Bommai v. Union of India* (1994)), the court held that federalism is a

part of the basic structure and that states are not mere appendices of the Centre. Though the Supreme Court, over time, has expanded its role to strengthen federalism by upholding states' taxing powers and placing limitations on the powers of Governors, it often leans towards the Centre in the interest of unity and security of the nation—a constitutional obligation the Centre is exclusively entrusted with by design.

A deeper study is necessary to appreciate the subtle realities. For example, contrary to allegations of interference by the Centre, states are effectively independent in almost all matters of governance and legislation within their jurisdiction. The central government neither supervises nor controls the states in this regard unless dictated by national interests—a rarity. Moreover, the Centre helps the states through centrally sponsored development schemes and also supports states in times of disasters. Most importantly, the All-India Services—the "steel frame" of India—state civil services, and all public servants in the state are absolutely under the control of state governments. On the other hand, the Central government depends on states to draw civil servants to work for the Government of India on deputation, since it does not have a cadre of its own. One can go on counting the ben-

efits the states enjoy. Problems also have a political dimension. When there is competition between national and regional parties, issues translate into questions of federal structure. For example, when it was politically feasible, even chief ministers of opposition-ruled states had cordial relations with Prime Ministers in the past, and Centre-State relations were never an issue. Then it was "cooperative federalism". Conversely, when political equations were hostile, a cold war set in, escalating issues into constitutional questions.

Politics is the art of the possible, they say. There is no good politics or bad politics any more than there is a good politician or a bad politician. However, politics cannot be detrimental to national unity; rather, it should advance the interests of the nation as a whole beyond sectarian concerns. More than between the Centre and the states, it is between national and regional parties that cordial relations need to be established. National parties have a wider appeal and a broader agenda for the entire country, while regional parties prioritise local interests; as such, both should respect each other and address discord with a spirit of accommodation.

Institutional reforms can help address the grievances of the states. Greater fiscal autonomy through higher devolution and reduced CSS conditions can ease tensions significantly. Effective functioning of the Inter-State Council (Sarkaria Commission), revisiting the role of Governors (Punchhi Commission), and prior consultation on central legislations are equally important to improve Centre-State relations. States should also engage in SWOT analysis in order to work in tandem with the Centre. To sum up, the position of the Central government as the leader of the Indian republic is non-negotiable, and the uni-federal system of the Constitution unequivocally envisages a predominant role for the Central government, no matter which party is in power.

Views expressed are personal

WORN
WISDOM



MITALI MADHUSMITA

THE WRITER IS A RETIRED IRS OFFICER WHO SERVED AS THE PRINCIPAL CHIEF COMMISSIONER OF INCOME TAX IN ANDHRA PRADESH AND TELANGANA

Elegance is not what you wear, but how you choose—and how responsibly you live with those choices

Beyond What We Wear

From hand-me-down childhood wardrobes to modern sustainability debates, fashion is less about appearance and more about choices that reflect values, identity and responsibility



Sustainable fashion is not a trend—it is a return to balance

they were given away! The only other arsenal at my disposal—my battle gear, to say—was a dash of lipstick.

Elegant fashion and demeanour is a way of life for most successful and happy people. A happy state of mind does not necessarily come from clothes or accessories; it is about how you carry yourself and deal with people. Inner happiness radiates through your entire being, and the glow is brighter than any gold or silver accessories. Elegance is also certainly about sustainable fashion; headlines are made when a Bollywood or Hollywood star repeats an outfit, which is something we have practised for centuries! Man used mucus produced by sea snails, vegetables, flowers, and plant extracts such as coffee, indigo, avocado and onion skin, chamomile, turmeric, marigold, madder, and so on to give cloth a touch of colour. Humans have, through the ages, discovered tried and tested ways in which

one can lead a sustainably fashionable life. Leaves, bark, and animal skin were used in prehistoric times. Vegetation such as flax, jute, and cotton was systematically improved upon to produce attire. Muslin, also known as 'baft hawa' (woven air) or 'Aab-e-rawan' (flowing water), woven by the weavers of undivided Bengal and affordable only to the Mughals and aristocrats, attracted the attention of the European nobility for its finesse, breathability, and luxuriousness.

Things changed post the Industrial Revolution. According to the UNEP, the fashion industry is responsible for up to one-fifth of all industrial water pollution—most clothes today are produced in poorer countries where regulation is weak and enforcement weaker still. Wastewater is dumped directly into rivers and streams; a potent cocktail of carcinogenic chemicals, dyes, salts, and heavy metals that not only

poison the land but also the water sources of all those—both people and animals—who rely on them. The rivers in Bangladesh's capital, Dhaka, have turned black due to the sludge produced by textile dyeing and processing factories. One of the biggest sources of harmful microfibres found in our oceans is cleaning synthetic fibres in washing machines, thereby releasing harmful microfibres into all water bodies. Bleached wood pulp, required to produce viscose and rayon fibres, leads to the danger of deforestation. Similarly, though cotton is not a man-made fibre, it is still harmful as the crop is a water- and insecticide-guzzler.

The way to sustainable fashion that is in tune with nature is through the three Rs: Reduce, Reuse, and Recycle. The young generation is attuned to the need of the hour. Their mantra is cool, comfortable, and sustainable fashion. Gone are the days when one splurged on wedding attire, only to abandon it later. Renting wedding costumes is doable. Wearing trousers multiple times in mild climate conditions is doable. The sector is poised for regulatory compliance. While India has formal Extended Producer Responsibility (EPR) obligations for plastic and electronic waste, similar rules for textile waste are in the pipeline under the Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change (MoEFCC). The government is pushing producers to take back used products, facilitate recycling and reprocessing, and reduce landfill waste. The need of the hour is fashion with a conscience!

At the end of the day, as the Stoic philosopher Epictetus would say: "You are not your body and hairstyle, but your capacity for choosing well. If your choices are beautiful, you will be too."

Views expressed are personal

LEBANON, ISRAEL TO RESUME RARE DIRECT TALKS IN WASHINGTON

Lebanon decries Israeli demolition of homes in areas occupied after ceasefire

BEIRUT: In areas of southern Lebanon it has occupied since agreeing last week to a ceasefire with Hezbollah, the Israeli army has been destroying homes it says were used as outposts by the Iran-backed militant group.

But the demolitions are happening on such a wide scale that residents, Lebanese officials and U.N. peacekeepers are increasingly worried that large numbers of people displaced by the latest war will have nowhere to return if the fragile truce holds.

From a hill overlooking Beit Lif — about 4 km (2.5 mi) north of Lebanon's border with Israel — Associated Press journalists could see that the village, once home to a few thousand people, had been almost entirely flattened.

"They were demolishing it gradually until they reached the main square and now, as you can see, there are no more



Supporters wave Hezbollah flags and make victory signs as they celebrate in the southern village of Zefta

FILE PHOTO

houses," said Hassan Sweidan, a resident of a neighboring village.

Lebanese officials plan to raise the issue of widespread demolitions on Thursday when they hold ceasefire talks with their Israeli counterparts in Washington — part of the first direct negotiations between the

two countries in decades.

Because of security concerns and limited access, neither UN peacekeepers nor Lebanese officials have been able to conduct a detailed survey of the villages where demolitions are taking place.

But observers have described entire residential

Highlights

» Lebanon and Israel were set to begin a second session of direct talks in Washington

» On March 2, two days after the US and Israel launched the war with Iran, Hezbollah entered the fray by firing missiles into northern Israel

» The fighting has killed around 2,300 people in Lebanon

neighborhoods in multiple villages being systematically destroyed.

On March 2, two days after the US and Israel launched the war with Iran, Hezbollah entered the fray by firing missiles into northern Israel.

The group had been under pressure by the Lebanese gov-

ernment to disarm following its previous war with Israel in 2024, but refused to do so.

Israel responded with an intense bombing campaign and ground invasion of Lebanon that prompted hundreds of thousands of people to flee the southern part of the country. The fighting has killed around 2,300 people in Lebanon, including hundreds of women and children. The fighting was mostly halted by a 10-day ceasefire that began Friday. But both sides have carried out strikes since then. Hezbollah has justified its attacks in part by pointing to the Israeli military's destruction of houses.

Israeli officials have said they intend to occupy parts of southern Lebanon, and the military has issued maps of a "forward defense line" that extends several miles into Lebanon and encompasses dozens of villages whose residents have not been allowed to return.

AGENCIES

Pakistan minister, US envoy discuss efforts for 2nd round of US-Iran talks

ISLAMABAD: Interior Minister Mohsin Naqvi on Thursday met US Charge d'Affaires to Pakistan, Natalie Baker and discussed ongoing diplomatic efforts to hold a second round of US-Iran talks in Islamabad, according to an official statement.

The meeting comes amid stepped-up diplomatic engagements aimed at bringing Tehran and Washington to the negotiating table, possibly by the weekend.

Naqvi and Baker held an "important meeting" during which they exchanged detailed views on the latest regional situation and discussed diplomatic efforts related to the proposed second round of peace talks, the interior ministry said in a statement.

Naqvi welcomed US President Donald Trump's initiative to extend the ceasefire, calling it a "welcome development" that made significant progress towards reducing tensions.

"We also hope for positive progress from Iran's side," the minister said.

Naqvi and Baker empha-



Representational Image

sised the need to maintain diplomatic channels for a lasting resolution to the West Asia conflict.

According to the statement, Naqvi told Baker that Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif and Chief of Defence Forces (CDF) Field Marshal Asim Munir were making "all-out efforts at every level" to facilitate a peaceful outcome.

"It is hoped that both parties will give a chance to a diplomatic and peaceful solution," the minister said. The meeting, the second between the

two this week, took place amid uncertainty over the talks, with Islamabad under tight security for the proposed engagement.

On Monday, Naqvi held separate meetings with Baker and Iran's Ambassador to Pakistan Reza Amiri Moghadam, to discuss arrangements for the second round of Islamabad Talks. Trump on Wednesday extended the ceasefire with Iran indefinitely at the request of Pakistan to give Tehran's leadership more time to prepare a unified proposal to end the war.

AGENCIES

US military seizes another oil tanker associated with Iran

DUBAI: The US military on Thursday seized another tanker associated with the smuggling of Iranian oil, ratcheting up a standoff with Iran a day after its paramilitary Revolutionary Guards took control of two vessels in the crucial Strait of Hormuz.

The Defence Department released video footage of US forces on the deck of the oil tanker Majestic X, which was seized in the Indian Ocean.

"We will continue global maritime enforcement to dis-

rupt illicit networks and interdict vessels providing material support to Iran, wherever they operate," a Pentagon statement said.

Ship-tracking data showed the Majestic X in the Indian Ocean between Sri Lanka and Indonesia, roughly the same location as the oil tanker Tifani, earlier seized by American forces. It had been bound for Zhoushan, China.

There was no immediate response from Iran on the news of the seizure.

The seizure comes a day

after Iran attacked three cargo ships in the strait, capturing two of them, in a move that intensified its assault on shipping in the key waterway through which 20 per cent of the world's traded oil passes in peacetime.

The Majestic X is a Guyana-flagged oil tanker. It previously had been named Phonix and had been sanctioned by the US Treasury Department in 2024 for smuggling Iranian crude oil in contravention of US sanctions on the Islamic Republic.

AGENCIES

Iran's exiled crown prince Reza Pahlavi splattered with red liquid in Berlin

BERLIN: Iran's exiled Crown Prince Reza Pahlavi was splattered with red liquid on Thursday as he left a building in Berlin.

Pahlavi had just departed a news briefing, during which he criticised the ceasefire between the United States and Iran, when the incident occurred outside Germany's federal news conference building.

He appeared unhurt by the liquid coating the back of his blazer and neck, and waved to his supporters before he got into a car that drove away. Police said the liquid appeared to be tomato juice. The alleged perpetrator, whose name was



Iran's exiled crown prince Reza Pahlavi

not released in line with German privacy rules, was immediately detained by police.

Pahlavi, 65, is the son of Iran's former shah, who was so widely hated that millions

took to the streets in 1979 to force him from power. Nevertheless, Pahlavi is trying to position himself as a player in his country's future, though it's unclear how much support he has in Iran after he has been in exile for nearly 50 years.

Hundreds of his supporters demonstrated Thursday near Germany's parliament building, according to German news agency dpa.

Pahlavi argued Thursday that the ceasefire agreement assumes the Iranian government's behaviour will change and "you're going to deal with people who all of a sudden have become pragmatists."

AGENCIES

EU okays \$106 bn loan package to help Ukraine

This comes after Hungary lifts its veto

BRUSSELS: The European

Union on Thursday approved a massive loan package to help Ukraine meet its economic and military needs for the next two years, the bloc's Cypriot presidency said, after Hungary lifted its veto. The EU also approved a new draft of sanctions against Russia over its war on Ukraine. The measures were prepared early this year and set to be announced in February to mark the fourth anniversary of the conflict, but Hungary and Slovakia opposed the move.

Hungary and Slovakia have been locked in a feud with

Ukraine since Russian oil deliveries to the two EU countries were halted in January after a pipeline was damaged.

Ukraine desperately needs the 90-billion-euro loan package to prop up its war-ravaged economy and help keep Russian forces at bay. Hungary angered its EU partners by reneging on a December deal to provide the funds. "Today the Council approved the final element needed to allow for the disbursement of the 90-billion-euro loan for Ukraine," Cypriot Finance Minister Makis Kervanos said.

AGENCIES

Russian oil to Slovakia resumes flowing through pipeline

BRATISLAVA: The flow of Russian oil to Slovakia through the Druzhba pipeline that crosses Ukraine has resumed, Slovak Economy Minister Denis Saková said Thursday, a breakthrough in an issue that has caused a major diplomatic spat in Europe.

The development is expected to unblock a large financial assistance package for war-ravaged Ukraine.

Populist Slovak Prime Minister Robert Fico welcomed the development, calling it "good news."

AGENCIES

WILDFIRES



Firefighters respond to the Pineland Road Fire in southeast Georgia as state's two biggest wildfires together have burned more than 33 square miles (85 square kilometers), and at least four other smaller fires have been reported in the state.

AP/PTI

US BLOCKADE SHAKEN THE GLOBAL ECONOMY

Strait of Hormuz shows how everything now about leverage

LONDON: Iran's military might was never going to be a match for the US and Israel. So instead it turned to the highly effective weapon it has at its disposal — geography.

Blocking off the Strait of Hormuz has shaken the global economy. It has doubled the price of a barrel of crude oil, which has a knock-on effect on the price the rest of the world pays for everything from fuel to heating and food to holidays.

It also made Donald Trump have a rethink. The world is now waiting to see what happens next in a stretch of water which carries around 20% of the world's oil and liquefied natural gas.

For Iran, the Strait of Hormuz has been an extremely valuable geopolitical asset. And its surprisingly strong negotiating position demonstrates a classic principle of game theory, the mathematical study of strategic interactions. This principle, sometimes referred to as Rubinstein bargaining, basically says that during a conflict, each side's



The sun rises behind a tanker anchored in the Strait of Hormuz off the coast of Qeshm Island

Iran will certainly be badly off if the war continues, using up its stockpiles of missiles and drones while its infrastructure gets bombed

strength depends on two things: how badly off it would be without a resolution, and how impatient it is to get things resolved.

Iran will certainly be badly off if the war continues, using up its stockpiles of missiles and drones

while its infrastructure gets bombed. But dictatorships can afford to be patient, crushing dissent if it arises.

For the US, continuing with the conflict means spending billions more taxpayer dollars on those bombs, while a blocked-

off Strait of Hormuz risks more rises in the price of fuel paid by American motorists. With mid-term elections coming up in November, perhaps the White House will lose patience quickly.

The Strait of Hormuz, then, has played an enormous role in the conflict so far. The US's position is much weaker than first thought because of a stretch of water the world can't do without.

AGENCIES

World Briefs

EX-PHILIPPINE PRESIDENT TO FACE TRIAL ON CRIMES AGAINST HUMANITY

THE HAGUE: Judges at the International Criminal Court on Thursday confirmed crimes against humanity charges against former Philippine president Rodrigo Duterte for deadly anti-drugs crackdowns he allegedly oversaw while in office. A three-judge panel found unanimously there were "substantial grounds" to believe the ex-leader was responsible for dozens of murders, first as mayor of the southern Philippine city of Davao and later when he was president. Duterte, who served as president from 2016 to 2022, was arrested in the Philippines last year and flown to the Hague, where the global court is located. He denies the charges against him.

TEENAGER BECOMES FIRST CONGO VIRUS FATALITY IN PAKISTAN'S KARACHI

KARACHI: A 17-year-old boy died on Thursday at a hospital in Pakistan's Karachi city after contracting the Congo virus, becoming the first confirmed victim of the disease this year, health authorities said. "The boy died today. He was brought to the hospital on Monday with high fever," Sindh Infectious Diseases Hospital and Research Centre Director Dr Abdul Wahid Rajput said. "His blood samples were taken and sent to Aga Khan University Hospital for testing. He was transferred to the Infectious Diseases Hospital on Tuesday for further treatment after the presence of the Congo virus was confirmed in the patient," he added. The boy, who worked at a livestock farm, showed symptoms of Crimean-Congo Haemorrhagic Fever (CCHF) and was moved to an isolation unit, Rajput said. The Congo virus is a tick-borne viral disease that can cause severe hemorrhagic fever in humans.

यूनियन बैंक Union Bank of India

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DRAFT DEMAND NOTICE UNDER SEC.13 (2)
Ref. 43560/6430/2025-26 Date: 11/03/2026
Place : NEW DELHI

To
1. M/s Pratyya Services Pvt. Ltd.
Through its Directors
Mr. Vikas Verma
Regd. Office - H. No. 151 & 152, Gali No. 8, Deepak Vihar, Najafgarh, New Delhi-110043
Also at
Add : Corp. Add - 308, 3rd Floor DDA 5 Building District Centre Janakpuri, New Delhi-110058
Also at
Add : 110-112, First Floor, Suneja Tower-1 District Centre, New Delhi-110058
2. Mr. Vikas Verma S/o Sh. Rajender Prasad Verma,
R/o H. No. 151 Gali No. 8, Deepak Vihar, Najafgarh, New Delhi-110043
Sir/Madam,
Notice under Sec.13 (2) read with Sec.13 (3) of Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002.
You the addressee No.1 herein have availed the following credit facilities from our RAJOURI GARDEN Branch and failed to pay the dues/installment / interest/operate the accounts satisfactorily and hence, in terms of the RBI guidelines as to the Income Recognition and Prudential Accounting Norms, your account/s has /have been classified as Non-Performing Asset as on 08/03/2026. As on 08/03/2026 a sum of Rs.19,43,798.63 (Rupees Nineteen Lakh Forty-Three Thousand Seven Hundred Ninety-Eight and Sixty-Three Paise) and interest thereon is outstanding in your account/s.
The particulars of amount due to the Bank from No. 1 of you in respect of the aforesaid account/s are as under:

Type of Facility	Outstanding amount as on date of NPA i.e. as 08/03/2026	Un applied interest w.e.f. 08/03/2026 to 10/03/2026	Penal Interest (Simple)	Cost/ Charges incurred by Bank	Total dues
VL004	18,89,932.00	53,866.63			19,43,798.63
Total Dues					19,43,798.63

To secure the repayment of the monies due or of the monies that may become due to the Bank, M/s. Pratyya Services Pvt Ltd (Applicant) & Mr. Vikas Verma (Guarantor) had executed documents on 08.11.2023 and created security interest by way of:
Hypothecation of movable Property - Four -Wheeler/Car described herein below:
✓ Maker/Brand : MAHINDRA
✓ Model : XUV 700
✓ Registration No : HR06BE6999
✓ Engine No.: ZTP4K46622
✓ Chassis No.: MA1NE2ZTP6PK16325
Therefore, You are hereby called upon in terms of section 13(2) of the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002, to pay a sum of Rs. 19,43,798.63 together with further interest and Charges at the contractual rate as per the terms and conditions of loan documents executed by you and discharge your liabilities in full within 60 days from the date of receipt of this notice, failing which, we shall be constrained to enforce the aforesaid securities by exercising any or all of the rights given under the said Act.
As per section 13(13) of the Act, on receipt of this notice you are restrained / prevented from disposing of or dealing with the above securities without the consent of the bank.
Your attention is invited to provisions of sub-section (8) of Section 13 of the SARFAESI in respect of respect of time available, to redeem the secured assets.

Yours Faithfully
Authorised Officer

No plan yet to raise petrol & diesel prices, says Govt

Kotak projected a Rs 25-28 a litre increase in price based on crude oil staying close to \$120 per barrel

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The government on Thursday dismissed reports suggesting petrol and diesel prices may be hiked by Rs 25-28 a litre soon after assembly elections, saying there is no such proposal under consideration.

“There are some news reports suggesting a price hike of petrol and diesel. It is hereby clarified that there is no such proposal under consideration by the government,” the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas said in a post on X.

The clarification came after a report by Kotak Institutional Equities hinted of a steep increase in petrol and diesel prices once the polling for assembly elections in states like West Bengal ends on April 29.

Kotak projected a Rs 25-28 a litre increase in price based on crude oil staying close to \$120 per barrel.

The ministry said such reports are “designed to create fear and panic amongst the citizens and are mischievous and misleading.”

“In fact, India is the only country where petrol and diesel prices haven't increased in the



The clarification came after a report by Kotak Institutional Equities hinted of a steep increase in petrol and diesel prices once the polling for assembly elections

last four years,” it said.

“Government of India and oil PSUs have taken relentless steps in order to insulate the Indian citizens from steep increases in international prices.”

International oil prices spiked after US and Israel attacked Iran on February 28, and Tehran's sweeping retaliation that effectively shut the

Strait of Hormuz - one of the world's most critical energy arteries, linking the Persian Gulf to global markets and handling roughly a fifth of global oil trade along with significant volumes of liquefied natural gas.

After the Iran war, oil prices spiked from around \$70 per barrel to \$119 before seeing some correction. Renewed ten-

Highlights

» The oil ministry said such reports are 'designed to create fear and panic amongst the citizens and are mischievous and misleading'

» 'In fact, India is the only country where petrol and diesel prices haven't increased in the last four years,' it said

» After the Iran war, oil prices spiked from around \$70/barrel to \$119 before seeing some correction. Renewed tensions have pushed Brent crude - to \$103-106 per barrel

sions have pushed Brent - the world's most known crude oil benchmark - to \$103-106 per barrel.

Despite a more than 50 per cent rise in input crude oil prices, petrol and diesel rates have remained unchanged in India. Petrol is priced at Rs 94.77 a litre in the national capital and diesel comes for Rs 87.67.

Infosys Q4 net profit up 21% to ₹8,501 cr, guides 1.5-3.5% revenue growth for FY27

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: IT major Infosys on Thursday reported a 20.8 per cent rise in consolidated net profit to Rs 8,501 crore in the January-March quarter and guided for 1.5 to 3.5 per cent revenue growth for FY27, pinning its optimism on momentum in financial services, utilities, and AI services.

The top management spoke of the calendar year starting on a strong note, but pointed out that there was a “change in economic environment” amid the West Asia conflict, though things appear to be stabilising now.

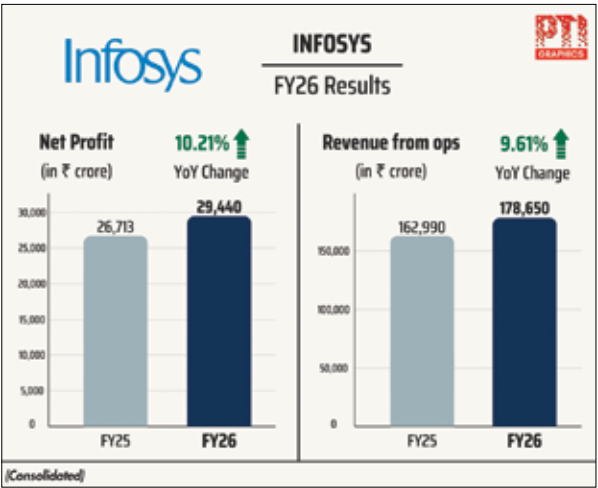
The company's revenue from operations increased 13.4 per cent to Rs 46,402 crore in Q4 FY26 compared to Rs 40,925 crore in the year-ago period.

In the full 2025-26 fiscal year, Infosys' net profit climbed 10.21 per cent to Rs 29,440 crore from Rs 26,713 crore in 2024-25.

Its revenue from operations in FY26 rose 9.61 per cent to Rs 178,650 crore.

For FY27, Infosys has given a revenue growth forecast of 1.5 to 3.5 per cent in constant currency terms.

“We had strong growth in financial services, in communications, and in manufacturing from the industry side and in Europe from the geography side. As we look ahead to the financial year 2027, we see large opportunities in AI services. We expect acceleration of



growth in financial services and in the energy, utility, resources and services vertical.

“With the Iran war, there was a change in the economic environment... (but) there seem to be paths towards things stabilising. What we understand, (through) talking to people in the market and the clients, is that the underlying resilience of some of the economies where we have big markets is pretty good. The economies are doing well. There are good investments. AI is growing well,” Infosys CEO and MD Salil Parekh said.

Infosys' ADR, however, traded 5 per cent lower in the US pre-market session.

Infosys peers have pointed out a volatile macroeconomic environment, rising uncertainties, geopolitical risks, and AI fears.

HCLTech management

flagged a highly volatile demand environment shadowed by tariffs and softened discretionary spending, while Wipro described a challenging macro environment as the new normal.

The total employee headcount stood at 328,594 at the end of Q4 FY26, marking a sequential drop of 8,440 staff from 3,37,034 in Q3 FY26, but an increase (of 5,016 staff) compared to 3,23,578 in Q4 FY25.

Infosys Chief Financial Officer Jayesh Sanghrajka attributed the quarterly fluctuations to a softer volume environment and the broader demand-supply equation playing out in the market.

He noted that Infosys successfully onboarded over 20,000 freshers in FY26. Looking ahead, the company plans to maintain this momentum, setting a target to hire 20,000

freshers in FY27.

“We announced (a target of) 20,000 for FY26, and we have hired more than 20,000 freshers from the market. This year, we are expecting at least 20,000 freshers to be hired,” Sanghrajka said.

The company secured large deals with a total contract value (TCV) of USD 3.2 billion in Q4. For the full year FY26, large deal TCV hit USD 14.9 billion, of which 55 per cent was net new.

The core markets of North America and Europe registered a year-on-year growth of 4.1 per cent in constant currency (CC) in Q4 FY26. Rest of the World (RoW) markets grew by 5 per cent, while the India market remained flat.

Life sciences led the Q4 sectoral growth at 11.6 per cent, followed by communication at 9 per cent and energy, utilities, resources and services at 6.7 per cent.

Financial Services posted a moderate growth of 2.9 per cent, manufacturing grew 1.3 per cent, and retail was nearly flat at 0.5 per cent. The hi-tech vertical was the only segment to report a decline, shrinking by 1.2 per cent.

Amid some media reports that the Board was set to review the succession plan and that Parekh may get a shorter extension, not another full term, the top management remained tight-lipped to a question on CEO tenure. Parekh's current five-year term is until March 2027.

Reserve Bank purchased \$7.4 bn in spot market in Feb

MUMBAI: The RBI net purchased \$7,409 billion from the spot currency market in February, according to its monthly bulletin released on Thursday. On a gross basis, the central bank purchased \$21.403 billion and sold \$13.994 billion during the month. This marked the second straight month of net dollar purchases, following a net buy of \$2.526 billion in January, after seven consecutive months of net sales.

Earlier, the RBI had net sold \$10.02 billion in December, \$9,710 billion in November, \$11,877 billion in October, \$7,910 billion in September, \$7,695 billion in August, \$2,540 billion in July and \$3.661 billion in June.

The rupee rose from early February 2026 after the announcement of an interim India-US trade deal but weakened in March amid escalating tensions in West Asia. The RBI said implied option volatility moderated in H2 of the fiscal compared to H1, though it remained elevated due to persistent risk-off sentiment and geopolitical tensions.

To maintain orderly forex market conditions, the RBI on March 27, 2026 capped the net open position in INR (NOP-INR) of authorised dealers in the onshore deliverable market at \$100 million at end of each day. Overall, the rupee fell by 6.2 per cent against the US dollar in H2 FY26 & by 3.3 per cent in REER terms from September 2025 to February 2026. AGENCIES

Indian economy steady despite West Asia conflict pushing energy prices and input costs higher

MUMBAI: Indian economy remains stable despite West Asia conflict pushing energy prices and input costs higher, and supply chain disruptions posing upside risks for inflation, according to an RBI Bulletin released on Thursday.

An article published in the Reserve Bank's April Bulletin said that the conflict in West Asia has intensified pressures on global supply chains in March, with some easing observed in the first half of April.

It also said that domestic economic activity displayed resilience in many segments, with a slowdown in a few others.

“If the conflict persists and supply chains are not restored early, it may create challenges to the domestic economy in the form of higher energy costs, input cost pressures, disruption in trade flows and financial mar-



ket spillovers,” it said.

Though inflation remains within the tolerance band, upside risks have increased, driven by supply-side disruptions, including weather-related uncertainties, said the article on ‘State of the Economy’.

Possible second-round effects with the supply shock transforming itself into a demand shock also warrant careful and continuous assessment, it added. “The temporary two-week ceasefire between the US and Iran has, however,

provided some breather to the global economy. The strong macroeconomic fundamentals should support the Indian economy to maintain its resilience to withstand such shocks,” it said.

The article further said the Indian economy continues to hold its ground despite facing a major supply shock due to the conflict in West Asia.

In March, available high-frequency indicators of economic activity displayed divergent trends -- demand conditions remained resilient, despite some pockets of slowdown in economic momentum.

The rural economy played an important role in sustaining resilience in demand in March, the article said. Automobile sales growth was driven by strong retail demand supported by post-GST momentum.

Increased electric vehicle

(EV) demand, particularly in the two-wheeler segment, also contributed to the overall momentum.

The article noted that the ongoing conflict in West Asia impacted the trade negatively, as India relies heavily on Gulf shipping routes.

The conflict led to an average 54 per cent decline in exports and imports from West Asia in March. Imports from Russia saw a sequential uptick.

The money market and bond yields moderated after the temporary ceasefire in West Asia. “A slowdown in imports and expansion in exports narrowed the trade deficit to a nine-month low. Foreign portfolio investment (FPI) flows remained volatile, although net foreign direct investment (FDI) turned positive in February,” the article said. PTI

Maruti Suzuki clocks highest-ever annual production volume of 23.4 lakh units in FY26

NEW DELHI: Car market leader Maruti Suzuki India Ltd (MSIL) on Thursday said it clocked its highest-ever annual production volume of 23.4 lakh units in FY 2025-26.

The feat makes the company the only passenger vehicles manufacturer in India to achieve such record production volume as per SIAM data, MSIL said in a statement.

The company has also become the only firm among Suzuki Motor Corporation's global automobile manufacturing facilities, to achieve this landmark volume, it added.

Commenting on the record, MSIL MD & CEO Hisashi Takeuchi said very few compa-



nies across the world have been able to manufacture such large volumes in a single country.

“This achievement is the outcome of a carefully nurtured automobile ecosystem built over four and a half decades. At its

foundation lies the mutual trust and long-standing collaboration that we share with our employees, vendor and dealer partners,” he said. This ecosystem supported by the current government's policy environment, like

the rollout of GST 2.0, strengthened market confidence and stimulated demand at a critical time allowing the company to manufacture record-high units, Takeuchi said.

He further said, “Our parent company, Suzuki Motor Corporation's strong belief in India's growth story, along with an increased focus on developing India as an export hub, is enabling us to further expand our production capacity. We aim to scale it to about 40 lakh units per annum.”

MSIL said its models Dzire, Fronx, Swift, Ertiga and Baleno were the most produced models during the year, with each crossing the 2 lakh unit mark. PTI

Union Bank consolidated PAT rises 9.83% to ₹5,503 cr in Q4 FY26

Union Bank of India posted a 6.6% year-on-year rise in the standalone profit at Rs 5,316 crore for the quarter

MUMBAI: State-owned Union Bank of India on Thursday reported a 9.83 per cent rise in March quarter's consolidated profit after tax (PAT) at Rs 5,503.61 crore on lower provision and improved asset quality.

The city-headquartered bank posted a 6.6 per cent year-on-year rise in the standalone profit at Rs 5,316 crore for the quarter.

Its core net interest income (NII) declined 1.14 per cent on-year to Rs 9,406 crore during the quarter on the back of narrowing of net interest margin to 2.64 per cent from 2.87



per cent, and a 9.74 per cent growth in advances.

Managing director and chief executive Ashesh Pandey said the bank's credit growth is slower than the industry's 15.6 per cent for fiscal 2025-26, and it aims to match that or take a

CLOSER LOOK

» Its core net interest income (NII) declined 1.14 per cent on-year to Rs 9,406 crore during the quarter

» 'Bank's credit growth is slower than industry's 15.6% for FY26, and it aims to take it a notch above in FY27'

» Asset quality of the bank saw an improvement with gross NPAs ratio declining to 2.82% as on March 31, 2026

notch above in fiscal 2026-27.

Pandey said the bank has a corporate loan book pipeline of Rs 55,000 crore in the current financial year, and Rs 30,000 crore of sanctions.

Non-interest income of the bank also reduced by 2.64 per

cent in Q4 to Rs 5,412 crore, as treasury income slumped.

However, on sequential basis, it rose by 19.18 per cent, supported by a spike in recoveries in written-off accounts.

Provisions declined dur-

ing the quarter, leading to a moderation in credit cost, as improved asset quality and lower slippages reduced the need for banks to set aside funds for potential loan losses.

In the March quarter, provision declined by 2.76 per cent year-on-year to Rs 2,640 crore, from Rs 2,715 crore a year ago. Similarly, credit cost declined to 0.16 per cent from 0.69 per cent, according to the investor presentation.

Asset quality of the bank saw an improvement with gross non-performing asset (NPA) ratio declining to 2.82 per cent

as on March 31, 2026, from 3.06 per cent on December 31, 2025, and 3.60 per cent a year ago.

Fresh slippages of the bank reduced in Q4 FY26 to Rs 2,023 crore from Rs 2,483 crore in the year-ago period.

The major slippages during the quarter came from MSME loans worth Rs 895 crore, followed by agriculture loans of Rs 742 crore.

Also, the board recommended a dividend of Rs 5 per equity share of Rs 10 each for financial year 2025-26. The payment is subject to shareholders' approval. PTI

Warner Bros stakeholders approve \$81 billion sale of company to Paramount

NEW YORK: Warner Bros Discovery's shareholders approved a \$81 billion sale of the company to Skydance-owned Paramount on Thursday, propelling a mega merger that could vastly reshape Hollywood and the wider media landscape closer to the finish line.

In a vote held on Thursday, the vast majority of Warner shareholders approved of the deal, per a preliminary count. Paramount wants to buy all of Warner — including



HBO Max, cult favourite titles like “Harry Potter” and even CNN — for \$31 a share in cash. A greenlight from company shareholders increases the likelihood of that becoming a reality. But the deal still faces ongoing regulatory reviews. AGENCIES

Markets extend losses as oil soars over \$100, Sensex tanks 852 points

The rupee extended its losing streak for 4th day, falls 23 paise to 94.01

MUMBAI: Stock markets fell for the second consecutive day on Thursday, with the benchmark Sensex tumbling 852.49 points, as crude oil prices once again breached the \$100 per barrel mark amid stalled US-Iran negotiations.

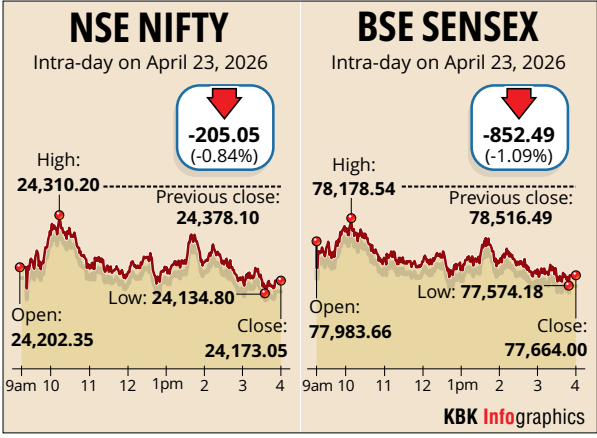
Sustained foreign fund outflows, along with a weak trend in Asian and European equities, also unnerved investors.

The 30-share BSE Sensex tumbled 852.49 points, or 1.09 per cent, to settle at 77,664. During the day, it slumped 942.31 points, or 1.20 per cent, to 77,574.18.

A total of 2,517 stocks declined, while 1,762 advanced and 170 remained unchanged on the BSE.

The 50-share NSE Nifty dropped 205.05 points, or 0.84 per cent, to end at 24,173.05.

“Indian equity markets extended their decline, turning decisively negative as geopolitical tensions intensified. Sentiment deteriorated following stalled Iran peace talks despite US President Donald Trump announcing an indefinite ceasefire extension, which lacked clear confirmation from Iran. “Escalating concerns around tightening control over the Strait of Hormuz and the continuation of the US naval blockade pushed the Middle East situation back to a critical



On the sectoral front, PSU Bank dropped 2.36 per cent, Auto (2.27 per cent), Realty (1.91 per cent), Consumer Discretionary (1.71 per cent), Consumer Durables (1.63 per cent) and Bankex (1.46 per cent).

“Indian markets extended their losing streak, with the Nifty witnessing back-to-back bearish sessions and correcting over 400 points across the last two trading days. The price action reflects a clear shift in market tone - from resilience to risk aversion - as global uncertainties intensify and domestic triggers fail to provide immediate support,” Hariprasad K, Research Analyst and founder, Livelong Wealth, said.

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Highlights

- » A total of 2,517 stocks declined, while 1,762 advanced and 170 remained unchanged on the BSE
- » From the Sensex pack, Trent, Bajaj Finserv, Tech Mahindra, Mahindra & Mahindra, Infosys and HDFC Bank were among the major laggards
- » In contrast, Adani Ports, L&T, Sun Pharma, Bharti Airtel and Bharat Electronics were winners
- » The BSE MidCap Select index declined 0.39 per cent, and the SmallCap Select index dipped 0.34 per cent

The BSE MidCap Select index declined 0.39 per cent, and the SmallCap Select index dipped 0.34 per cent.

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On the other hand, Healthcare jumped 1.66 per cent, Capital Goods (0.40 per cent), Power

(0.40 per cent) and Industrials (0.11 per cent).

“Concerns surrounding disruptions in the Strait of Hormuz have significantly dented investor confidence, introducing a fresh layer of uncertainty into global markets. This has directly translated into a spike in crude oil prices. For an import-dependent economy like India, this creates a dual pressure, rising inflation expectations and stress on corporate margins,” Hariprasad said.

FII offloaded equities worth Rs 2,078.36 crore on Wednesday, according to exchange data.

The rupee extended its losing streak for the fourth consecutive session, settling 23 paise lower at 94.01 on Thursday.

“Domestic equities witnessed a broad-based decline, as elevated crude prices above \$100 per barrel, amid the impasse in US-Iran negotiations, continued to weigh on sentiment. The risk-off mood was further intensified by weak global cues, persistent FII outflows, and a depreciating rupee alongside higher US Treasury yields,” Vinod Nair, Head of Research, Geojit Investments Limited, said.

On Wednesday, Sensex fell 756.84 points, or 0.95 per cent, to settle at 78,516.49. The Nifty dropped 198.50 points, or 0.81 per cent, to 24,378.10.

‘Indian aviation sector to handle about 500 mn passengers by 2030’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

MUMBAI: The Indian aviation sector is estimated to handle about 500 million passengers annually by 2030 and reach nearly 1 billion by 2047, supported by sustained demand and fleet expansion, with over 1,000 aircraft orders in place, a top industry executive said on Thursday.

Speaking at the Airport 360 Expo 2026, which commenced at Bombay Exhibition Centre, the executive said that India is already among the top three domestic aviation markets globally, with passenger traffic reaching around 412 million in 2025, reflecting strong growth momentum.

“We are already one of the top three domestic aviation markets in the world, and we are continuing to grow rapidly. In 2025 itself, we handled about 4 million passengers and 3.5 million of cargo, which is around 20 per cent higher than the pre-COVID levels,” Navi Mumbai International Airport Ltd CEO BVJK Sharma said at the event.

The growth would be rapid, but considering that the historical growth has been 10-12 per cent, it could taper down to 5.6 per cent by 2044, he said.

“But, nevertheless, we will see about 500 million passengers very soon, probably before 2030 and a billion passengers by 2047. Our domestic air travel is expected to grow at 17 per cent to start with, year-on-year and also show a steady, very healthy demand,” he said.



At Navi Mumbai International Airport, capacity is being developed in phases to reach 90 million passengers by 2032

Infrastructure expansion is progressing at pace, with over 160 operational airports and continued investments under National programmes, he said, adding that aviation contributes nearly \$54 billion to the economy and supports millions of jobs, with emerging segments, such as MRO, expected to play a significant role in strengthening the ecosystem.

At Navi Mumbai International Airport, capacity is being developed in phases to reach 90 million passengers by 2032, supported by strong connectivity, digital infrastructure, and integrated planning, he said.

As demand continues to rise, the focus will remain on building scalable, efficient, and

future-ready airport ecosystems to support India's next phase of aviation growth, Sharma added.

Addressing the conference, Sharad Kumar, Chief Advisor, Airports Authority of India, said that India's aviation sector is entering a defining phase where growth must be supported by clear strategic choices.

“Globally, the industry is being shaped by digital transformation, sustainability, and deeper integration across aviation, logistics, tourism, and trade. At the same time, recent geopolitical developments have highlighted the sector's vulnerability, impacting routes, costs, and operational efficiency,” he said.

In this context, India has a strong advantage with rising demand, expanding infrastructure, and a clear vision to scale to around 350 airports by 2047, he said, adding that initiatives, such as UDAN, have strengthened regional connectivity, and the next phase will focus on long-term viability, efficiency, and network integration.

IEX profit grows 11% to ₹129.77 crore in March qtr

NEW DELHI: Indian Energy Exchange (IEX) on Thursday posted around 11 per cent rise in consolidated net profit to Rs 129.77 crore for the March quarter, supported by rise in revenues.

It had logged a net profit of Rs 117.11 crore in the year-ago period, the company said in an exchange filing.

Total income rose to Rs 196.43 crore from Rs 174.59 crore in January-March FY25.

In the entire fiscal year, the profit was at Rs 492.92 crore, up from Rs 429.16 crore as of March 31, 2025.

Total income rose to Rs 746.95 crore from Rs 657.36 crore.

The board of directors has recommended final dividend of Rs 2 per equity share having face value of Re 1 each fully paid-up for the financial year ended March 31, 2026.

In a separate statement, IEX said it traded highest-ever electricity volumes of 141.1 billion units in FY26, posting a year-on-year rise of 17 per cent.

It traded 187.20 lakhs of RECs (renewable energy certificate) during FY26, registering an increase of 5 per cent.

IEX is India's premier electricity exchange providing a nationwide, automated trading platform for physical delivery of electricity, renewable power, renewable energy certificates & energy saving certificates.

FM meets heads of banks following concerns over Anthropic's Mythos

NEW DELHI: Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Thursday met heads of banks on risks related to Artificial Intelligence (AI) following global concerns over Anthropic's Mythos model threatening data security of the financial systems.

The meeting assumes significance in view of development of the Claude Mythos AI model by Anthropic claiming that it has found vulnerabilities in many major operating systems. According to sources, risks and measures needed to deal with AI were discussed at the meeting.

The meeting chaired by the Finance Minister deliberated on various risks that AI posed on the financial sector, sources said, adding that banks have been urged to take preemptive measures to secure their systems, data and money of customers.



Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman

The meeting was attended by top officials of banks, officials from Reserve Bank of India, and Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology.

According to a senior finance ministry official, the ministry and the RBI are studying the extent of risks that the Indian financial sector faces from this breach. As per the reports, Anthropic said Mythos can outperform humans at

cyber-security tasks, finding and exploiting thousands of bugs, including 27-year-old vulnerabilities, in major operating systems and web browsers.

Anthropic, an US-based artificial intelligence company, said unauthorised access was made on its new model Mythos, which is deemed too dangerous for public release.

Announced on April 7, Mythos is being deployed as part of Anthropic's 'Project Glasswing', a controlled initiative under which select organisations are permitted to use the unreleased Claude Mythos Preview model for defensive cybersecurity.

Mythos is a powerful AI model that has sparked concerns among regulators about its unprecedented ability to identify digital security vulnerabilities and potential for misuse.

Gold falls ₹900, silver tanks ₹5,300 to ₹2,50,000 per kg

NEW DELHI: Gold prices declined by Rs 900 to Rs 1.56 lakh per 10 grams in the national capital on Thursday, and silver plunged to Rs 2.50 lakh per kilogram amid weak global trends.

The yellow metal had finished at Rs 1,57,000 per 10 grams in the previous market session.

Gold of 99.9 per cent purity depreciated by Rs 900 to Rs 1,56,100 per 10 grams on Thursday, according to the All India Sarafa Association.

Silver prices fell Rs 5,300 to Rs 2,50,000 per kg from Wednesday's closing level of Rs 2,55,300 per kg.

“Gold prices extended their decline as a stronger US dollar

and rising oil prices weighed on sentiment,” Saumil Gandhi, Senior Analyst - Commodities at HDFC Securities, said.

In the international market, spot silver fell nearly 2 per cent to \$76.37 per ounce while gold traded marginally lower at \$4,738.40 per ounce.

“Markets remain on edge due to limited progress in US-Iran negotiations and escalating tensions around the Strait of Hormuz. Adding to the downside, Treasury bond yields also edged higher, with the 10-year yield rising by around 3 basis points to 4.32 per cent, further reducing the appeal of safe-haven assets such as gold,” Gandhi said.

CHHATTISGARH: In a step towards inclusive growth, NMDC Limited Chairman and MD (CMD) Amitav Mukherjee, along with senior leadership, met Panchayat heads from villages around its Dantewada operations to address grassroots concerns and deepen community engagement.

Sarpanches and representatives from villages including Gumiyaipal, Samalwar, Kalepal, Cholnar, Kadampal, Hiroli, Benpal, Kodenar, Madkamiras and Kutrem raised issues related to drinking water, road connectivity, healthcare, street lighting, sports facilities and rural infrastructure.

Senior leaders present included Director (Person-

AAISHA SABIR

NEW DELHI: India's rapidly expanding financial technology ecosystem faces mounting pressure to balance innovation with security and stability, according to the Secretary of the Department of Financial Services, M Nagaraju, as the country's digital payment infrastructure scales to unprecedented levels.

The Pradhan Mantri Jan Dhan Yojana has opened 58 crore bank accounts, with women accounting for half the beneficiaries.

Insurance and lending schemes have collectively enrolled 84 crore beneficiaries, while micro-credit disbursements under the Mudra program have reached ₹39 lakh crore.



He highlighted the sector's dual challenge at a fintech conference organized by FICCI and IBA on Thursday. He highlighted that integrating advanced technologies while protecting citizen data and maintaining systemic resilience against emerging threats, at the event.

Gross non-performing assets in public sector banks have fallen to a record low of

2.2 per cent, with net NPAs at 0.5 per cent.

The economy expanded at 7.6 per cent in 2025-26, outpacing the previous year's 7.1 per cent growth despite global headwinds and geopolitical uncertainty, as per a statement released by FICCI.

The country's digital payment infrastructure has emerged as a global benchmark.

Last month alone, the Unified Payments Interface processed 22 billion transactions valued at over Rs 29 trillion, making it the world's largest real-time retail payment system.

UPI's operational expansion into multiple countries signals India's role in shaping global digital finance architecture.

Financial inclusion has emerged as a cornerstone of this expansion.

However, Nagaraju cautioned that scaling presents fresh obstacles. Cyber threats, data privacy vulnerabilities, credit quality risks, and trust deficits require careful management, he said.

The next phase demands strategies centered on deepening financial inclusion quality, ensuring accessible capital deployment, and leveraging artificial intelligence for both innovation and fraud prevention.

India's fintech ecosystem—the largest and fastest-growing globally—requires coordination between banks, technology firms, and regulators to sustain momentum, officials stressed.

PhonePe tops 10 bn UPI payments for 1st time in March

The Unified Payments Interface network registered a record 22.64 billion transactions in March

NEW DELHI: Walmart-backed PhonePe crossed the 10 billion mark in UPI transactions for the first time in March, according to data released by the National Payments Corporation of India.

The Unified Payments Interface (UPI) network registered a record 22.64 billion transactions during the month, rising from 20.39 billion in February and 21.7 billion in January. The increase points to a recovery after a brief dip in February and a renewed growth momentum in digital payments.

PhonePe retained its leadership position, processing 10.5 billion transactions and



accounting for around 46.4 per cent of total UPI volume. In value terms, its share stood at about 49.1 per cent, highlighting its strong presence in both merchant payments and peer-to-peer transfers. The platform had processed 9.28 billion trans-

CLOSER LOOK

- » Google Pay retained second-spot, handling 7.53 billion transactions in March & 33.3% market share by volume
- » Paytm followed with 1.77 billion transactions, translating to a 7.8 per cent share by volume
- » Navi processed around 790 million transactions, while BHIM recorded about 202 million transactions

actions in February and 9.9 billion in January.

Google Pay retained the second-spot, handling 7.53 billion transactions in March and capturing roughly 33.3 per cent market share by volume. Its share by value was close to 33.9

per cent. Paytm followed with 1.77 billion transactions, translating to a 7.8 per cent share by volume and about 6.5 per cent by value. Other players trailed significantly behind the top three. Navi processed around 790 million transactions, while

BHIM recorded about 202 million transactions.

Among smaller but notable platforms, CRED processed 163 million transactions worth Rs 62,029.55 crore, accounting for over 2 per cent of total transaction value, indicating a relatively higher average ticket size. WhatsApp handled around 130 million transactions, while apps from Axis Bank contributed a smaller share, including B2C payments.

Newer entrants such as super.money & FamApp by Trio continue to scale but remain relatively small, compared to dominant players.

IGL DIVIDEND TO DELHI LG



Kamal Kishore Chaturvedi, MD IGL, Mohit Bhatia, Director (Commercial) IGL, along with senior officials of Indraprastha Gas Limited, called on Lt. Governor of Delhi, Taranjit Singh Sandhu, to hand over the interim dividend cheque of Rs 22.75 crore for FY 2025-26. The Government of NCT of Delhi holds a 5 per cent stake in IGL.

IOC assures nationwide availability of petroleum products



NEW DELHI: IndianOil Corporation (IOC) assures all citizens that the availability of Petrol (MS) and Diesel (HSD) remains normal and uninterrupted across all our supply channels nationwide.

Petrol (MS) and diesel (HSD) sales through retail outlets recorded growth exceeding 13 per cent during April 1-21, 2026.

This increased demand has been efficiently met through our extensive distribution network of over 42,000 fuel stations backed by robust logistics and supply chain capabilities, enabling us to consistently meet the nation's energy requirements without any disruption. Customers are requested to rely only on official communications.

IndianOil remains committed to transparent and reliable operations, ensuring seamless energy access for the nation.

Chennai's Super King

Samson's 101*, Akeal's spin magic script MI's biggest IPL defeat

MUMBAI: India's T20 World Cup-winning star Sanju Samson returned to top form with a scintillating unbeaten 101 as Chennai Super Kings out-classed Mumbai Indians by a massive 103 runs in a high-profile IPL clash between two five-time champions at the Wankhede Stadium on Thursday.

Samson, leading from the front, struck his fifth IPL century—and his second for CSK in just four innings—to anchor the innings and propel Chennai Super Kings to a formidable 207 for 6 after Mumbai Indians elected to bowl first. His knock came at a time when wickets kept tumbling at the other end, underlining both his composure and authority at the crease.

The right-hander's 54-ball innings was studded with 10 boundaries and six towering sixes, as he blended timing with power to keep the scoreboard ticking. Despite the lack of sustained partnerships, Samson ensured CSK posted a daunting total, taking charge during the middle and death overs with calculated aggression.

Mumbai's bowling effort had a few bright spots, with AM Ghazanfar and Ashwani Kumar claiming two wickets apiece. Jasprit Bumrah, as usual, was disciplined and eco-



Samson smashed his fifth IPL century, and second for CSK in four innings

PTI

nomical, finishing with figures of 1 for 31, but the rest of the attack struggled to contain Samson's onslaught.

Chasing 208, Mumbai Indians never found momentum and suffered a dramatic collapse in front of their home crowd. The batting unit faltered under pressure, eventually folding for 104 in 19 overs, marking their heaviest defeat in IPL history.

Tilak Varma (37) and Suryakumar Yadav (35) were the only batters to offer some

resistance, but their efforts were far from enough to challenge the steep target. The rest of the lineup failed to reach double figures, exposing a fragile middle and lower order.

CSK's bowlers, particularly the spinners, were clinical in dismantling the opposition. West Indies left-arm spinner Akeal Hossain delivered a standout performance, returning impressive figures of 4 for 17 in just his third game of the season. His control and variations proved too much for MI's

batters.

Afghanistan's left-arm wrist spinner Noor Ahmed complemented him brilliantly, picking up 2 for 23 and maintaining relentless pressure from the other end. The duo shared excellent chemistry, choking Mumbai's scoring opportunities and triggering a steady procession of wickets.

The comprehensive victory helped Chennai Super Kings bounce back strongly after their previous loss to Sunrisers Hyderabad.

AGENCIES

Starc cleared to join DC

SYDNEY: The franchise said Mhatre, who sustained the injury during CSK's previous game against Sunrisers Hyderabad on April 18, will require a rehabilitation period of six to 12 weeks.

Mitchell Starc has been cleared by Cricket Australia to feature in the Indian Premier League with the pacer expected to be available for Delhi Capitals' match against Rajasthan Royals on May 1.

The left-arm quick has been sidelined since January due to elbow and shoulder niggles. He played a key role across all five Ashes Tests, earning the Player of the Series honour, before featuring in five Big Bash League games for Sydney Sixers later that month. "Starc is on track to make his debut for the 2026 season in Delhi's May 1 match against Rajasthan Royals," Cricket.com.au reported.

AGENCIES

RCB WILL BANK ON HOME SUPPORT

Royal Challengers, Gujarat Titans look to bat away blues

BENGALURU: Royal Challengers Bengaluru will be eyeing a batting resurgence against an equally stuttering Gujarat Titans in their Indian Premier League match here on Friday.

A slightly tacky Chinnaswamy pitch squeezed the usual firepower out of the RCB batting unit against Delhi Capitals in their previous match, which they lost by six wickets.

But more than the second defeat of the season, which was also a first at home in IPL 2026, squandering a chance to firm up their position inside the top four might disappoint RCB management.

Now, third on the table with eight points, they have Sunrisers Hyderabad (8 points), Delhi Capitals and the Titans (6 points each) close on their tail.

The reigning champions would very well know that another slip-up, this time against GT, would push them further into a tight spot, particularly because they are now bracing for a slew of away matches, including two at 'home away from home' Raipur.

Therefore, the Royal Challengers would like to give a fitting farewell to their adoring and loyal Chinnaswamy fans, producing a forceful effort against Gujarat.



RCB's Virat Kohli bats at nets

PTI

The reigning champions know that another slip-up would push them further into a tight spot

But one pre-requisite for that is RCB batters' regaining their mojo and finding a way to put on board a challenging total even when conditions do not favour them.

The opposite of it has happened in two matches in a row. RCB won quite easily in the end against Lucknow Super Giants in the 16th over but gave away five wickets in return.

AGENCIES

Against DC, the RCB batters could not get going from ball one despite opener Phil Salt making a well-crafted 63.

Even acclaimed six-hitters like Rajat Patidar and Tim David had to look for alternate ways to score runs, though without much success.

So, the RCB batters might do well to keep a Plan B in store, as, at times, their all-out attack approach might not work.

RCB bowlers under Bhuvneshwar Kumar, who has aged like fine wine, dragged the contest against the Capitals to the penultimate over, but did not have enough runs on board to play with. They would hope for a change in script on Friday.

Wolvaardt does ton of good as SA bag T20I series against India

JOHANNESBURG: India scored their highest-ever total against South Africa but still suffered a nine-wicket thrashing at the hands of the home team with skipper Laura Wolvaardt leading the way with a splendid ton in the third women's T20 International here.

South Africa thus took an unassailable 3-0 lead to clinch the five-match series here on Wednesday. Put in to bat, India made 192 for 4 -- their highest

ever against South Africa -- with captain Harmanpreet Kaur and opener Shafali Verma scoring 66 and 64 respectively. But, South Africa captain Wolvaardt slammed 115 off just 53 balls while her opening partner Sune Luus struck 64 not out off 42 deliveries against a Indian bowling attack to easily chase down the target of 193 with 21 balls to spare.

Loss blessing in disguise?

Harmanpreet believes her side's below-par performance against South Africa has come at the right time, allowing the management sufficient time to address their shortcomings and "come back strong" for the T20 World Cup. "I think it's good that whatever mistakes we are making are now and not in the World Cup. This is the right time where we can learn and come back strong," she said.

AGENCIES

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING
THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

(See Section 82 Cr PC/84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita-2023)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person namely **Nitesh Kumar Singh S/o Anil Kumar R/o Vegabond, Sukha Ped Parking, Mori Gate, Kashmir Gate, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **e-FIR No. 229/2023 U/s 27/61/85 NDPS Act at PS: Kashmiri Gate, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Nitesh Kumar Singh** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Nitesh Kumar Singh** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Nitesh Kumar Singh** of **e-FIR No. 229/2023 U/s 27/61/85 NDPS Act of PS: Kashmiri Gate, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **29.06.2026**.

By order
Vaibhav Garg
Judicial Magistrate First Class-11
(Central), Room No.138,
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/5114/N/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person **Shahnawaz, S/o: Ikram, R/o: Gali No. 7, Nehru Vihar, Dayalpur K. Khas, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 331/18, U/S: 25 Arms Act, PS: Gokalpuri, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Shahnawaz**, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Shahnawaz**, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person **Shahnawaz, of FIR No. 331/18, U/S: 25 Arms Act, PS: Gokalpuri, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **22.05.2026**. By Order
Ms. Shruti Saraswat
Ld Judicial Magistrate First Class-03
North/East District
Karkardooma court, Delhi

DP/5103/NE/2026
(Court Matter)

Govt. of Jharkhand Energy Department
Jharkhand Renewable Energy Development Agency (JREDA)

3rd Floor, S.L.D.C. Building, Kusai Colony, Doranda, Ranchi-833672. Ph.: 0651-2491161, Fax: 0651-2491165, E-mail: info@jreda.com; Website: www.jreda.com

e-Procurement Notice
Tender reference no.: 05/JREDA/SHMLS/RC/26-27
Dated: 21.04.2026

1	Name of the work	Rate Contract for Design, Supply, Installation, Testing & Commissioning including 5 years Comprehensive Maintenance Contract (CMC) of 60 W LED based solar High Mast Lighting systems (SHMLS) including Remote Monitoring System (RMS) & Global Positioning System (GPS) with Lithium Ferro Phosphate Battery on Turnkeybasis across the state of Jharkhand.
2	Estimated Project cost (Rs.)	50,00,00,000/- inclusive GST
3	Period of Completion	04 (Four) Months
4	Contract Period from the date of ITC	05 (Five) Years
5	Date of publication of NIT on website: http://jharkhandtenders.gov.in	30.04.2026 (Thursday)
6	Last date & time for receipt of online bids	25.05.2026 (Monday) up to 05:00 PM
7	Submission of Bid fee and EMD through Online Via SBI Payment Gateway of Jharkhand Tenders.	25.05.2026 (Monday) up to 05:00 PM
8	Technical Bid Opening Date	28.05.2026 (Thursday) at to 03:00 PM. Director, Jharkhand Renewable Energy Development Agency (JREDA) 3rd Floor, S.L.D.C. Building, Kusai Colony, Doranda, Ranchi-833672 (Jharkhand)
9	Name & address of office inviting tender	0651-2491163/67/61/7903935514
10	Contact no. of procurement officer	0651-2491163/67/61/7903935514
11	Helpline no. of e-procurement	0651-2491163/67/61

Any corrigendum/addendum can be seen on website: <http://jharkhandtenders.gov.in> & www.jreda.com. Further details can be seen on website: <http://jharkhandtenders.gov.in> & www.jreda.com.
PR.NO.378211 Energy(26-27)-D Sd Director, JREDA

SBI STATE BANK OF INDIA E-AUCTION SALE NOTICE

HOME LOAN CENTRE-CUM-SARC-II, CORRENTUM BUILDING, GROUND FLOOR, SECTOR-62, NOIDA, DISTT.- GAUTAM BUDDH NAGAR, U.P.-201301

NOTICE FOR E-AUCTION SALE ON 30.04.2026 FOR MOVABLE PROPERTY

E-Auction Sale Notice for Sale of Movable Assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002. Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described movable property hypothecated / charged to the Secured Creditor, the physical possession of which has been taken by the Authorized Officer State Bank of India, the Secured Creditor, will be sold on "As is Where is", As is What is" and Whatever there is" on 30.04.2026, for recovery of bank due to the secured creditor as under:-

Interested bidder may deposit Pre-Bid EMD with BAANKNET before the close of e-Auction. Credit of Pre-Bid EMD shall be given to the bidder only after receipt of payment in BAANKNET's Bank Account and up-dation of such information in the e-auction website. This may take some time as per banking process and hence bidders, in their own interest, are advised to submit the pre-bid EMD amount well in advance to avoid any last minute problem.

Date / Time of E-Auction on 30.04.2026 for 6 Hours from 10:00 AM to 04:00 PM with unlimited extn. of 10 minute each.					
S. No.	Name of the Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s)	Outstanding Dues for Recovery of which Property / ies /s are being Sold	Vehicle Description	Reserve Price (Rs.) (below which property could not be sold) Earnest Money (EMD) 10% of the Reserve Price Bid Increment Amount	Name of the Authorised (Signatory)
1.	MR. HUSSAIN	Rs. 6,76,636/- as on 23.04.2026 plus future Interest and other Charges etc. thereon	Make & Model: TATA TIAGO CNG MX 1.2 RTN BS6PH2 (PETROL / CNG) R.C. No.: DL7CV1964 Engine No.: REVTN23CWXX37053 Chassis No.: MAT626143PKC33591 Date of Regn.: 19.04.2023 Kilometer Run: 89776 Fuel: Petrol / CNG	₹ 3,70,000.00 ₹ 37,000.00 ₹ 1,000.00 *GST as applicable	Mr. Binay Pathak (Chief Manager) Home Loan Centre-cum-SARC-II, Sector-62, Gautam Buddh Nagar, Noida, U.P.

Last Date of EMD Deposit on or before 29.04.2026 before 16:00 Hrs.
Account/ Wallet in which EMD to be remitted : Bidder's own wallet Registered with BAANKNET on its e-auction site: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing> by means of NEFT/RETS. EMD of Reserve Price to be transferred by bidders by means of challan generated on his/her/their bidder account maintained with BAANKNET on its e-auction site: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing> by means of NEFT from his/her/their bank. For any assistance, please call please call BAANKNET HELPPDESK: +91 8291220220, support.BAANKNET@psballiance.com and/or Authorized Officer.

TERMS AND CONDITIONS OF THE E-AUCTION ARE AS UNDER:
(1) E-Auction is being held on "As is where is", "as is what is basis" and "whatever there is basis" and will be conducted "On Line". The auction will be conducted through the Bank's approved service provider BAANKNET at their web portal: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing>
(2) Bank shall reserve the right to cancel/postpone the auction.
(3) The Vehicle are available for inspection during banking hours on 28.04.2026 From 11:00 AM to 04:00 PM., Contact Person: Mr. Rahul Pal, Mob No.: 9810807622 (Resolution Agent) Address: G-27, Flat 104, Pankaj Tower 4 DDA Community Center, Vikas Puri, West Delhi-110018.
(4) * Successful bidder to pay GST as applicable on the successful bid amount, viz sale value.
(5) To the best of knowledge and information of the Authorized Officer there is no encumbrance on the property/ies. However the intending bidder should make their own independent inquiries regarding the encumbrances, title of the property/ies put on auction and claims/tights/dues/affecting the property prior to submitting their bid.
The e-Auction Advertisement does not constitute and will not be deemed to constitute any commitment or any representation of the Bank. The property is being sold with all the existing and future encumbrances whether known or unknown to the bank. The Authorized Officer shall not be responsible in any way for any third party claims/rights/ dues.
(6) The Earnest Money Deposit (EMD) of the successful bidder shall be retained towards part sale consideration and the EMD of the unsuccessful bidders shall be refunded. The Earnest Money Deposit shall not bear any Interest. The successful bidder shall have to deposit 25% of the sale price, immediately on acceptance of bid price by the Authorized Officer and the balance of the sale price on or before 15' day of the sale. Default in deposit of amount by the successful bidder would entail forfeiture of the whole money already deposited and property shall be put to the e-auction and the defaulting bidder shall have no claim/right in respect of property/ amount.
(7) For detailed terms and conditions of the sale please refer to the link at the Bank's Service Provider's web portal: <https://baanknet.com/eauction-psb/eproc-listing> & e-auction website: <https://BAANKNET.com>

Date: 23.04.2026 Place: Noida Authorized Officer, State Bank of India, Home Loan Centre, RACPC 2, Noida

M.P. POWER GENERATING COMPANY LIMITED

OFFICE OF THE A.D.E. (P&W), SHREE SINGAJI THERMAL POWER PROJECT
Dongalia Distt. Khandwa (M.P.) E-mail ID: sepnw.sstpp1@gmail.com

No. : 515-1700/SSTPP/MPPGCL/P&W/601 Date : 23.04.2026

Tender Particulars/Tender Number	Estimated Cost (Rs.) (including GST)	Tender Cost & EMD in Rs.	Last date and time for closing of online submission
Procurement of spare parts of Ring Granulator of L and T make for CHP-I, 2x600 MW, SSTPP, MPPGCL, Dongalia. (T-2026_MPPGCL_482907_1)	Rs. 1,51,16,791/- (including G.S.T.)	5000/- & 2,00,000/-	18.05.2026 Up to 15:30 hrs.
Procurement of spare parts of 'Apron Feeder' of L and T make installed at CHP-II, 2x660 MW, SSTPP, MPPGCL, Dongalia. (T-2026_MPPGCL_486324_1)	Rs. 1,98,18,973/- (including G.S.T.)	5000/- & 2,00,000/-	18.05.2026 Up to 15:30 hrs.
Procurement of spare parts of Wagon Tipplers, Side Arm Charger and Apron Feeder of L and T make for CHP-I, 2x600 MW, SSTPP, MPPGCL, Dongalia. (T-2026_MPPGCL_494438_1)	Rs. 1,98,67,642/- (including G.S.T.)	5000/- & 2,00,000/-	19.05.2026 Up to 15:30 hrs.
Procurement of 01 No. Complete Rotor Assembly of Ring Granulator for CHP-I, 2x600 MW, SSTPP, MPPGCL, Dongalia. (T-2026_MPPGCL_482905_1)	Rs. 1,04,81,940/- (including G.S.T.)	5000/- & 2,00,000/-	19.05.2026 Up to 15:30 hrs.
"Complete overhauling of Electrical wire rope Hoist along with supply of spares for Electrical wire rope Hoist installed at coal mill area at 2X600 MW, Stage-I, SSTPP, MPPGCL, Dongalia" (T-2026_MPPGCL_487295_1)	Rs. 1,49,09,064/- (including G.S.T.)	5000/- & 2,00,000/-	21.05.2026 Up to 15:30 hrs.

For extension & other details, the bidders are requested to please visit e-portal of GoMP at www.mptenders.gov.in
M.P. Madhyam/125462/2026 //SAVE ELECTRICITY// SE (P&W)

millenniumpost CLASSIFIEDS

CHANGE OF NAME

I, KIRAN KUMAR SINGH's/o Late Devendra Kumar singh R/o WZ-911, Naraina Village, South West Delhi-110028.

It is for general information that I KIRAN KUMAR SINGH S/O LATE DEVENDRA KUMAR SINGH permanent resident MAJHYAN WARD NO- 10 DAKGHAR JETHAUR JAMUAA P.S -AMARPUR PARKHAND AMARPUR ANUMANDAL DISTT.BIHAR STATE BIHAR – PIN-813101, declare that name of mine has been wrongly written KARAN KUMAR MISHRA in my Aadhar card no. 449281612519. The actual name of mine is KIRAN KUMAR SINGH which may be amended accordingly.

It's coming to City?

Haaland winner puts City top



Manchester City's Erling Haaland scores the winner

AP

LONDON: Manchester City completed their ominous, late-season rise to the top of the Premier League by beating Burnley 1-0 thanks to Erling Haaland's early goal, ending Arsenal's 200-day stay in first place.

The result condemned American-owned Burnley to relegation after one season ban in the top flight. Haaland ran onto Jeremy Doku's pass to convert a deft finish in the fifth minute for his league-high 24th goal of the campaign.

AGENCIES

MALAVIYA NATIONAL INSTITUTE OF TECHNOLOGY JAIPUR
Jawahar Lal Nehru Marg, Jaipur 302017
Admission to Ph.D. and Masters Degree Programmes 2026-27

F4/A-1-I-2026-27/ Acad Ph.D/01

Online Applications are invited for admission to Ph.D. and M.Tech./M.Plan. (Sponsored (Full Time/Part Time) & Full Time Self-Financed) in all the Departments/Centres for Odd Semester 2026-27 (July 2026). For more information visit www.mnit.ac.in. The last date for submission of online application is 07th May 2026.

cbc 21312/11/0003/2627

REGISTRAR

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF A PERSON ACCUSED

See Section 82 Cr. P.C. / 84 BNSs

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Ashish @ Ashu @ Chhotu S/o Naresh R/o House of Heera, Near Purana, P.O. Bawana, Delhi and Permanent Address: Village Samaspur Khalsa, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 545/2020 U/s 356/379/411/34 IPC, P.S. Bawana, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Ashish @ Ashu @ Chhotu** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Ashish @ Ashu @ Chhotu** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Ashish @ Ashu @ Chhotu** of case **FIR No. 545/2020 U/s 356/379/411/34 IPC, P.S. Bawana, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **08.06.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Bharti Benival
Judicial Magistrate First Class-05
North, Court No. 114, 1st Floor
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/5182/ON/2026 (Court Matter)

ASSETS CARE & RECONSTRUCTION ENTERPRISE LTD.
Corporate Office : Unit No. 502, C Wing, ONE BKC, Plot No. C – 66, G – Block, Bandra Kurla Complex, Mumbai – 400051. Tel: 022 68643101.
Registered Office : 14th Floor, EROS Corporate Tower, Nehru Place, New Delhi – 110019.
E-mail : acre.arc@acreindia.in | Website : www.acreindia.in | CIN : U65993DL2002PLC115769

APPENDIX IV-A
Sale Notice for sale of Immovable Property
E-Auction Sale Notice for sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) and Rule 9(1) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.
Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described Immovable Property mortgaged to **Assets Care & Reconstruction Enterprise Ltd.** [CIN : U65993DL2002PLC115769] ("Secured Creditor"), the physical possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of the Secured Creditor, will be sold on "as is where is", "as is what is" and "whatever there is" basis on 14.05.2026 from 05.00 P.M. to 06.00 P.M., for recovery of **Rs. 82,19,579/- (Rupees Eighty Two Lakh Nineteen Thousand Five Hundred Seventy Eight only)** pending towards **Loan Account No. HHLNOD00222510**, by way of outstanding principal, arrears (including accrued late charges) and interest till 09.04.2026 with applicable future interest in terms of the Loan Agreement and other related loan document(s) w. e. f. 1.04.2026 along with legal expenses and other charges due to the Secured Creditor from **VIJAY GROVER and REENA GROVER**.
The Loan Account bearing No. **HHLNOD00222510**, along with all right(s), title(s), interest(s), underlying security(ies), pledge(s) and / or guarantee(s), including the Immovable Property, had been assigned by Sammaan Capital Limited ("SCL") (formerly known as Indiabulls Housing Finance Ltd.) to Indiabulls Asset Reconstruction Co. Ltd. ("IARCL") vide Assignment Agreement dated 31.12.2018 and the same had been renumbered by IARCL and bears new Loan Account No. **V0040IV-02**. The said Loan Account had been further assigned by IARCL to and in favour of the Secured Creditor, acting as a **Trustee of ACRE - 102 - Trust** vide Assignment Agreement dated **26.04.2021** read with Rectification Deed dated **26.08.2021**. Furthermore, the said Loan Account has now been assigned by Assets Care & Reconstruction Enterprise Ltd. acting as a **Trustee of ACRE - 102 - Trust** and in favour of the Secured Creditor acting as **Trustee of ACRE - 180 - Trust** vide Assignment Agreement dated **23.06.2025**.
The Reserve Price for the Immovable Property will be **Rs. 92,00,000/- (Rupees Ninety Two Lakh only)** and the Earnest Money Deposit ("EMD") will be **Rs. 9,20,000/- (Rupees Nine Lakh Twenty Thousand only)** i.e. equivalent to 10% of the Reserve Price.

DESCRIPTION OF THE IMMOVABLE PROPERTY
RESIDENTIAL APARTMENT NO. B1 - 1702, ON 17TH FLOOR, HAVING LEASABLE AREA / SALEABLE AREA OF 1765 SQUARE FEET APPROX., SITUATED AT COMPLEX KNOWN AS "JKG PALM COURT", CONSTRUCTED ON PLOT NO. GH1-D, SECTOR - 16C, GREATER NOIDA, NOIDA – 201308, UTTAR PRADESH.
For detailed terms and conditions of the sale, please refer to the link provided on the website of the Secured Creditor i.e. www.acreindia.in; Contact No : 0124 - 6910910, +91 7065451024; E - mail id: auctionhelpline@sammaanacpaital.com. For bidding, log on to www.auctionfocus.in.

Sd/-
Authorized Officer
Date : 20.04.2026 **ASSETS CARE & RECONSTRUCTION ENTERPRISE LTD.**
Place : NOIDA
TRUSTEE OF ACRE - 180 - TRUST
"For any grievance you may contact Mr. Mohd Sharif Malik, Grievance Redressal Officer, Phone No. : 011 - 66115609, E-mail : complaint@acreindia.in. The detailed policy on Grievance Redressal Mechanism within the organisation can be accessed at <https://www.acreindia.in/compliance>".

Chhattisgarh State Industrial Development Corporation Limited
(A Government of Chhattisgarh Undertaking)
(ISO 9001 : 2015 Certified)
1st Floor, Udyog Bhawan, Ring Road No. 1, Tehanda, Raipur(C.G.) - 492006.
CIN : U45200CT1981SG00183 PAN : AAJCM288N. SGT Regn No:22AAJCM288N/SY
Phone : 0771-6621900 Fax : 0771-288794
Website : www.csidc.in. Email address: csidc@nic.in; nic.in:csidc; raipur@vahoo.com

NOTICE INVITING TENDER (1st call)
(Through e-Procurement Portal Only)
No.: 09/CSIDC/E.E.-I/Division-1/2026-27/ 189464 Raipur, dated 22/04/2026
Online (Percentage Basis) tenders in Form-A are invited from contractors registered in Class-C & Above in New Unified Registration System (E-Registration) website <https://eproc.csidc.state.gov.in> at appropriate class, for the following works -

S.No.	Name of Work	Registered Contractor in CGPWD or in appropriate class in other dep't.	Time allowed including rainy season	Estimated Cost (INR Lacs)	EMD (INR Rs.)	Cost of Tender Doc. (INR) including GST 18%
1.	Up gradation of Existing 30m & 24m wide BT roads including Street Light at I/A Silpahari, Distt. Bilaspur (C.G.)	C& Above	03 Months i/c rainy season	195.59 Lacs	1,47,000/-	3540/-

The tender document and other details can be downloaded from the web portal (website) <https://eproc.csidc.state.gov.in> and shall be submitted online only. Amendment in tender, if any, will only be uploaded on the website and shall not be published in any newspaper
NOTE: 1) The interested tenderers for online submission of tender may contact CG eProc Helpdesk. Operated by Mjunction Services Limited. they may reach Helpdesk using 18002582502 (from 9 AM to 11 PM) (therein press 2 for CG e-Proc) or you can email them at Helpdesk_eproc@csidc.state.gov.in
2) Tenderer may contact to E.E., Div-I, CSIDC, Udyog Bhawan in working hours to clear their doubt if any before online submission of the tender

samvad 47603/3

Executive Engineer, Division-1

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person Namely **Mr. Laksmi Kant Gaur R/o C-58, Surahmal Vihar, Delhi-92** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case, **Case No 4476/2019 U/s 138 NI Act PS: Shalimar Bagh, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Mr. Laksmi Kant Gaur** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Mr. Laksmi Kant Gaur** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Mr. Laksmi Kant Gaur** accused of **Case No 4476/2019 U/s 138 NI Act PS: Shalimar Bagh, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **25.05.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Apoorv Bhardwaj
JMFC-02, Room No. 113
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/5275/NW/2026
(Court Matter)

ASSETS CARE & RECONSTRUCTION ENTERPRISE LTD.
Corporate Office : Unit No. 502, C Wing, ONE BKC, Plot No. C – 66, G – Block, Bandra Kurla Complex, Mumbai – 400051. Tel: 022 68643101.
Registered Office : 14th Floor, EROS Corporate Tower, Nehru Place, New Delhi – 110019.
E-mail : acre.arc@acreindia.in | Website : www.acreindia.in | CIN : U65993DL2002PLC115769

APPENDIX IV-A
Sale Notice for sale of Immovable Property
E-Auction Sale Notice for sale of Immovable Assets under the Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to Rule 8(6) and Rule 9(1) of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002.
Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described Immovable Property mortgaged to **Assets Care & Reconstruction Enterprise Ltd.** [CIN : U65993DL2002PLC115769] ("Secured Creditor"), the physical possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of the Secured Creditor, will be sold on "as is where is", "as is what is" and "whatever there is" basis on 14.05.2026 from 05.00 P.M. to 06.00 P.M., for recovery of **Rs. 96,14,622/- (Rupees Ninety Six Lakh Fourteen Thousand Six Hundred Twenty Two only)** pending towards **Loan Account No. HHLNOD0022202**, by way of outstanding principal, arrears (including accrued late charges) and interest till 09.04.2026 with applicable future interest in terms of the Loan Agreement and other related loan document(s) w. e. f. 1.04.2026 along with legal expenses and other charges due to the Secured Creditor from **VIJAY GROVER and REENA GROVER**.
The Loan Account bearing No. **HHLNOD0022202**, along with all right(s), title(s), interest(s), underlying security(ies), pledge(s) and / or guarantee(s), including the Immovable Property, had been assigned by Sammaan Capital Limited ("SCL") (formerly known as Indiabulls Housing Finance Ltd.) to Indiabulls Asset Reconstruction Co. Ltd. ("IARCL") vide Assignment Agreement dated 31.12.2018 and the same had been renumbered by IARCL and bears new Loan Account No. **V0040IV-01**. The said Loan Account had been further assigned by IARCL to and in favour of the Secured Creditor, acting as a **Trustee of ACRE - 102 - Trust** vide Assignment Agreement dated **26.04.2021** read with Rectification Deed dated **26.08.2021**. Furthermore, the said Loan Account has now been assigned by Assets Care & Reconstruction Enterprise Ltd. acting as a **Trustee of ACRE - 102 - Trust** and in favour of the Secured Creditor acting as **Trustee of ACRE - 180 - Trust** vide Assignment Agreement dated **23.06.2025**.
The Reserve Price for the Immovable Property will be **Rs. 87,40,000/- (Rupees Eighty Seven Lakh Forty Thousand only)** and the Earnest Money Deposit ("EMD") will be **Rs. 8,74,000/- (Rupees Eight Lakh Seventy Four Thousand only)** i.e. equivalent to 10% of the Reserve Price.

DESCRIPTION OF THE IMMOVABLE PROPERTY
RESIDENTIAL APARTMENT NO. B2 - 1604, ON 16TH FLOOR, HAVING LEASABLE AREA / SALEABLE AREA OF 1635 SQUARE FEET APPROX., SITUATED AT COMPLEX KNOWN AS "JKG PALM COURT", CONSTRUCTED ON PLOT NO. GH1-D, SECTOR - 16C, GREATER NOIDA, NOIDA – 201308, UTTAR PRADESH.
For detailed terms and conditions of the sale, please refer to the link provided on the website of the Secured Creditor i.e. www.acreindia.in; Contact No : 0124 - 6910910, +91 7065451024; E - mail id: auctionhelpline@sammaanacpaital.com. For bidding, log on to www.auctionfocus.in.

Sd/-
Authorized Officer
Date : 20.04.2026 **ASSETS CARE & RECONSTRUCTION ENTERPRISE LTD.**
Place : NOIDA
TRUSTEE OF ACRE - 180 - TRUST
"For any grievance you may contact Mr. Mohd Sharif Malik, Grievance Redressal Officer, Phone No. : 011 - 66115609, E-mail : complaint@acreindia.in. The detailed policy on Grievance Redressal Mechanism within the organisation can be accessed at <https://www.acreindia.in/compliance>".

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person, namely, **Lucky @ Gaurav S/o Kamal, R/o J-80 Gail No. 4, Sardar Colony, Sec-16, Rohini, Delhi**, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. : 235/2023, U/s: 25/54/59 Arms Act 1959, Dt. 12.05.2023** registered at **P.S.: Prem Nagar, Delhi**, and the warrant has been returned writing upon that the said accused person, **Lucky @ Gaurav** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person, **Lucky @ Gaurav** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said, accused person, **Lucky @ Gaurav, FIR No. : 235/2023, U/s: 25/54/59 Arms Act 1959, Dt. 12.05.2023** registered at **P.S.: Prem Nagar, Delhi**, is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **30.05.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Shagun, Id.
Judicial Magistrate First Class
Distt. North-West, Court No. 109, 1st Floor
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/5334/RD/2026
(Court Matter)

NORTHERN RAILWAY
OPEN TENDER NOTICE

The Principal Chief Mechanical Engineer, Northern Railway, Baroda House for and on behalf of President of India invites sealed tender on "Two Packet System" for following work from experienced and capable tenderers.

- Name of work : Supply, Installation and Commissioning (on turnkey basis) of CNC Under floor Wheel Lathe at Coaching Depot/Ayodhya Cantt and Coaching Depot/Prayagraj Sangam of LKO Division, CNC Portal Wheel Lathe at ROH Depot/Ambala and ROH Depot/Khanalampura of Ambala Division, CNC Surface Wheel Lathe at Mechanical Workshop/Amritsar and Wagon Care Centre/Tughlakabad
- Work Place : Northern Railway
- Period of Work : 12 months
- Approximate cost of work : Rs. 60,58,03,408.02/- (inclusive GST@18%)
- Earnest money in favour of FA&CAO, Northern Railway, New Delhi : Rs. 1,21,16,100/-
- Cost of the tender form : Nil
- Availability of tender documents : Website www.ireps.gov.in
- Date and time of availability of tender documents : From 17.04.2026 to 08.05.2026
- Date and time of tender closing : 08.05.2026 at 15.00 Hrs.
- Date and time of tender opening : 08.05.2026 at 15.00 Hrs. If the date of opening happens to be a holiday the tender shall be opened on the next working day.
- Place for opening of tender : Northern Railway Headquarter Office, Baroda House, New Delhi.

No.: 582-M/155/NR-2026-WT-CNC Wheel Lathes Date: 20.04.2026 1348/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Tender Notice No. : 0820262027 Date : 20.04.2026

E-Tender Notice

Divisional Railway Manager (Engineering)/ North Central Railway/ Prayagraj, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites the following E-Tenders on prescribed form for the following works up to 13:30 hrs. on 12.05.2026. The details of the tenders are as under:-

Tender No. : 32	Approx. Cost of Work (Rs.) : 63967610.66
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Name of Work : Improvement of RUBs No. 34, 36, 37, 44, 45 and 47 for protection of water seepage under ADEN/FZD and other miscellaneous works including dewatering of RUBs in the section of Sr. DEN/III/PRYJ.

Bis security (Rs.) : 1279400.00	Completion Period : 12 Months
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Date of Opening of tender : 12.05.2026

Similar work for Eligibility Criteria : Seepage protection or strengthening of Bridges/Tunnels/Reservoirs/Any Important Civil engineering structures by Cement/Epoxy grouting or by Hydro reactive Polyurethane (PU) resin grouting or by any advanced method use for seepage protection.

Note : 1. The complete information along with tender document of above E-Tenders is available on website www.ireps.gov.in up to 13:30 hrs. on the due date of tender opening i.e. 12.05.2026. The tender shall be opened at or after 15:00 hrs on due date of opening. 2. Bids other than in the form of E-Bids shall not be accepted against above Tenders. For this purpose, vendors are required to get themselves registered with IREPS website along with Digital Signature Certificates issued by CCA under IT Act-2000. 3. Rates entered into Financial Rate page and duly signed digitally shall be considered. Rates and any other financial entity in any other form / letter head if attached by Tenderer shall be straight way ignored & shall not be considered. (4) Documents being attached should be signed by the Tenderer on its body. (5) For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website www.ireps.gov.in. 872/26 (A)

f North central railways @ www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in @CPRONCR

CFM ASSET RECONSTRUCTION PRIVATE LIMITED
REGISTERED OFFICE: Block no. A/1003, West Gate, Near YMCA Club, Sur No. 835/1+3, S. G. Highway, Makarba, Ahmedabad-380051 Gujarat
CORPORATE OFFICE: 1ST FLOOR, WAKEFIELD HOUSE, SPROTT ROAD, BALLARD ESTATE, MUMBAI-400038
EMAIL: info@cfmarc.in, sweta.rana@cfmarc.in, Anmol.mishra@cfmarc.in CONTACT: 022-40055282

APPENDIX IV-A
[See proviso to rule 8 (6)]
SALE NOTICE FOR SALE OF IMMOVABLE PROPERTY
E-auction Sale Notice for the sale of immovable assets under the Securitization and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 read with proviso to rule 8(6) of the Security Interest Enforcement Rules, 2002.
Notice is hereby given to the public in general and in particular to the Borrower(s) and Guarantor(s) that the below described immovable property (Secured Asset) mortgaged/charged to the Secured Creditor, the physical possession of which has been taken by the Authorised Officer of CFM Asset Reconstruction Pvt. Ltd. (acting in its capacity as a Trustee of CFMARC Trust – 1 IHFL "The secured Creditor") will be sold on "As is where is basis", "As is what is basis", "Whatever there is basis" and "No recourse basis" on 28.05.2026 for recovery of **Rs.64,88,210/- (Rupees Sixty Four Lakh Eighty Eight Thousand Two Hundred Ten only)** pending towards Loan Account No. HHLVAS00222572 as on 09.04.2026 together with further interest, other costs, and expenses thereon due and payable till the final payment.

DESCRIPTION OF SECURED PROPERTY:
Property Bearing No. D – 1302, Type – A1, Having A Saleable Area Of Approximately 1040 Square Feet, In K. M. Residency On Plot Of Land Measuring 10810 Square Meters, Situated At R/o / Kharsa No. 308, 309, 310, 311, 312, Village Noor Nagar, Rajnagar Extension, Ghaziabad – 201002, Uttar Pradesh

SECURED DEBT:
Rs.64,88,210/- (Rupees Sixty Four Lakh Eighty Eight Thousand Two Hundred Ten only) pending towards Loan Account No. HHLVAS00222572 as on 09.04.2026 together with further interest, other costs, and expenses thereon due and payable till the final payment.

RESERVE PRICE (RP):
Rs.30,00,000/- (Rupees Thirty Lakh only)

INSPECTION
Visit on request

TIME DATE:
E-Auction/Bidding through website (www.auctionfocus.in)
Date: 28.05.2026 Time: 05.00 P.M. to 06.00 P.M

PLACE FOR E-AUCTION
On or before 3:00 PM on 28.05.2026

LAST DATE AND TIME FOR BID SUBMISSION:
EMD: Rs.3,00,000/- (Rupees Three Lakh only)

CONTACT:
0124-6910910, +91 7065451024

Encumbrances if any: Not known to the secured creditor
For detailed terms & conditions of the sale, please refer to the link provided in Secured Creditors website i.e. <https://www.cfmarc.in> for detailed terms & conditions of e-auction-sale of respective properties and other details before submitting their bids for taking part in the e-auction. Bidders may also visit the website to www.auctionfocus.in or contact No : 0124-6910910, +91 7065451024; E-mail id: auctionhelpline@sammaanacpaital.com.

Date: 20.04.2026
Place: Ghaziabad

Sd/- Authorised Officer
CFM Asset Reconstruction Pvt. Ltd.
Acting as trustee of CFMARC Trust - 1 IHFL

NORTH EASTERN RAILWAY
Open E-Tender Notice
NER-LJN-2026-69

On behalf of the President of India, Divisional Railway Manager/ Engineering, North Eastern Railway, Lucknow, invites online tender for the following work, detail of which is as given below: **E-Tender no. : NER-LJN-2026-69; Name of Work : NER-LJN Division: At LJN division- Improvement of B.bagh officers' colony with provision of road, water supply, drain etc in section of SSE/WB.Bagh. Estimated cost (Rs.): 2,02,38,605.36 Earnest Money (Rs.) : 4,04,800.00 Completion Period : 12 Months 1. The tender, for the above tender number NER-LJN-2026-69 can be uploaded up to 15:00 hrs. on 13.05.2026 and this tender will be opened after 15:00 hrs. on the same day. 2. All the information related minimum qualification, complete details of terms and conditions of the above tender is available on North Eastern Railway website www.ireps.gov.in. Tenderers should read the corrigendum (if any) available on the website related to this tender information before uploading the tender form and be sure to take into consideration as well.**

Div.Railway Manager(Engg.), Lucknow

CPRO/V-40

DO NOT SMOKE BID/CIGARETTE IN TRAIN

COURT NOTICE
(U/o S Rule 20 CPC)
IN THE COURT OF
IN THE COURT OF Sh. Ashok Kumar-I
Additional District and Sessions Judge, Sonapat
In CS/306/2017 DOD 29.11.2025
Prayed that the instant appeal be accepted throughout by decreeing the suit of the plaintiffs
Dhan Raj Vs. Wazir Chand
Case No. CA/525/2025
CNR No. HR5001-012624-2025
Next Date- 25-05-2026
PUBLICATION ISSUED TO:
WAZIR CHAND
FATHER:-BUDH RAM
H NO- F/1747, NETAJI NAGAR, NEW DELHI.
In above titled case, the defendant (s)/ respondent(s) could not be served. It is ordered that defendant(s)/ respondent(s) should appear in person or through counsel on **25-05-2026 at 10:00 am**. For details logon to <https://highcourtcdh.gov.in> /trs = district notice & district = Sonapat
Sd/- Sh. Ashok Kumar-I Additional District and Sessions Judge, Sonapat
Dated 22-04-2026

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-Tendering Tender Notice

Divisional Railway Manager (Works) N.C. Railway, Jhansi for and on behalf of President of India invites sealed "Open Tender" through on Line (E-Tendering) for the following work.

E-Tender No.: JHS-ENGG-E-2026-83

Description of work: Jhansi Division:- Zone No. 8A: Annual sectional contract for repair and maintenance work and supply of material under ADEN/MBA sub division from Jhansi (Excl.) to Baripura (INCL), MBA (INCL) to KURJ (EXCL.) for the year 2026-27

Approx Cost : ₹ 127000000.00	Earnest Money : ₹ 2540000.00
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Date of closing Tender: 15.05.2026 at 15.00 hrs.

Date of completion/period from issue of acceptance letter: 12 Months

E-Tender No.: JHS-ENGG-E-2026-84

Description of work: Jhansi Division:- Zone No. 8A: Annual sectional contract for repair and maintenance work and supply of material under ADEN/MBA sub division from KURJ (INCL.) to LAR (EXCL.) for the year 2026-27

Approx Cost : ₹ 17000000.00	Earnest Money : ₹ 340000.00
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Date of closing Tender: 15.05.2026 at 15.00 hrs.

Date of completion/period from issue of acceptance letter: 12 Months

E-Tender No.: JHS-ENGG-E-2026-85

Description of work: Jhansi Division:- Zone No. 9: Annual Sectional contract for repairs and maintenance work and supply of material under ADEN/BNDA sub division from Baripura (Excl.) MKP (Excl.) and KID to BZM (Excl.) for the year 2026-27

Approx Cost : ₹ 150000000.00	Earnest Money : ₹ 3000000.00
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Date of closing Tender: 15.05.2026 at 15.00 hrs.

Date of completion/period from issue of acceptance letter: 12 Months

• Tender online can be submitted up to 15:00 hrs on 15.05.2026 • For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website www.ireps.gov.in. 868/26 FA

f North central railways @CPRONCR www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-TENDER No. : NCRPU-ALJN-DER-MSDAC-T-04-2026 Date: 20.04.2026

E-TENDER NOTICE

Dy. CSTE/PU/Aligarh, N. C. Railway, for and behalf of President of India invites sealed "Open Tender" through on Line (E-Tendering) for the following work.

Description of Work: Reliability improvement of Track circuits by provision of MSDAC in parallel of existing DCTC and other associated work at 14 stations in ALJN-DER section of Prayagraj Division.

Approx. Cost (Rs.): ₹ 30,60,28,155.73	Earnest Money (Rs.): ₹ 61,20,600/-
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Cost of Tender From: Nil **Date of Closing Tender & Time:** 20.05.2026 15:00 hrs.

Date of Completion/Period from issue acceptance letter: 18 Months **Validity of Tender:** 90 days

Note:- (1) The complete information along with Tender document of above E-Works Tender will be available on Website on www.ireps.gov.in up to 15:00 Hrs. on the due date of Tender opening. (2) Bids other than in the form of E-Bids shall not be accepted against above Tenders. For this purpose, Venders are required to get themselves registered with IREPS website along with Class III Digital signature certificate issued by CCA under IT Act 2000. (3) Rates entered into financial rate page and duly signed digitally shall only be considered. Rates and any other financial entity in any other form / letter head if attached by Tenderer shall be straight way ignored & shall not be considered. (4) Documents being attached should be signed by the Tenderer on its body. (5) For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website www.ireps.gov.in. 872/26 (A)

f North central railways @CPRONCR www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita-2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Virender, S/o Bhagwan Das, R/o H.No. 143, Gali No. 3, Khadda Colony, Swaroop Nagar, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 113/26, dated 18.03.2026, U/s 69/74/75/3(5) Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita-2023, P.S. Swaroop Nagar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said **Virender** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Virender** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Virender** accused of **FIR No. 113/26, dated 18.03.2026, U/s 69/74/75/3(5) Bhartiya Nyaya Sanhita-2023, P.S. Swaroop Nagar, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **26.05.2026**.

By Order - Ms. Jyoti Nain
Judicial Magistrate First Class, North
DP/5315/ON/2026 Room No. 06, 1st Floor, Rohini Courts, Delhi

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82 Cr. P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) **Vakil Ahmad S/o: Banne Khan, R/o: Jhuggi No. 30, B-494, H-4 Block, Jahangir Puri, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 123/19, U/S: 33 Delhi Ex. Act, PS: Jahangir Puri, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Vakil Ahmad**, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Vakil Ahmad**, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Vakil Ahmad of FIR No. 123/19, U/S: 33 Delhi Ex. Act, PS: Jahangir Puri, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **03.06.2026**.

By Order
Jyoti Nain
Judicial Magistrate First Class-07
North Court No. 06 1st Floor
Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/5119/NW/2026
(Court Matter)

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY

Tender Notice No. 0720262027 Date: 20.04.2026

E-Tender Notice

Divisional Railway Manager/ North Central Railway, Prayagraj, for and on behalf of the President of India, invites online tenders (E-tender) as detailed below-

S. N. : 1 | E-Tender Notice No. : 0720262027-20 | Approx. Cost(₹) : ₹ 1,44,00,002.15

Name of work: Execution of annual repairs and maintenance Zonal works in the Jurisdiction of SSE/Works/Station/PRYJ, P.E. 30.06.2027

Earnest Money (₹) : ₹ 2,88,000.00

S. N. : 2 | E-Tender Notice No. : 0720262027-21 | Approx. Cost(₹) : ₹ 1,85,24,928.63

Name of work: Execution of annual repairs and maintenance Zonal works in the Jurisdiction of SSE/Works/Traffic/PRYJ, P.E. 30.06.2027

Earnest Money (₹) : ₹ 3,70,500.00

S. N. : 3 | E-Tender Notice No.:0720262027-22 | Approx. Cost(₹) : ₹ 2,41,82,713.11

Name of work: Execution of annual repairs and maintenance Zonal works in the Jurisdiction of SSE/Works/Rajnagar/PRYJ, P.E. 30.06.2027

Earnest Money (₹) : ₹ 4,83,700.00

S. N. : 4 | E-Tender Notice No. : 0720262027-23 | Approx. Cost(₹) : ₹ 2,45,33,278.48

Name of work: Execution of annual repairs and maintenance Zonal works in the Jurisdiction of SSE/Works/Naini/PRYJ, P.E. 30.06.2027

Earnest Money



‘Ranveer Singh doesn’t see Dhurandhar as his film’

Sara Arjun opened up about the actor’s ‘generosity’

Sara Arjun has emerged as one of Bollywood’s freshest faces following the success of ‘Dhurandhar’. Despite a career spanning over 15 years, the 20-year-old actress has managed to strike a fine balance between her professional journey and personal life, making her recent rise feel refreshingly new. She recently opened up about her experience working with Ranveer Singh in the Aditya Dhar directorial.

Speaking to ‘Femina India’, Sara said, “I’m just in such awe of the actor Ranveer is - the dedication he brings to his craft. For all these reasons, nobody can top my experience with him as a co-actor. He’s protective of the result, the way a child is protective of something they love. Nobody will ever top Ranveer Singh as a co-actor. He really believes it’s not his film; it’s everybody’s film. And he’s like that, not just with actors - he treats technicians, spot boys, every crew member with

the same respect. He never lets his seniority come across as superiority.”

When asked whether she anticipated the film’s scale and the response it has received, Sara shared, “Everything about ‘Dhurandhar’ - the cast, the technicians, the direction - was solid, but what gave us the most faith was the script. It was incredibly detailed. When something is so well written and the vision is so clear, you instinctively feel like it will work.”

Reflecting on success, she added, “It’s not about scale or critical or commercial success. It’s about an inner voice telling me I have grown from yesterday. That sense of fulfilment is what matters the most.”

Talking about her approach to acting, Sara explained, “Sometimes, you really have to forget who you are and just focus on the emotion - how

deeply the character would feel it - and go for it. Contrary to what many might believe, I don’t think I have grown up on camera just because I started acting young. I owe a lot to my parents for protecting my personal life.”

She also spoke about her process, saying she doesn’t rely on personal emotional memories. “People often ask how I portray intense emotions like marital conflict or loss. I don’t use personal memories because they’re temporary. If I rely on real-life pain, I’d exhaust that emotion quickly. That’s not the way I want to work.”

Sara credited her father for being her constant support. “I can’t imagine reaching anywhere without my father’s presence. It’s not even 50-50 - he’s held my hand throughout. He considers acting a sacred art and



that value has been passed on to me. For me, it’s always about living up to the standards he has set. He taught me to ‘do and forget’ - not even look at the monitor while on set - and I have taken that lesson very seriously.”

AGENCIES

40TH ANNIVERSARY

‘Top Gun’ to re-release in India

The original was directed by the late Tony Scott

‘Top Gun’ is celebrating its 40th anniversary and fans in India will get to see Tom Cruise’s young recruit Pete ‘Maverick’ Mitchell one more time on the big screen, starting May 15.

‘Paramount Pictures’ is all set to re-release the iconic 1986 blockbuster ‘Top Gun’ as well as its 2022 follow-up for a special one-week-only theatrical run.

A class of elite, hotshot Navy pilots at the Fighter Weapons School known as Top Gun push their aircraft and each other to the limits as they compete to be the best of the best. Cruise played ‘Maverick’ in the iconic 1986 blockbuster that defined a generation. He followed it up with an equally successful sequel decades later with ‘Top Gun: Maverick’. The third



It featured Val Kilmer, Anthony Edwards, Kelly McGillis, Meg Ryan and Tom Skerritt also appearing in supporting roles

movie in the franchise has already been announced, with Cruise slated to reprise his role.

‘Top Gun: Maverick’ earned over 1.5 billion US dollars at the worldwide box office and was the number 1 movie of 2022 and the highest-grossing film in Paramount Pictures’ history. In ‘Top Gun: Maverick’, after more than 30 years of service as one of the Navy’s top aviators, Pete ‘Maverick’ Mitchell (Cruise) is where he belongs, pushing the envelope as a courageous

test pilot and dodging the advancement in rank that would ground him.

When he finds himself training a detachment of Top Gun graduates for a specialised mission the likes of which no living pilot has ever seen, Maverick encounters Lt. Bradley Bradshaw (Miles Teller), call sign: ‘Rooster’, the son of Maverick’s late friend and Radar Intercept Officer Lt. Nick Bradshaw, aka ‘Goose’.

The original was directed by the late Tony Scott. PFI

Citadel Season 2 to premiere on May 6

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Prime Video’ recently released the action-packed official trailer and announced the premiere date for the return of the high-stakes spy series, ‘Citadel’. All seven episodes will be released on May 6, 2026, exclusively on ‘Prime Video’.

‘Citadel’ is a heart-racing spy thriller following Mason Kane (Richard Madden), Nadia Sinh (Priyanka Chopra Jonas) and Bernard Orlick (Stanley Tucci) - elite operatives of a legendary agency destroyed by ‘Manticore’, a ruthless network backed by the world’s most powerful families. When a terrifying new threat emerges, the three are pulled back into action.

Now, they must recruit an unlikely team of skilled new operatives and launch a globe-spanning mission to stop a conspiracy that could reshape humanity. With blockbuster action, shocking betrayals, and an expanded ensemble of mysterious agents, the stakes have never been higher and anyone could be a friend or foe.

Returning cast mem-



The thrilling spy series stars Richard Madden, Priyanka Chopra Jonas, Stanley Tucci, Jack Reynor and Matt Berry

bers this season include Lesley Manville and Ashleigh Cummings, alongside an expanded ensemble cast featuring Jack Reynor as Hutch, Matt Berry as Franke Sharpe, and Lina El Arabi as Celine. Other notable additions include Merle Dandridge, Gabriel Leone and Rayna Vallandingham.

From ‘Amazon MGM Studios’ and ‘the Russo Brothers’ AGBO, ‘Citadel’ is executive produced by Anthony Russo, Angela Russo-Otstot and Scott Nemes for AGBO, with David Weil serving as showrunner, director and executive producer.

GOVERNOR: THE SILENT SAVIOUR

First poster unveiled on Manoj Bajpayee’s birthday

Producer Vipul Amrutlal Shah unveiled the first poster of his upcoming film ‘Governor: The Silent Saviour’ on Manoj Bajpayee’s 57th birthday. The movie, scheduled for release in theatres on June 12, marks the first collaboration between the National Film Award-winning actor and the producer, known for backing the controversial ‘The Kerala Story’ franchise.

The film is directed by Chinmay Mandlekar

Shah’s banner ‘Sunshine Pictures’ shared the first look from the movie on its official social media pages. “We are a world power today because an unsung hero fought an untold war. ‘GOVERNOR’ releasing in cinemas on 12th June, 2026,” read the caption.

Directed by Chinmay Mandlekar, the first poster features Bajpayee walking down a corridor from behind, suitcase in hand. The tagline on the poster read, “If I fail... India fails.”

A second poster spotlights a solitary green chair with the lines ‘India is on the verge of bank-



ruptcy’ and ‘Yeh sirf kursi nahii... zimmedaari hai’ written on it.

The film will also feature actor Adah Sharma, who played the lead role in Shah’s 2023 production ‘The Kerala Story’. ‘Governor: The Silent Saviour’ is co-produced by Aashin A Shah. The screenplay is written by Suvendu Bhattacharyjee, Saurabh Bharat, Ravi Asrani and Shah. The film features music by Amit Trivedi and lyrics by Javed Akhtar.

Bajpayee, one of Hindi cinema’s most versatile actors, comes into the project on the back of a strong recent run. In 2025, he headlined ‘Inspector Zende’ on ‘Netflix’ and featured in ‘Jugnuma’. PFI

Payal Kapadia named jury president for Cannes Critics Week

All We Imagine As Light’s director Payal Kapadia will be the president of the jury for the 65th Cannes Critics Week, which runs parallel to the main festival and nurtures emerging voices in cinema. Kapadia, who became the first Indian filmmaker to win the Grand Prix award at the Cannes Film Festival in 2024, will lead a panel of international jury members, including Quebecois actor Théodore Pellerin, singer-songwriter Oklou, Ghanaian British producer Ama Ampadu and journalist and director of the Bangkok World Film Festival Donsaron Kovitvanitcha.

The festival sidebar, known as ‘Semaine de la critique’, is organised by the French Syndicate of Cinema Critics. The 65th edi-



tion will run from May 13 to 21. “At a time when independent cinema is being eroded in every country, supporting the first

The 65th edition will run from May 13 to 21

works of filmmakers is almost a resistance to the market forces. Film criticism is one of the key components of the independent and arthouse film ecosystem. The first films are often freer, more daring and more fearless, with an individual voice, and championing them is essential. First films are also fragile and to be nurtured in a section like Critics Week, which helps them blossom amongst already established filmmakers’ work,” Kapadia said.

Kapadia studied at the Film & Television Institute of India, Pune. Her short films ‘Afternoon Clouds’ and ‘And What is the

Summer Saying’ were selected at the Cinéfondation and the Berlinale. Her first feature documentary, ‘A Night of Knowing Nothing’ was selected at the Directors’ Fortnight at Cannes in 2021 and won L’Oeil d’Or for ‘Best Documentary’. ‘All We Imagine As Light’, which documented the lives of two working women in Mumbai, shot Kapadia among the most promising filmmakers across the world with its win at the Cannes Film Festival.

Kapadia will present La Semaine de la Critique Ami Paris Grand Prize for ‘Best Feature Film’, the Louis Roederer Foundation Rising Star Award for ‘Best Actor or Actress’ and the Sony Discovery Prize for ‘Best Short Film’. PFI

Medha Shankr calls herself an ‘OG Laila Majnu fan’

The actress and Avinash Tiwary currently star in ‘Ginny Weds Sunny 2’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

Ginny Weds Sunny 2, a follow-up to the 2020 romantic comedy ‘Ginny Weds Sunny’, is all set to hit theatres today. The film follows two people from different worlds as they navigate life, love and relationships, with their paths crossing and beginning to have an impact on each other. Medha Shankr and Avinash Tiwary, who star in the film, recently spoke with ‘IMDb’ about their film, their take on marriage and working together.

Talking about what drew them to the film, Avinash shared, “I think it’s the script that made me really, really jump with joy. It felt like this is one film my entire family would absolutely sit down and watch and thoroughly enjoy. That was one thing that really touched me.”

Medha, on the other hand, shared, “I think the script is damn fun. Like, I haven’t laughed like that while reading a script in a very long time. So, I was sold on that.”

When asked what their film says

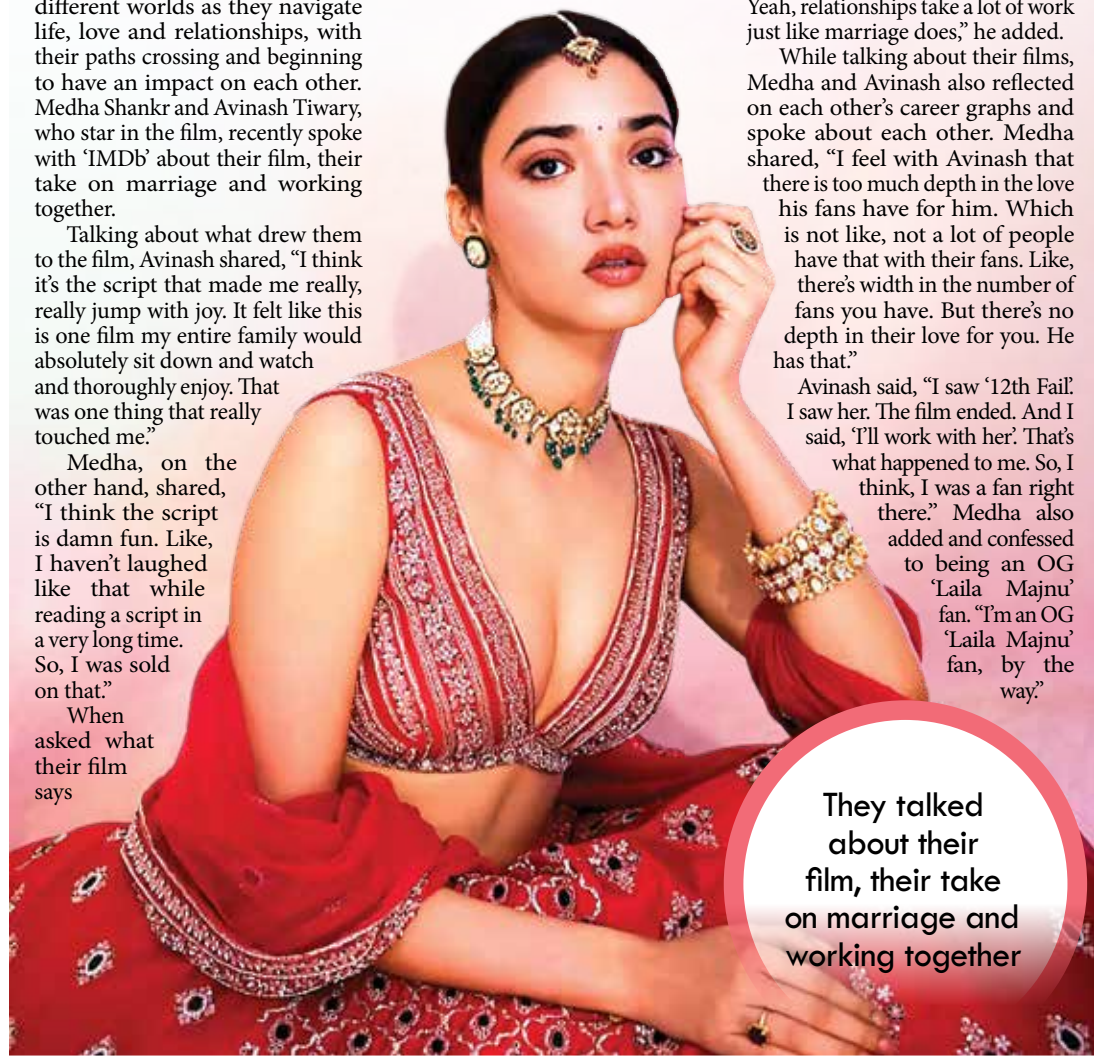
about modern relationships, both the actors admitted that ‘they’re difficult’. Avinash shared, “I’ll give you a stat I read somewhere that the marriage percentage has fallen by almost 28 per cent in this country, which was absolutely known for cele-

brating weddings and stuff like that. It’s a worthy thing to think about.”

“Our film kind of touches upon it. And then also the fact that eventually love triumphs over all the rationalisations that we may have. This is what I felt about the film. Yeah, relationships take a lot of work just like marriage does,” he added.

While talking about their films, Medha and Avinash also reflected on each other’s career graphs and spoke about each other. Medha shared, “I feel with Avinash that there is too much depth in the love his fans have for him. Which is not like, not a lot of people have that with their fans. Like, there’s width in the number of fans you have. But there’s no depth in their love for you. He has that.”

Avinash said, “I saw ‘12th Fail’. I saw her. The film ended. And I said, ‘I’ll work with her’. That’s what happened to me. So, I think, I was a fan right there.” Medha also added and confessed to being an OG ‘Laila Majnu’ fan. “I’m an OG ‘Laila Majnu’ fan, by the way.”



They talked about their film, their take on marriage and working together